From: Yardeni QuickTakes <yardeni-research@ghost.io>
Subject: Is AI Useless?
Date: 15 minutes ago

Is AI Useless?

YARDENI QUICKTAKES

Is AI Useless?

By Ed Yardeni & Elias Griepentrog • 26 Oct 2026

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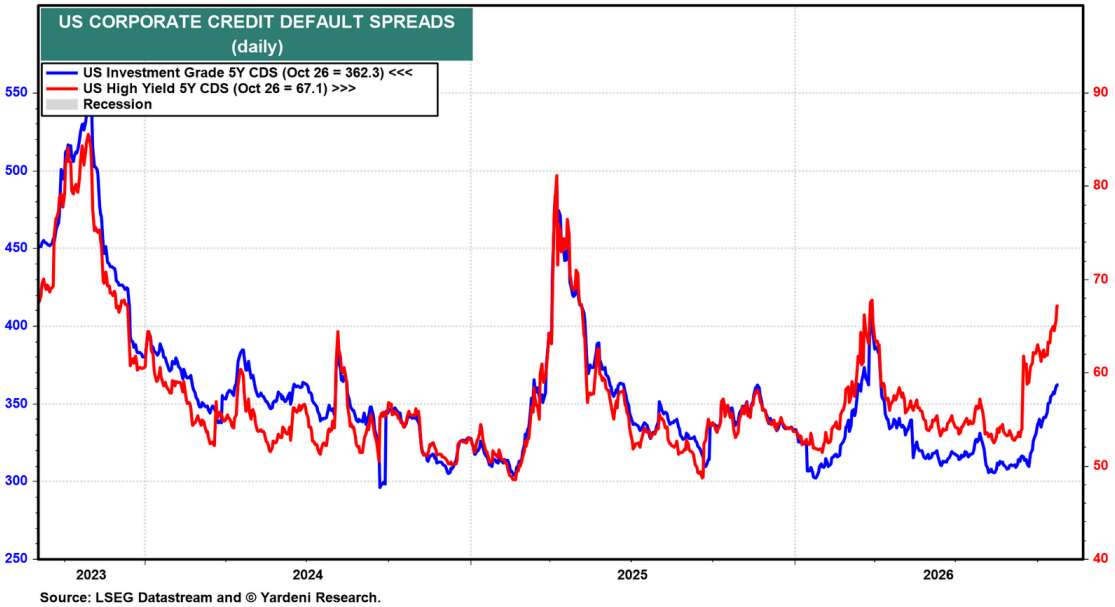
I. AI's Toxic Financial Trifecta

Recent AI jitters have been fueled by a potentially toxic trifecta of financial constraints: elevated borrowing costs, uncertain investment returns, and concerns about whether sufficient capital exists to finance everyone's ambitious AI spending plans. Consider the following:

(1) Elevated borrowing costs. The 10-year Treasury yield is hovering near the upper end of its "old normal" range of 4.0%-5.0% (chart). That puts it at the highest level since 2007. Overall, credit spreads (the extra

yield paid over equivalent US Treasuries, such as the 10-year note) have *not* blown out uniformly across the board. Instead, the market has bifurcated sharply between the pristine balance sheets of mega-cap tech companies and the leveraged balance sheets of pure-play infrastructure/data center borrowers.

Yields on AI debt have not broadly surged relative to Treasuries for the dominant Big Tech issuers, whose balance sheets continue to be treated virtually like "proxy sovereigns." However, the credit market is increasingly imposing credit discipline, demanding significantly higher risk premiums and spreads from the leveraged second- and third-tier infrastructure borrowers that are building out the physical plumbing of AI. Increased concerns about the credit quality of AI borrowers have been reflected in widening credit default spreads (chart).

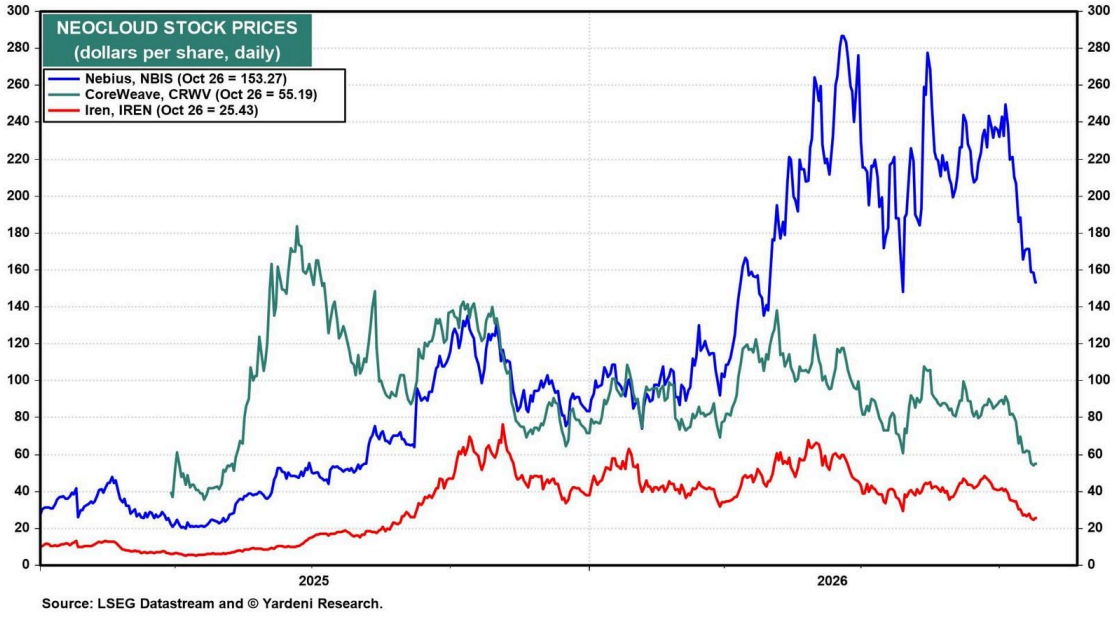


(2) Uncertain returns. Gartner estimates that AI data center operators must generate $8.5 trillion in cumulative revenues through 2030 to cover their investments and associated financing costs and still achieve a 12% return on invested capital. Yet Gartner projects no more than $3.6 trillion in attributable AI revenues over that period. In our view, if the numbers don't add up, the pace of the AI buildout will slow. That wouldn’t be a calamity.

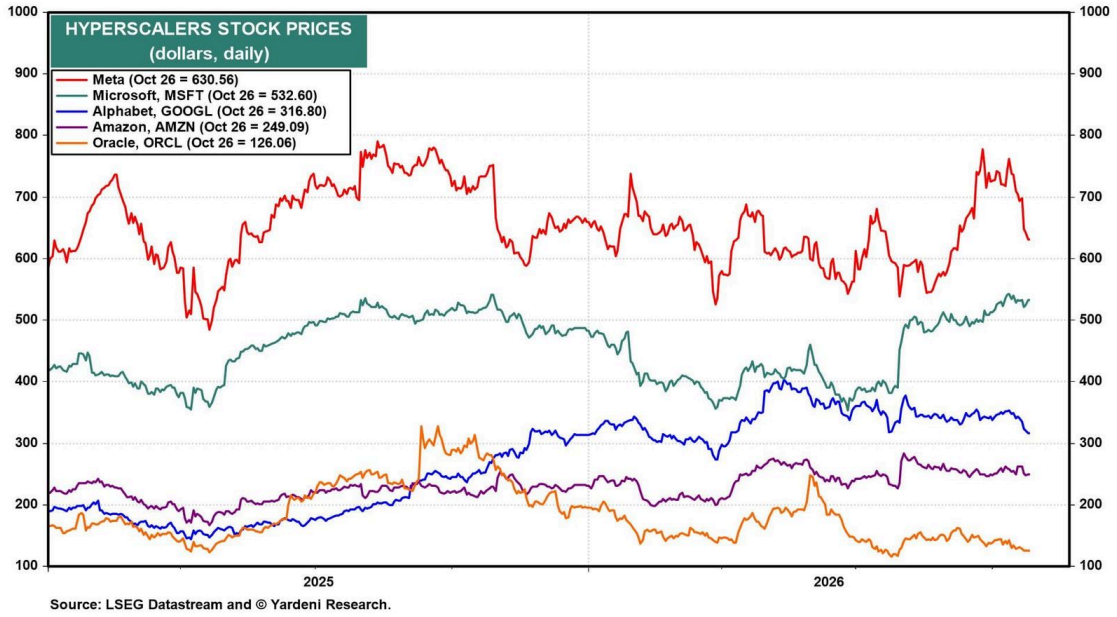
(3) Increasingly constrained capital. Meta's Q3 earnings report intensified concerns about capital availability. Despite strong revenue growth, the company reported negative free cash flow for the first time since 2012 and announced new non-voting shares to facilitate fundraising, warning of an "increasingly difficult fundraising environment." Today, Meta unveiled plans to raise up to $95 billion through equity offerings.

Meanwhile, Broadcom CEO Hock Tan identified capital as potentially the biggest constraint on AI development. BlackRock CEO Larry Fink described competition for capital as the fiercest of his career, while Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang observed that neocloud demand is "off the charts," but capital is scarce.

Today, Elon Musk warned that more than 200 specialized AI cloud providers (i.e., neoclouds) are headed for a wave of "guppy-level death and consolidation." Musk stated that debt markets have "almost entirely shut off access to money for any company that doesn't have substantial revenue independent of AI data centers." In recent weeks, the neocloud providers’ stock prices have tumbled (chart).



On balance, hyperscalers' stock prices have held up relatively well (chart).



II. Will AI Pay Off?

Demand for compute nevertheless remains extraordinary. Global spending on cloud infrastructure services surged 43% y/y to $143 billion in Q2, its fastest growth in eight years. But how sustainable is that demand growth? Ultimately, the marginal economic benefits derived from AI must justify the marginal cost of supplying the necessary compute.

We believe AI is already generating tangible economic benefits, even if they have yet to become clearly visible in aggregate macroeconomic statistics. Consider the following:

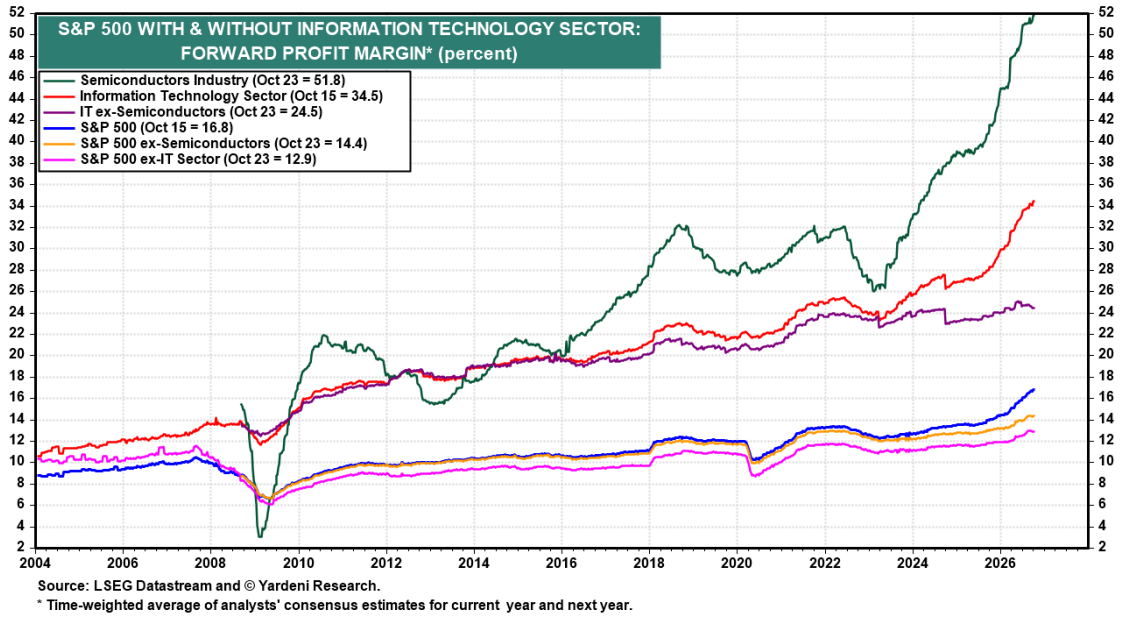
(1) Anthropic's S-1. Anthropic's IPO filing today offered five revealing takeaways: First, revenues soared from $1.2 billion in H1-2025 to $16.3 billion in H1-2026. Second, operating losses narrowed from $2.1 billion to $693 million, with Q2 marking the company's first quarterly operating profit of $974 million. Third, revenue per dollar of compute expense surged 5.2-fold to $2.08 between Q1-2025 and Q2-2026. Fourth, Anthropic held $131.7 billion in cash and short-term investments as of June, alongside $3.9 billion in H1 operating cash flow. Fifth, its enterprise footprint expanded rapidly, with more than 11,900 customers spending at least $100,000 annually as of September, up from roughly 950 a year earlier.

(2) Corporate America's emerging AI payoffs. An August Janus Henderson study of 109 companies found that 69% reported some margin

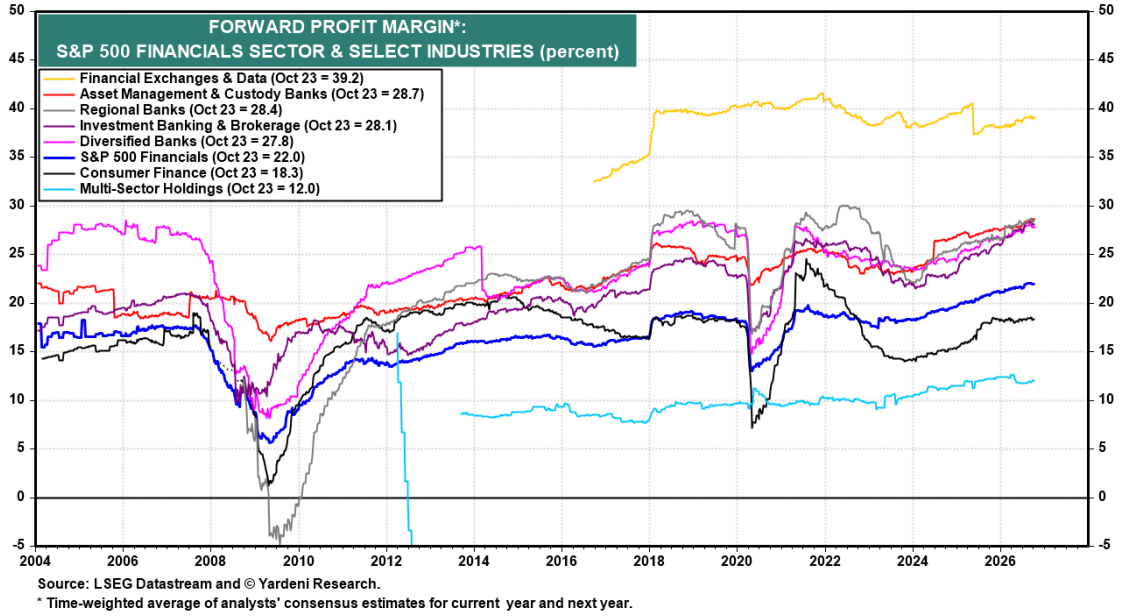
improvement associated with productivity gains and AI-related cost reductions. Among the examples cited, Shell reported $400 million in annual savings and a 45% reduction in unplanned downtime; Freeport-McMoRan increased mill throughput 10% while cutting unit costs by up to 15%; inventories at one Hitachi facility fell 50% and lead times shortened by 77%; and IBM reported $4.5 billion in AI-related savings in 2025.

Last Thursday, Barclays announced plans to eliminate approximately 5,000 jobs, or 5% of its workforce, as AI and broader technological modernization improve efficiency. PayPal is targeting $1.5 billion in annualized savings, partly through AI adoption.

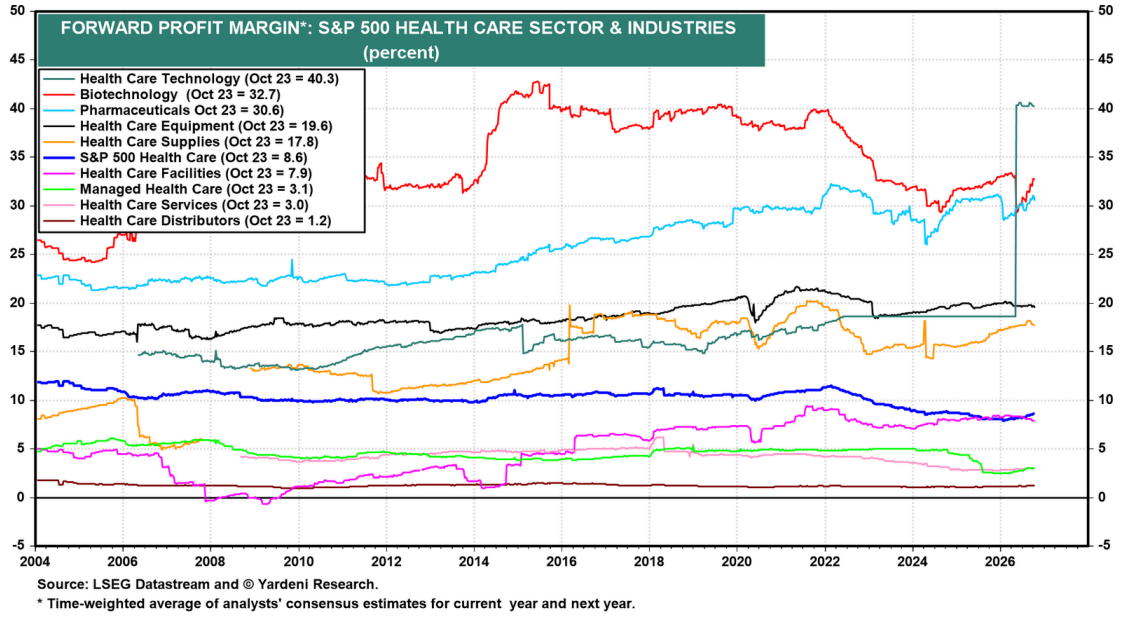
(3) Corporate profit margins. Corporate America is becoming more profitable. The forward profit margin of the S&P 500 excluding its Information Technology sector has been climbing this year, reaching 12.9% in October (chart). Excluding just the Semiconductors industry, the forward profit margin rose to a record 14.4%. The forward profit margin in Semiconductors rose to a record 51.8% in the week of October 23. But most of the industry's margin expansion since 2024 is attributable to capacity constraints pushing prices higher.



A closer look reveals encouraging trends in industries where AI applications could be particularly beneficial. Forward profit margins have expanded in numerous financial industries where AI offers significant opportunities for automation (chart).



Health Care stands to benefit from AI applications that can streamline clinical workflows and administrative processes (chart).



(4) Bottom line. We aren't yet seeing significant AI-driven profit margin expansion across the economy, but anecdotal evidence of AI-related productivity gains is mounting. We expect AI adoption to become increasingly widespread across industries, eventually delivering substantial productivity growth and boosting corporate profit margins. AI's economic payoff may not yet be obvious in aggregate statistics, but that doesn't mean it isn't already materializing.

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US SECTORS CALL: Communication Services, Materials & Energy

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US SECTORS CALL: Communication Services, Materials & Energy

By Ed Yardeni & Toby Hearst • 25 Oct 2026

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Photo by Noah Klassen / Unsplash

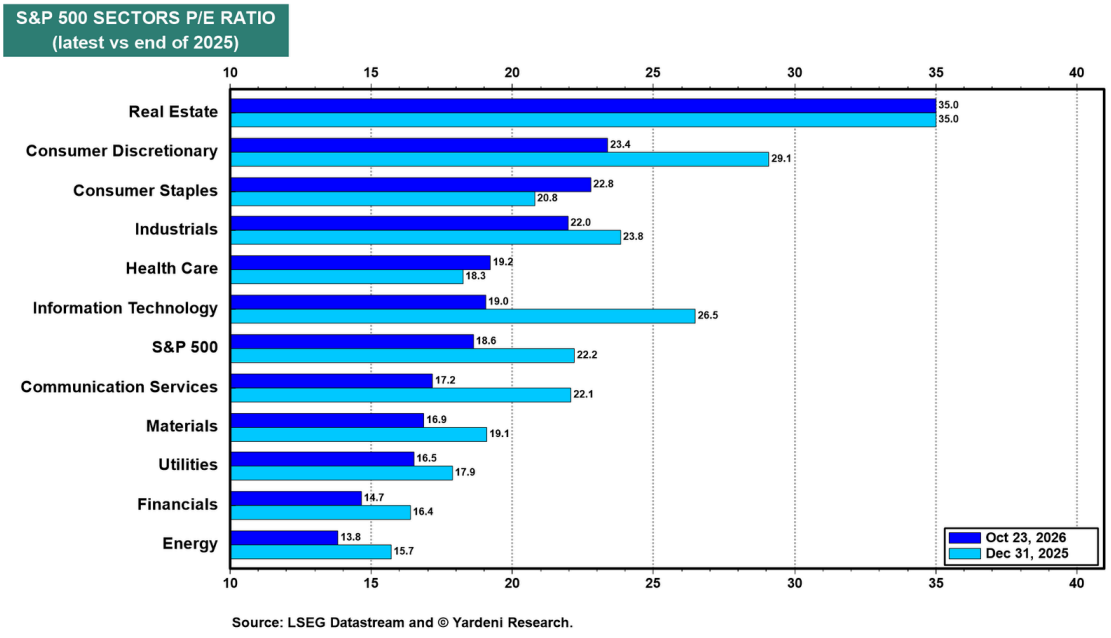
YRI S&P 500 SECTORS WEIGHTING RECOMMENDATIONS* (Oct 23, 2026)				
S&P 500 Sectors	Weight Recommendation	Week-to-Date	Month-to-Date	Year-to-Date
S&P 500		-0.5	-0.4	11.4
Communication Services	MW	-6.2	-7.3	-3.7
Consumer Discretionary	UW	0.5	2.9	-3.6
Consumer Staples	UW	0.5	9.6	14.1
Energy	OW	1.6	12.8	55.1
Financials	OW	0.7	4.7	2.0
Health Care	OW	1.5	6.4	15.7
Industrials	OW	-1.9	-1.4	6.1
Information Technology	MW	-0.3	-5.1	21.3
Materials	OW	-0.1	4.4	12.3
Real Estate	UW	0.9	3.6	6.4
Utilities	MW	0.8	7.9	-0.3

Source: LSEG Datastreamand © Yardeni Research.

* OW = overweight, MW = market weight, and UW = underweight.

Investors spent the week worrying about an AI bubble. The S&P 500 slipped by 0.5%, led by a 6.2% drop in Communication Services (MW), which was the worst-performing S&P 500 sector (table). Yet, Information Technology fell just 0.3%. Energy (OW) led the winning sectors with a 1.6% gain, followed by Health Care (OW), up 1.5%.

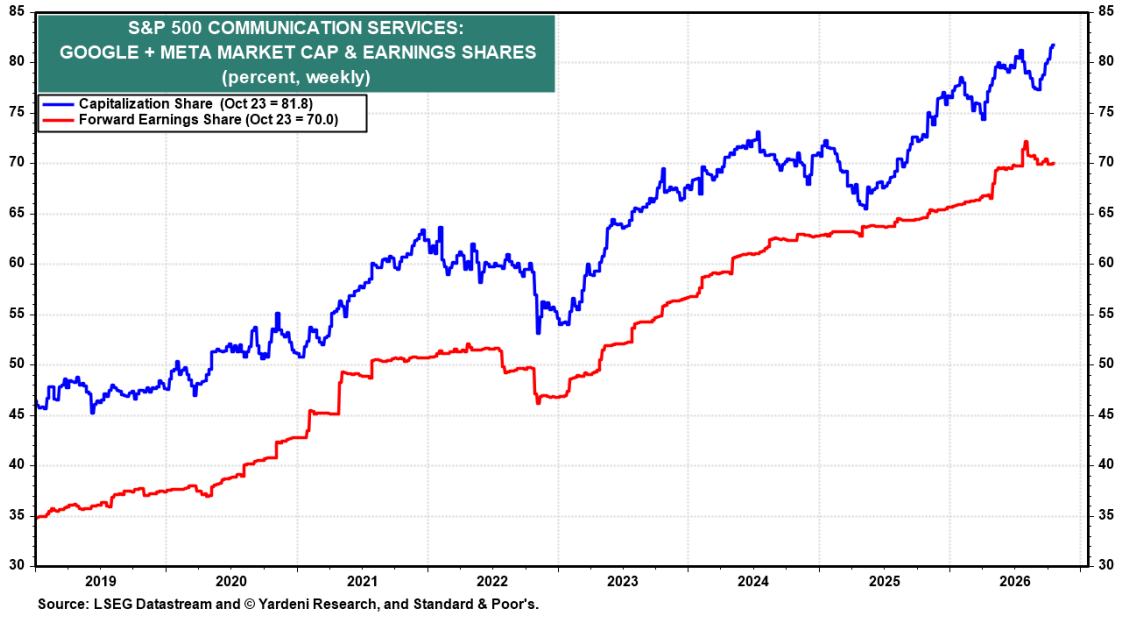
Bubbles inflate valuation multiples. This year, multiples have contracted. The S&P 500's forward P/E has fallen to 18.6 from 22.2 at the end of 2025 (chart). Information Technology's forward P/E is down to 19.0 from 26.5. Stocks have gotten cheaper this year as earnings growth outpaced stock price gains.



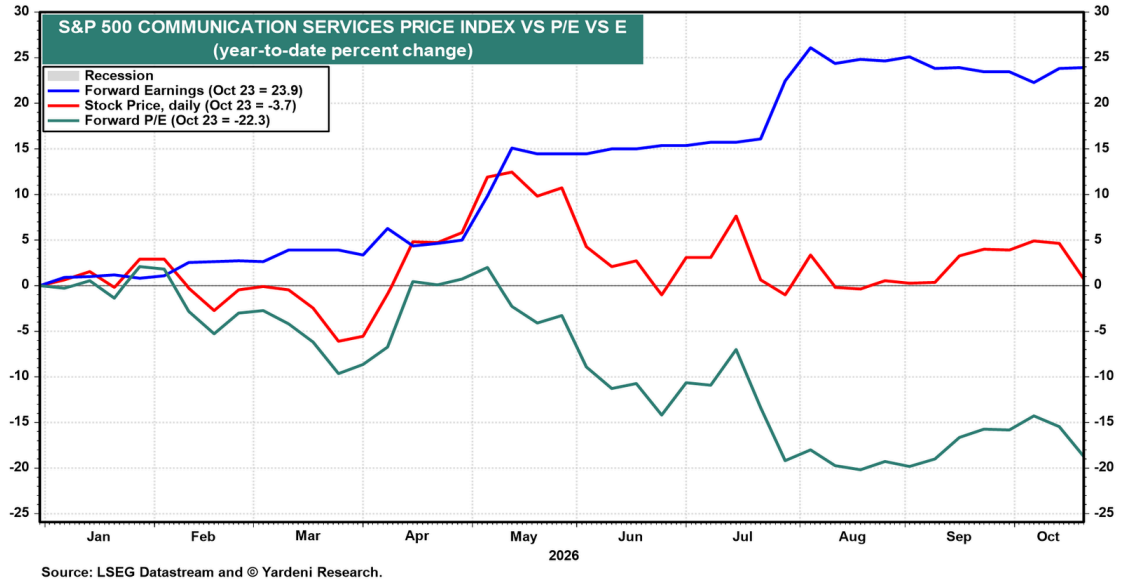
Source: LSEG Datastream and © Yardeni Research.

Here's more on the Communication Services, Materials, and Energy sectors:

(1) Communication Services. Meta's Q3 report last Wednesday hit the sector hard. Its free cash flow turned negative for the first time since its 2012 IPO, and it raised its 2026 capex guidance floor to $135 billion. Its shares fell 7.0% and Interactive Media & Services fell 4.3% on Thursday, closing down 7.0% for the week. Alphabet and Meta dominate the sector. Together they account for 81.8% of its market cap and 70.0% of its forward earnings (chart).

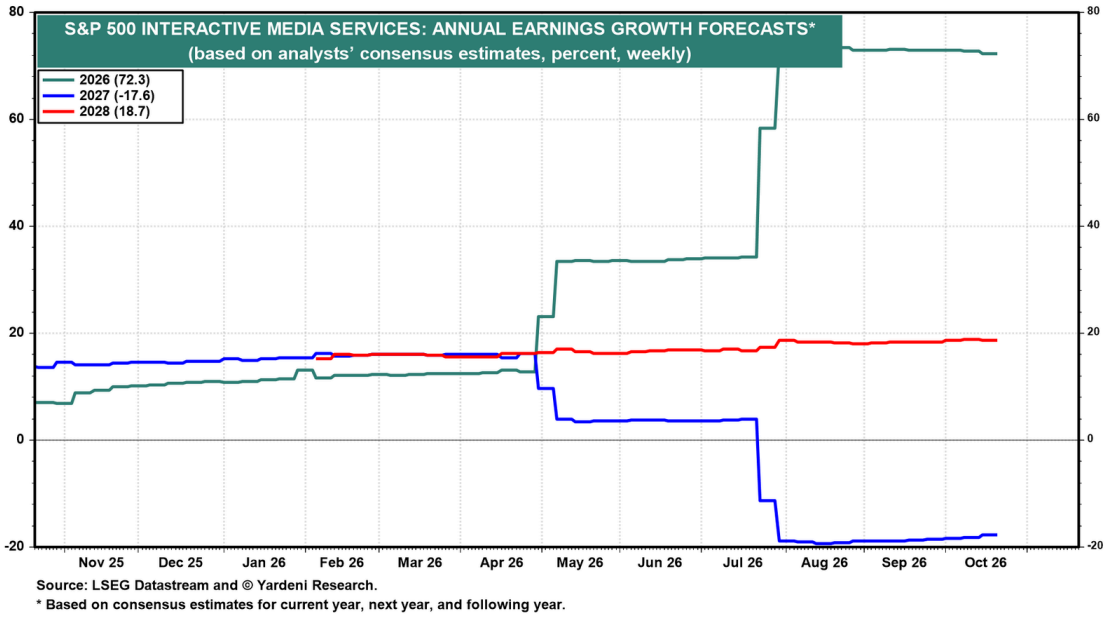


The sector's forward earnings is up 23.9% ytd, while its stock price index is down 2.3% (chart). Its forward P/E has dropped to 17.2 from 22.1 at the start of the year. That puts it below the S&P 500's 18.6.



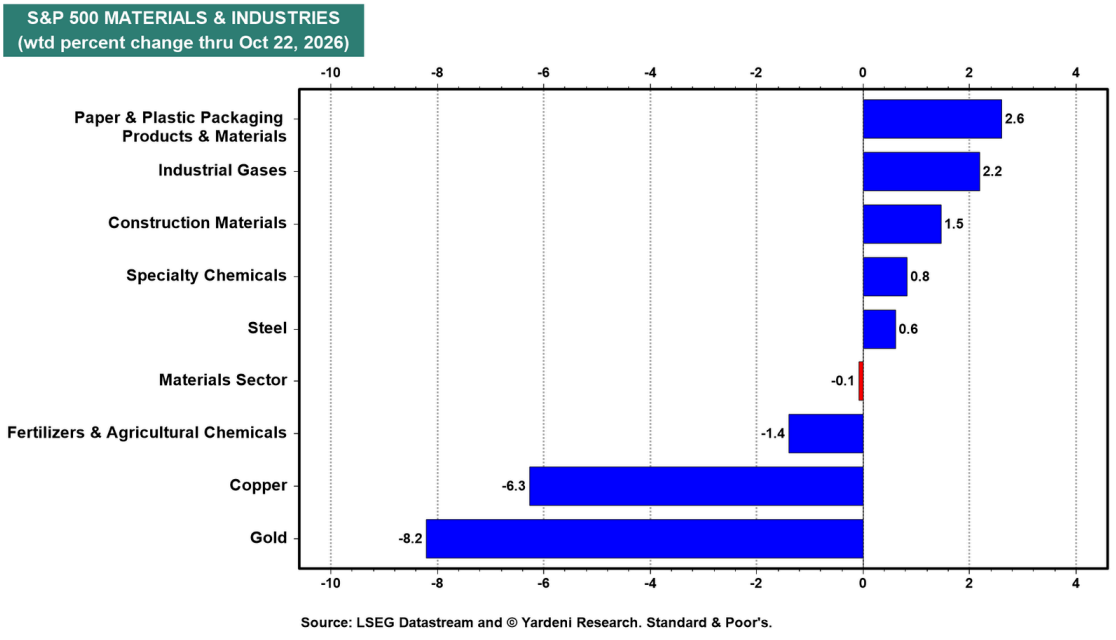
Analysts expect earnings at Interactive Media & Services, the sector's largest industry, to rise 72.3% this year, then fall 17.6% in 2027 (chart). Yet they expect its revenues to grow 25.0% and 22.8% over the same two

years. Unrealized gains on Alphabet's stakes in private AI companies, including Anthropic, inflated this year's earnings.



The de-rating isn't limited to AI. Netflix, which accounts for more than half of Movies & Entertainment's market cap, reported Q3 results on Tuesday. It cut its ad revenue outlook and guided Q4 earnings below expectations. Its stock is now down 51% from its mid-2025 record high.

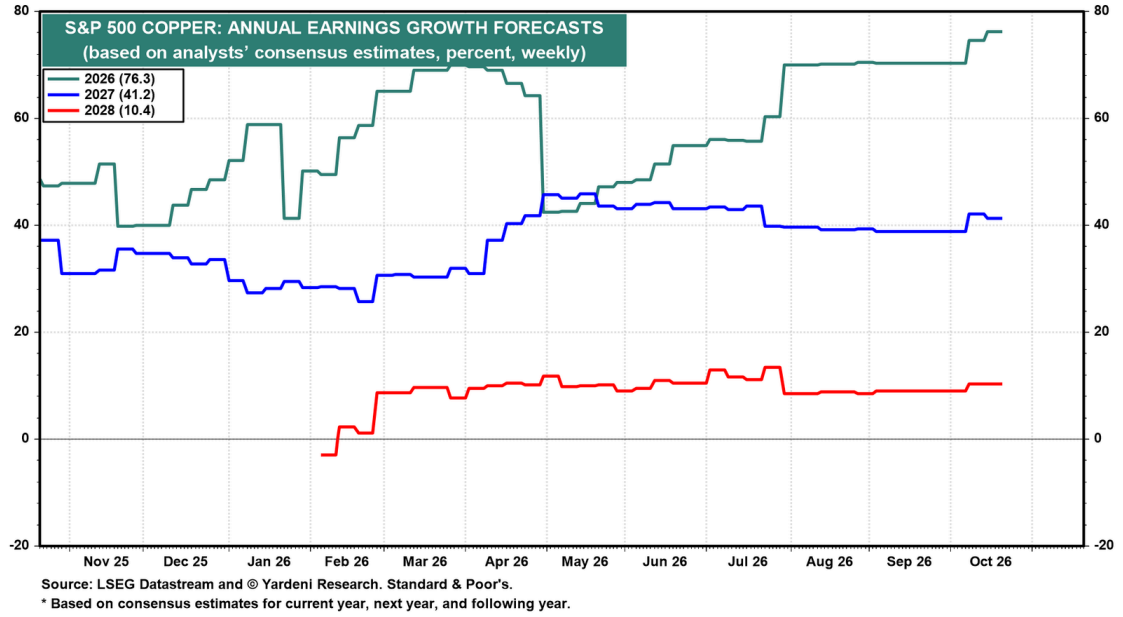
(2) Materials. Materials slipped 0.1% this week. Gold and Copper were the sector's worst-performing industries, down 8.2% and 6.3% (chart). Copper stocks fell along with the AI trade on Thursday.



Copper futures also fell slightly last week, ending at $6.48 per pound. The AI selloff hit industrial metals on Thursday, but copper rebounded on Friday. Rising inventories also weighed on the red metal last week.

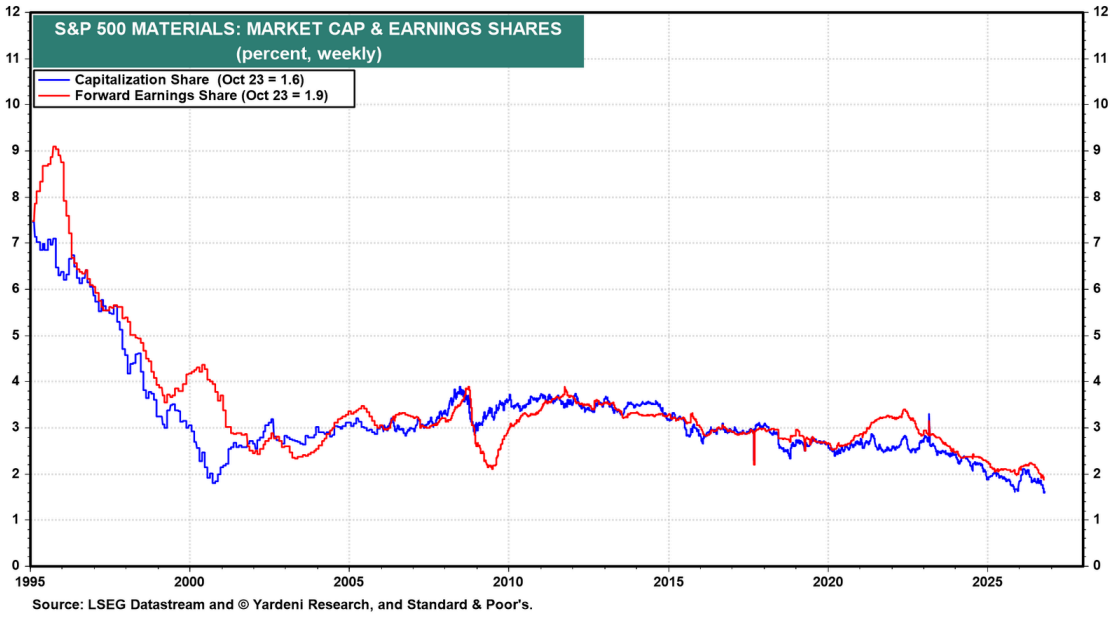
Copper flowed back into London Metal Exchange warehouses, where inventories rose to their highest since July. Traders spent the year shipping copper to the US ahead of potential tariffs. The US price premium that drove those flows has turned into a discount. Copper remains near the top of an uptrend channel that began in 2016 (chart).

Forecasts have copper earnings rising 76.3% this year and 41.2% in 2027. The forward profit margin is up to 17.1%, the highest since 2022, yet the forward P/E has dropped to 16.4. The selloff hit stock prices, not earnings estimates.

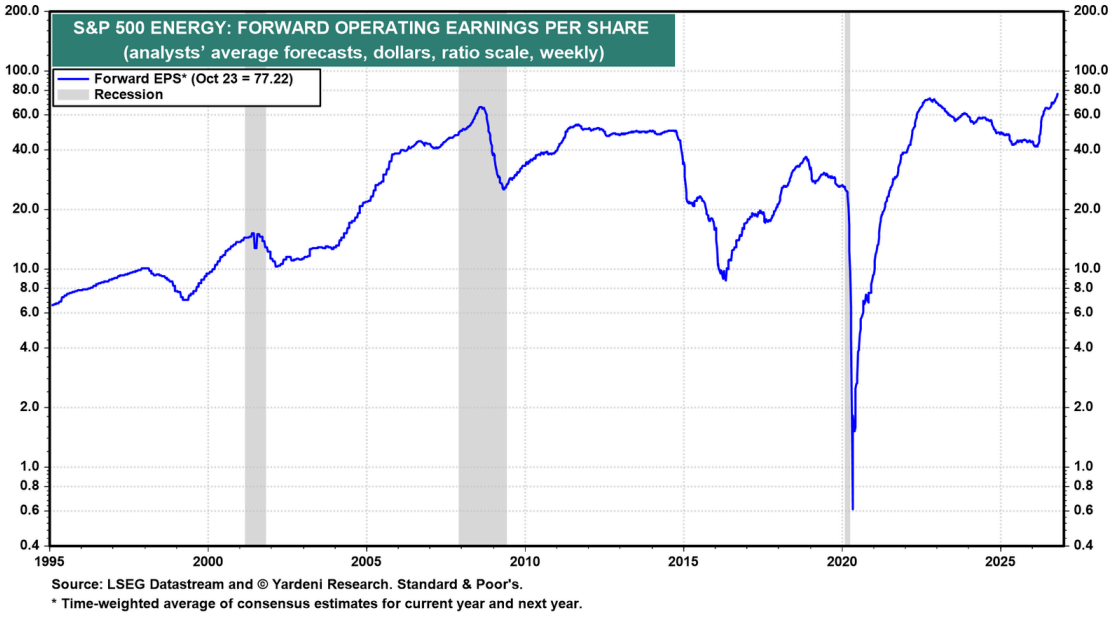


Analysts expect Materials earnings to rise 40.2% this year and 11.8% in 2027. Materials accounts for just 1.9% of S&P 500 forward earnings and only 1.6% of its market cap, the smallest share in over 30 years (chart).

We remain overweight. Materials offers rising earnings at a shrinking multiple.

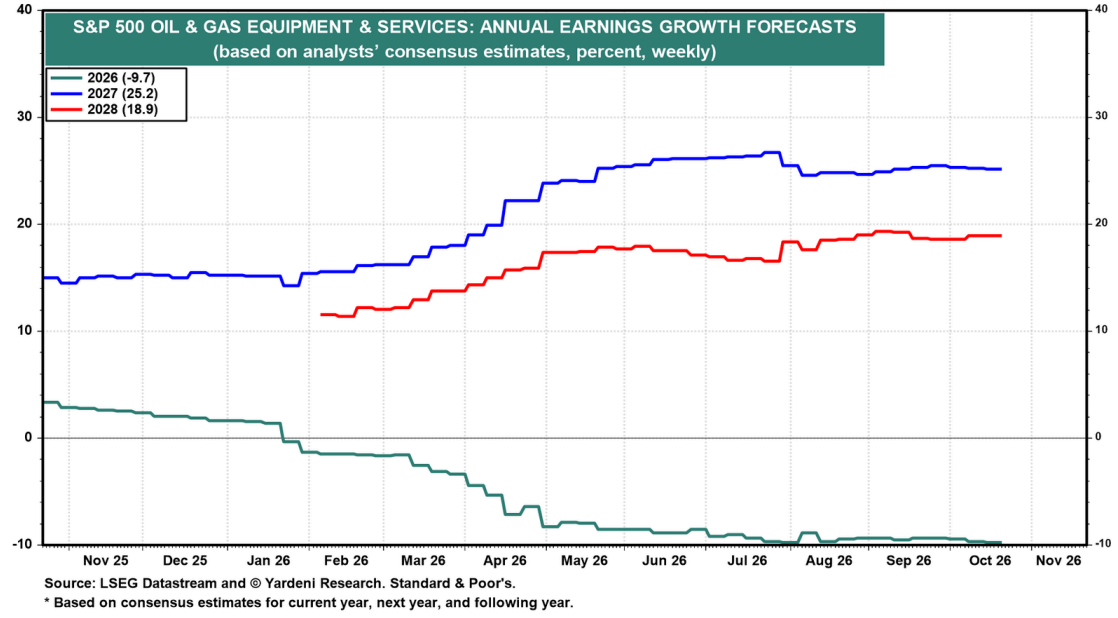


(3) Energy. Energy is up 55.1% ytd, the best-performing sector. Its forward earnings has risen even faster, up 76.5% ytd to a record high (chart). Energy still has the lowest forward P/E of the 11 sectors, at 13.8, down from 15.7 at the start of the year.



Analysts see 2026 as the peak. They expect sector earnings to rise 101.9% this year, then fall 8.0% in 2027. Refining & Marketing shows this most clearly. Its forward profit margin has soared to a record 9.0% (chart). Its forward P/E is 9.0, with earnings forecast to fall 11.0% in 2027.

Oil & Gas Equipment & Services is the exception. Analysts expect its earnings to fall 9.7% this year, then rise 25.2% in 2027 and 18.9% in 2028 (chart).



Consensus estimates assume the oil premium fades, and we expect it will eventually. Renewed strikes on Iran after the midterms, which the US and Israel reportedly have planned, would challenge the fading-premium assumption. At only 3.7% of the S&P 500's market cap and a forward P/E of 13.8, Energy is a cheap hedge against more geopolitical turmoil.

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GLOBAL MARKETS CALL: Bond Yields Ease

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GLOBAL MARKETS CALL: Bond Yields Ease

By Ed Yardeni & Toby Hearst • 25 Oct 2026

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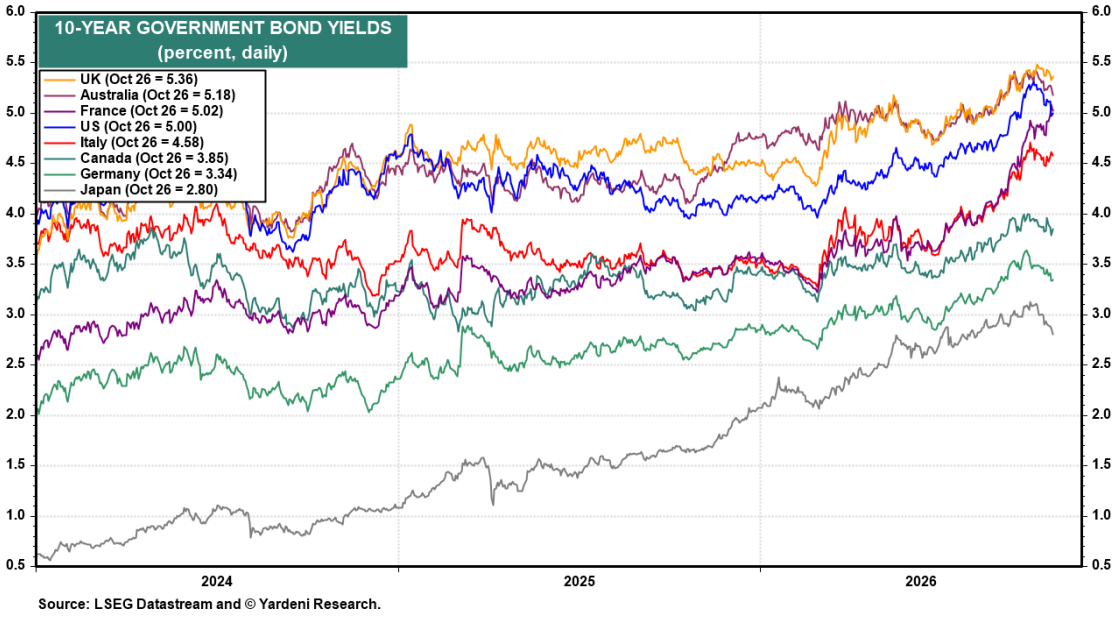
Photo by Jeffrey Hamilton / Unsplash

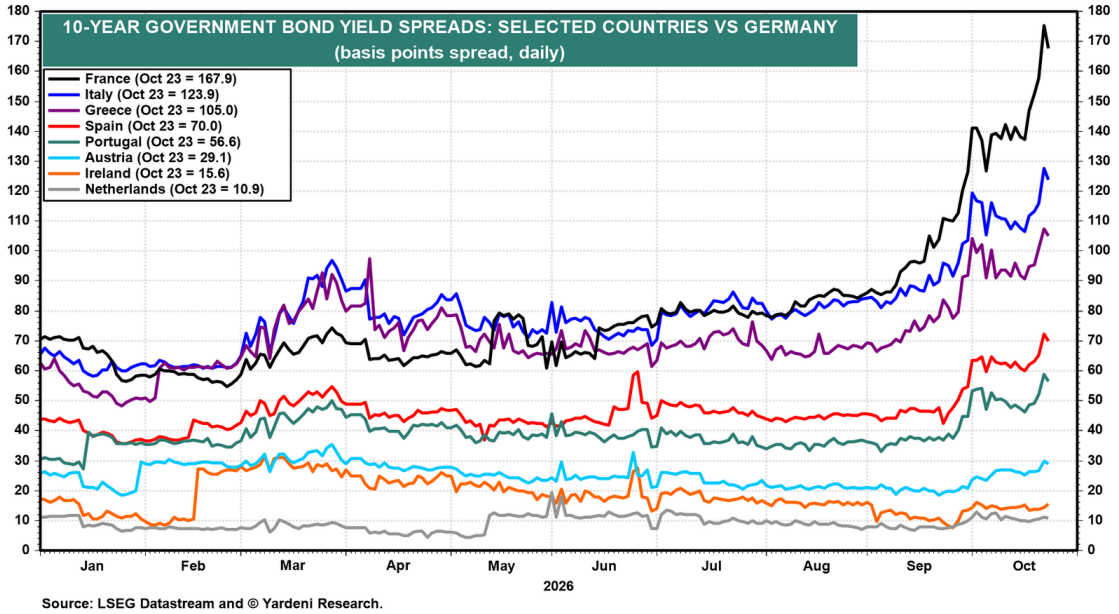
Bond yields eased in most major markets last week, but France was the glaring exception. In stocks, the global AI selloff kept hitting the equities markets that had gained the most this year, putting the US back ahead of the All Country World ex-US ytd. That supports our downgrade last week of Go Global to market weight, though the fundamental case for overseas stocks remains strong. Here's more:

I. Global Bonds

Yields fell in five of the eight major bond markets we track (chart). The US 10-year Treasury yield fell to 5.00%. France's yield jumped 24bps to 5.02%, slightly surpassing the US's. Yields also fell in the UK, Australia, Germany, and Japan.



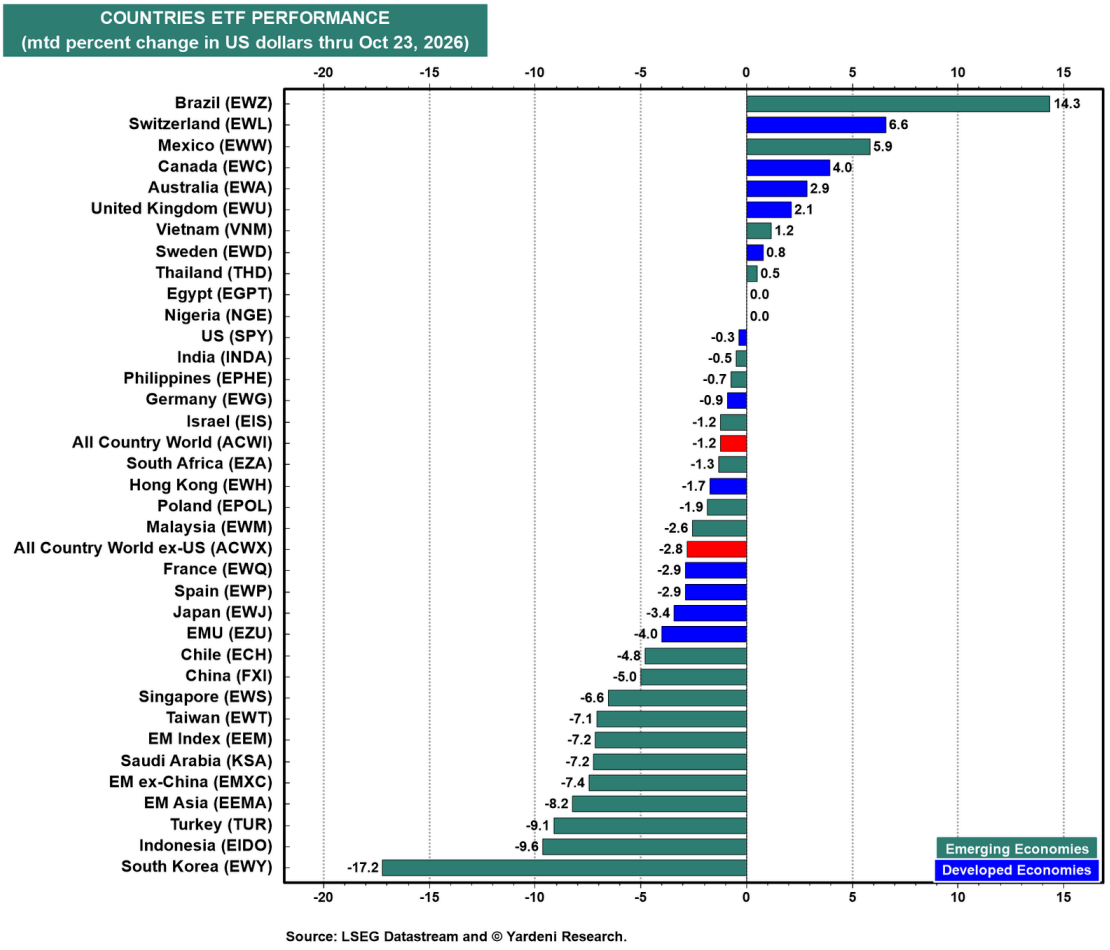
The spread between French and German 10-year yields widened 31bps last week to 167.9bps (chart). Last week, we wrote that contagion from France had eased for now. It's back. Italy's spread widened to 123.9bps from 106.6bps. Greece's widened to 105.0bps from 90.8bps. Italy's 10-year bond now yields 44bps less than France's.



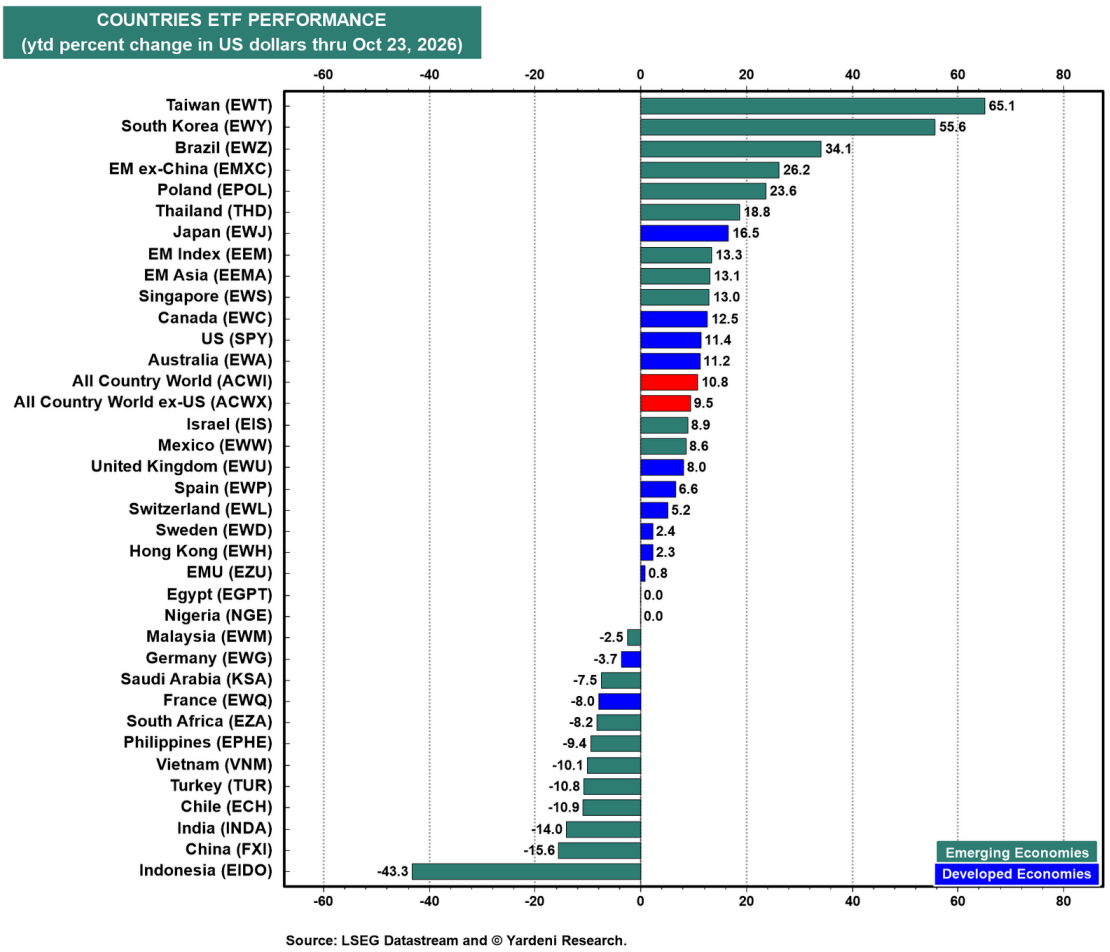
II. Global Stocks

Brazil remains at the top of the country ETF rankings mtd, up 14.3% in dollars (chart). South Korea remains at the bottom, down 17.2%. The US

is down just 0.3%, while the All Country World ex-US ETF is down 2.8%.



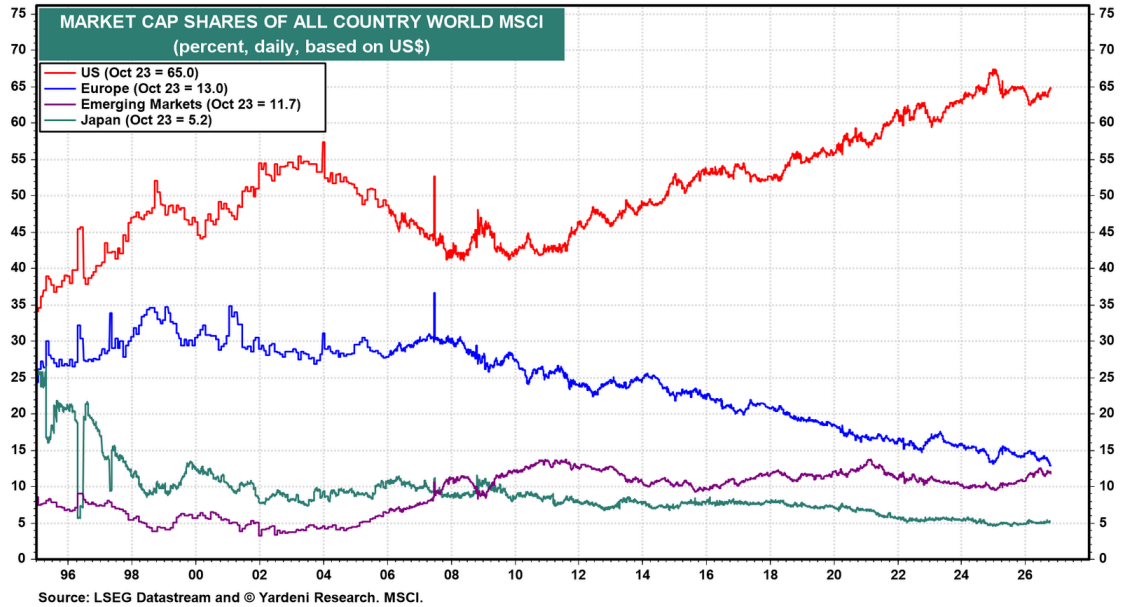
Go Global no longer leads Stay Home this year. The US ETF is up 11.4% ytd, ahead of the All Country World ex-US ETF's 9.5% (chart). Taiwan (65.1%) and South Korea (55.6%) still top the ytd rankings, followed by Brazil (34.1%). China (-15.6%) and Indonesia (-43.3%) are at the bottom.



Source: LSEG Datastream and © Yardeni Research.

III. Global Earnings & Valuations

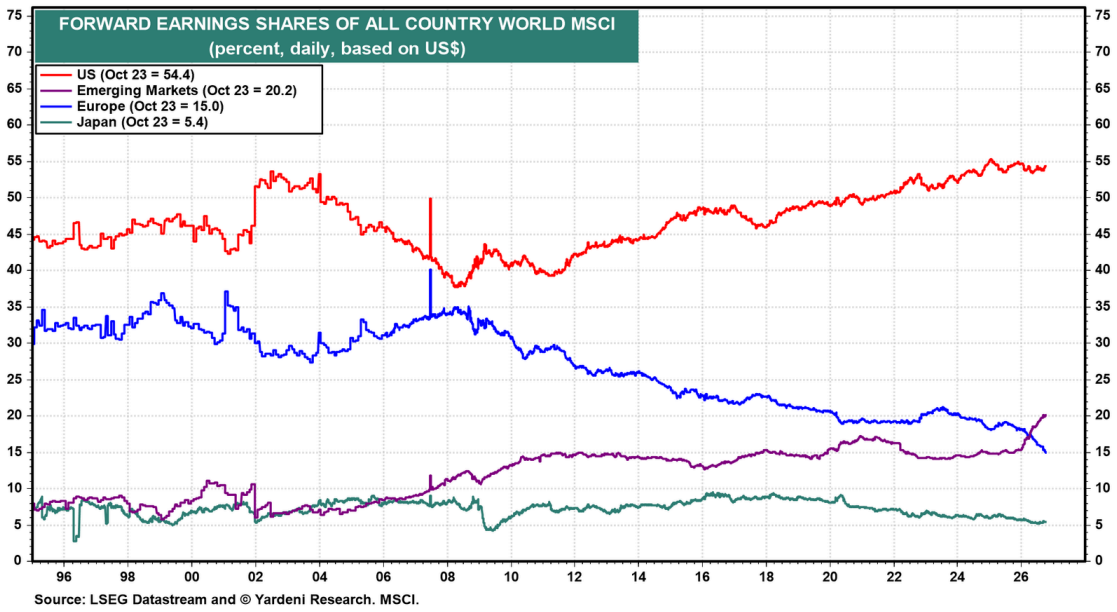
The US MSCI's share of the All Country World MSCI's market cap has edged up to 65.0% (chart). The Emerging Markets (EM) MSCI's share slipped to 11.7% from 12.1% last week.



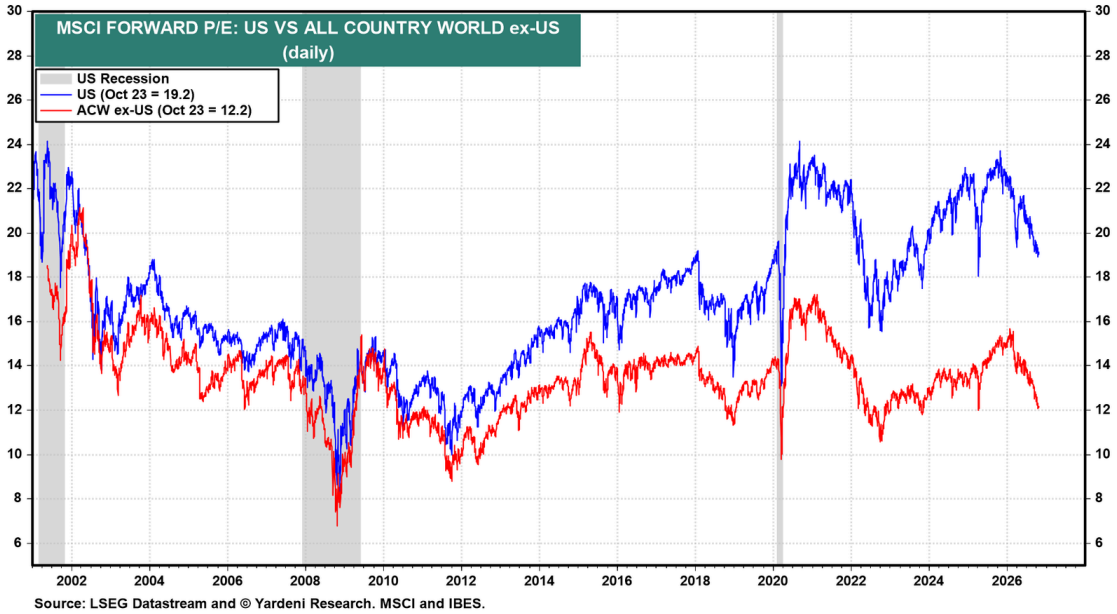
Source: LSEG Datastream and © Yardeni Research. MSCI.

Yet the EM MSCI now accounts for 20.2% of the All Country World MSCI's forward earnings (chart). That's more than Europe's 15.0%. It's the first

time that EM has overtaken Europe since the data began in 1995. The US accounts for 54.4% of forward earnings, well below its market-cap share.



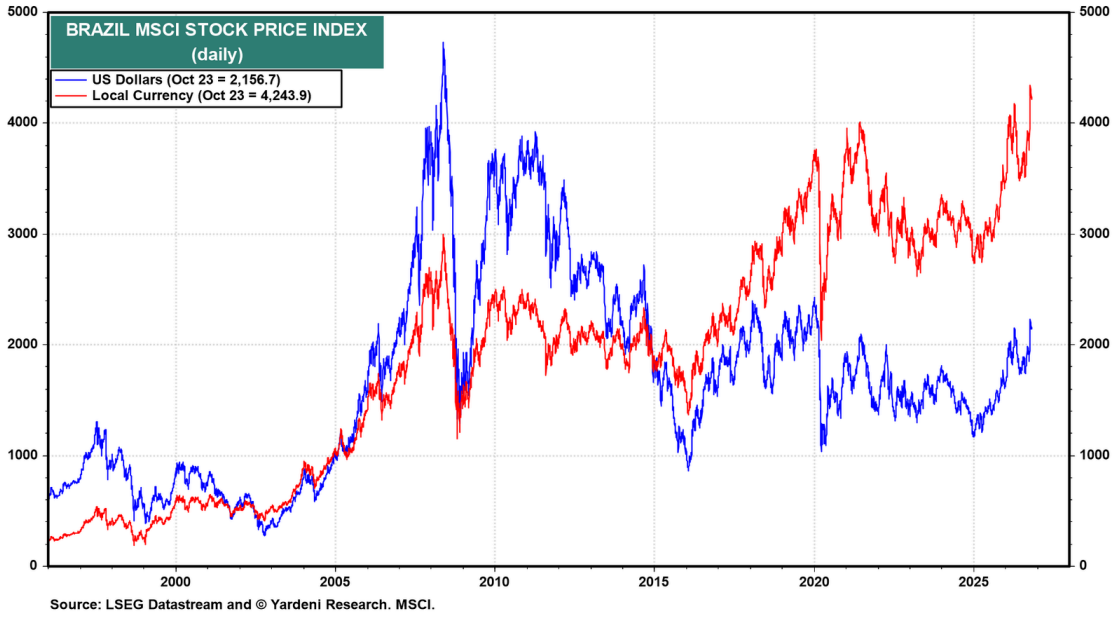
That mismatch shows up in valuations. The US MSCI's forward P/E is 19.2 versus 12.2 for the All Country World ex-US (chart). The ex-US multiple has dropped from 15.7 in January even as its forward earnings soared. The EM MSCI trades at just 9.0.



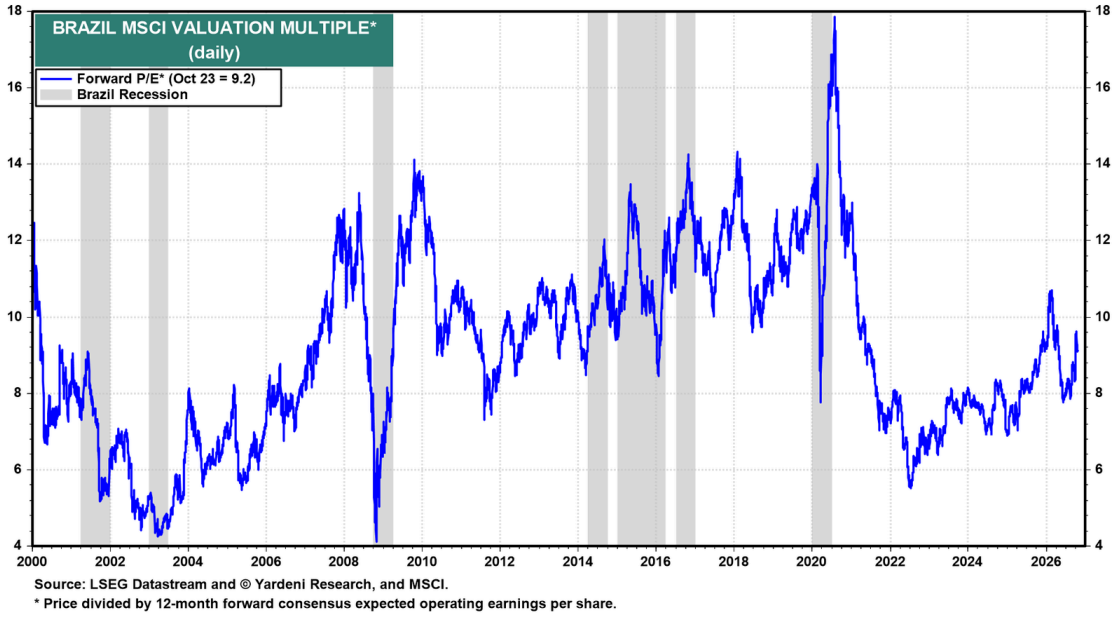
IV. In Focus

(1) Brazil. Brazil's MSCI stock price index is up 22.2% ytd in local currency and 31.0% in dollars (chart). The real has gained 8.0% against the dollar this year. In dollar terms, the index remains less than half its 2008 peak. Stocks rallied after Senator Flávio Bolsonaro took a surprise lead in the October 4 first round. He held a narrow edge in the final polls

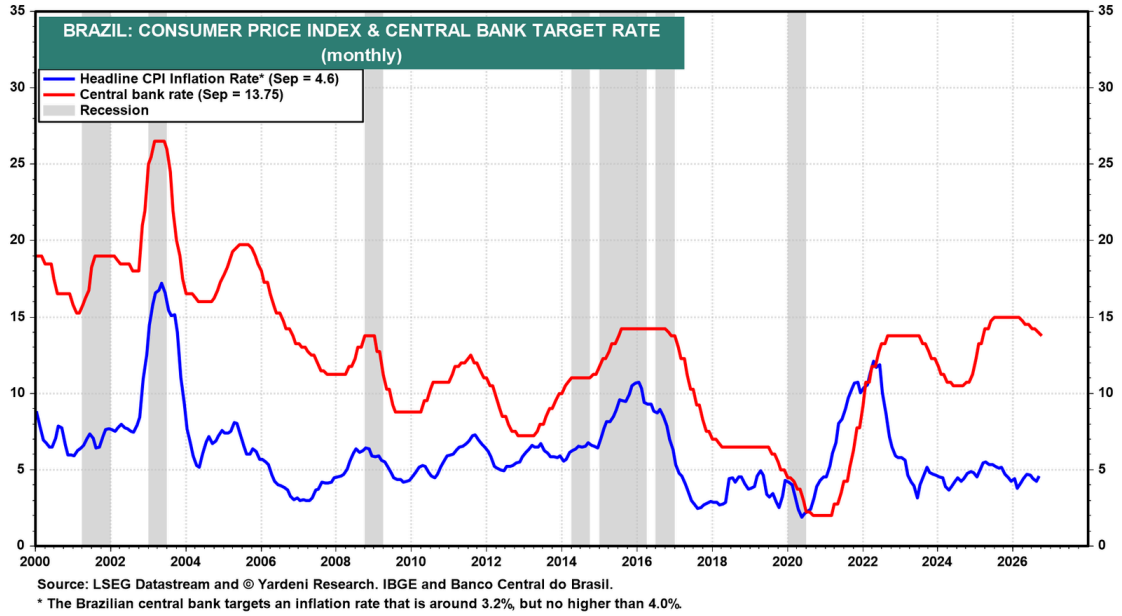
before the October 25 runoff against President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva. A Bloomberg poll released on October 19 gave Bolsonaro 51.1% of valid votes against 48.9% for Lula.



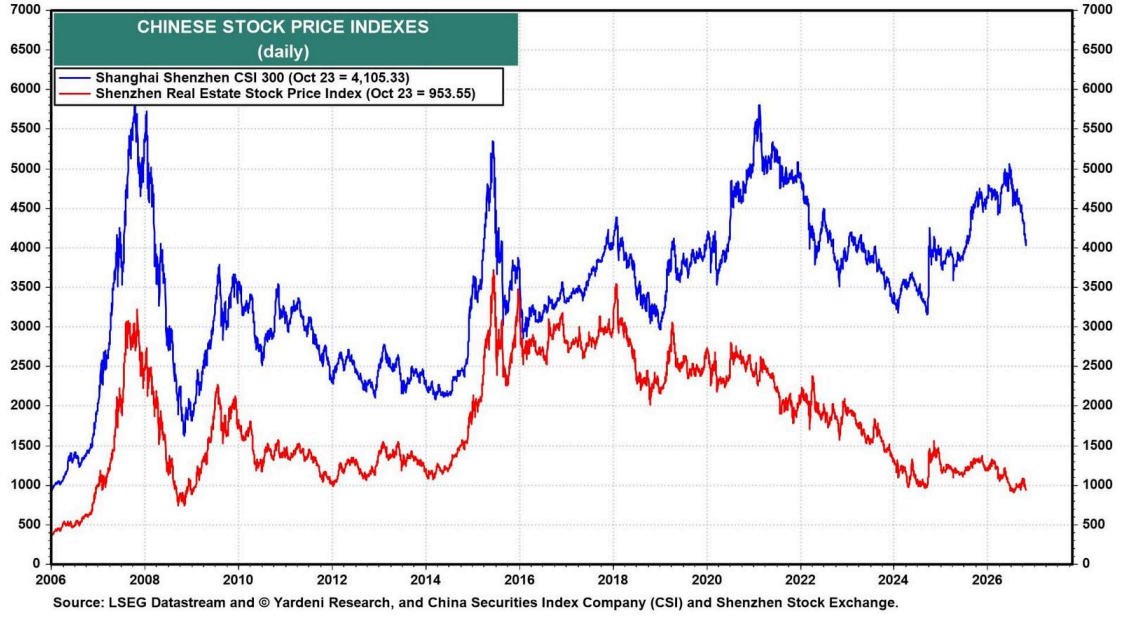
Valuations aren't stretched. Brazil's forward P/E is 9.2 (chart). That's below its 2025 high of 10.7. The catch is that analysts expect earnings to grow 44.6% this year but just 0.6% in 2027.



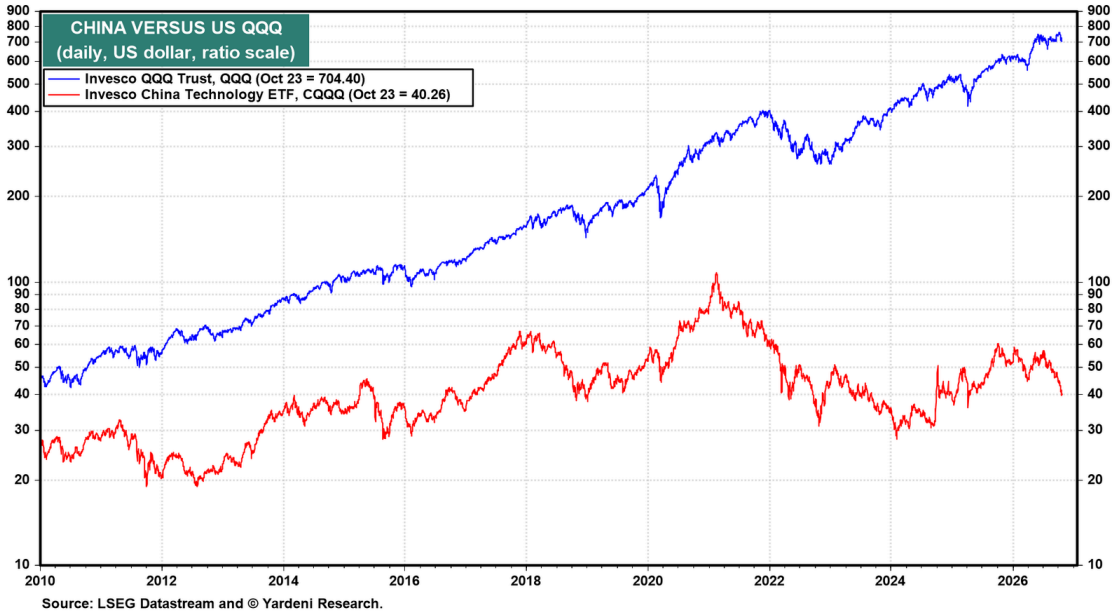
Brazil's central bank has room to ease. It has lowered the Selic rate to 13.75% from a peak of 15.00% (chart). Inflation was 4.6% in September. That leaves a real policy rate of about 9%.



(2) China. China's property bust is deepening. The Shenzhen Real Estate Stock Price Index fell to 953.55, breaking below the floor that had held since 2012 (chart). Last week, we wrote that we would worry if it did that. Now we are worried. Real estate investment is down 20.6% through the first nine months of the year. Exports continue to carry the economy.



Beijing's stabilization efforts haven't stopped the selling. The China ETF (FXI) fell 4.5% last week. Chinese technology stocks have missed the AI rally that lifted US tech (chart). The China Technology ETF (CQQQ) is at 40.26, far below its 2021 peak.



China's bond market confirms the deflationary picture. The 10-year government bond yield is down to 1.62% (chart). It's one of only two major yields that have fallen this year. China's yield is now well below Japan's 2.80%.

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Subject: Weekly Roundup - October 25th
Date: 2 hours ago

Weekly Roundup - October 25th

YARDENI QUICKTAKES

Weekly Roundup - October 25th

By Ed Yardeni • 25 Oct 2026

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Thank you for being a valued member of Yardeni QuickTakes. Here's a recap of the insightful articles, webinars, and market analyses you enjoyed this week:

ECONOMIC WEEK AHEAD: October 26-30

The S&P 500 fell 0.5% last week, and the Nasdaq dropped 0.7%, both posting second straight weekly losses. The Nasdaq's …

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US MARKETS CALL: Still Proceeding Cautiously

On September 15, we advised investors to proceed with caution. We pushed out our 8,400 S&P 500 target from year-end 202…

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AI Credit Crunch?

I. AI Jitters Investors have worried that AI companies are spending too much on data centers. These companies' once am…

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Irrational Exuberance In S&P 500 FEMO?

Are analysts' earnings expectations for the S&P 500 irrationally exuberant? So far this year, FEMO (fabulous earnings m…

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WEEKLY WEBCAST: Question For The Fed: Where Is Waldo?

The risks to the Fed’s dual mandate are constantly changing. Its attempt to hit its inflation target is complicated by …

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What Will Warsh Do?

I. The Fed: To Hike or Not To Hike? The Federal Reserve announces its next interest-rate decision on Wednesday, Octobe…

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FOMO's Rollercoaster Versus FEMO's Steady Climb

I. FOMO vs FEMO Forecasting the stock market is easy! Just multiply the P/E (price-to-earnings ratio) by E (earnings p…

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US SECTORS CALL: Tech Wrecked, Health Care & Staples Rally

The S&P 500 fell 2.0% this week, and Information Technology (MW) took the biggest hit. The sector fell 6.4%, the worst …

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ECONOMIC WEEK AHEAD: October 19 - 23

Last week’s inflation reports came in hot. September’s CPI rose 0.6% m/m, lifting headline inflation from 3.4% y/y in A…

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GLOBAL MARKET CALL: Downgrading 'Go Global' To Market Weight

We are downgrading the “Go Global” portfolio strategy from overweight to market weight and raising “Stay Home” (in the …

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ECONOMIC WEEK AHEAD: October 26-30

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ECONOMIC WEEK AHEAD: October 26-30

By Ed Yardeni & Toby Hearst • 24 Oct 2026

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Photo by Monica Sauro / Unsplash

Live Economic Calendar

October 26–30, 2026

Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
26 • Chicago Fed Nat'l Activity (Sep) • Dallas Fed Business Survey (Oct)	27 • Case-Shiller HPI (Aug) • Consumer Confidence (Oct) • Durable Goods (Sep) • New Home Sales (Sep) • Richmond Fed Business Survey (Oct)	28 • FOMC Meeting Statement • Mortgage Applications (10/23)	29 • GDP (Q3) • Personal Income (Sep) • Unemployment Claims (10/24)	30 • Chicago PMI (Oct) • Employment Cost Index (Q3)

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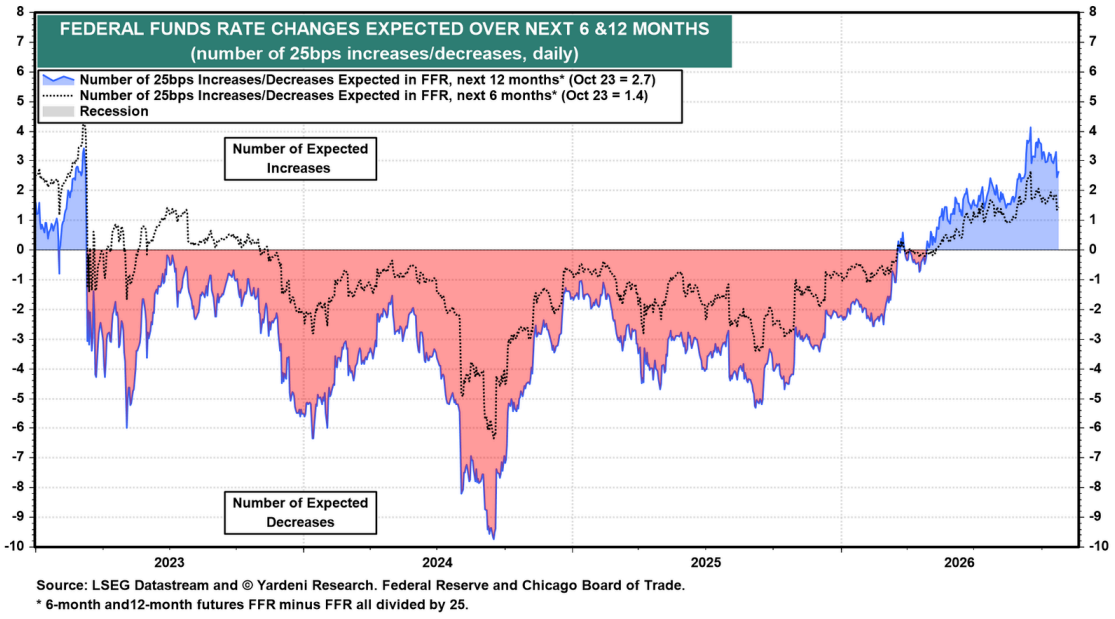
The S&P 500 fell 0.5% last week, and the Nasdaq dropped 0.7%, both posting second straight weekly losses. The Nasdaq's 2.9% slide on Thursday was its biggest one-day drop since June, as concerns flared over the cost and availability of financial capital for AI investment. The price of WTI crude topped $100 a barrel amid US-Iran conflict concerns, while the 10-year Treasury yield fell to 5.0%.

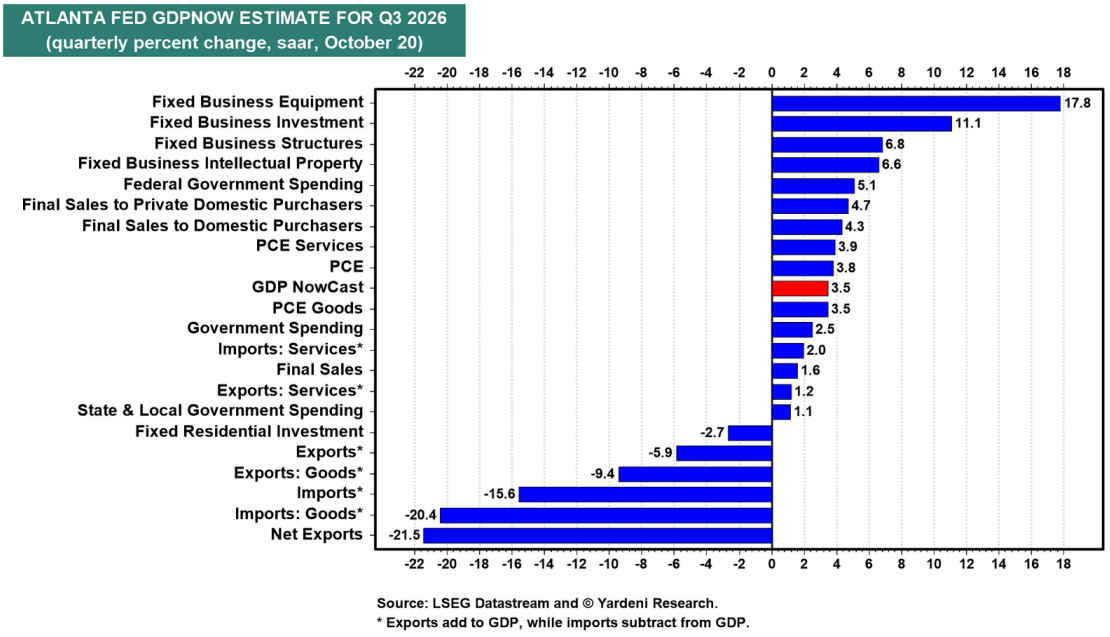
The FOMC meeting (Wed) is the focus this week, alongside the release of Q3 GDP and September's PCED inflation report (Thu). San Francisco Fed President Mary Daly and St. Louis Fed President Alberto Musalem speak on Friday. A heavy week of Q3 earnings reports rounds out a packed calendar. Here's more:

(1) FOMC. The FOMC's two-day meeting concludes Wednesday, followed by Fed Chair Kevin Warsh's press conference. The CME FedWatch Tool puts the odds of a hike this week at 9% and the odds of one in December at 84%. Federal funds futures imply 2.7 rate hikes over the next 12 months and 1.4 over the next six (chart). We believe the committee should hike on Wednesday but won't because the midterm elections are so close.

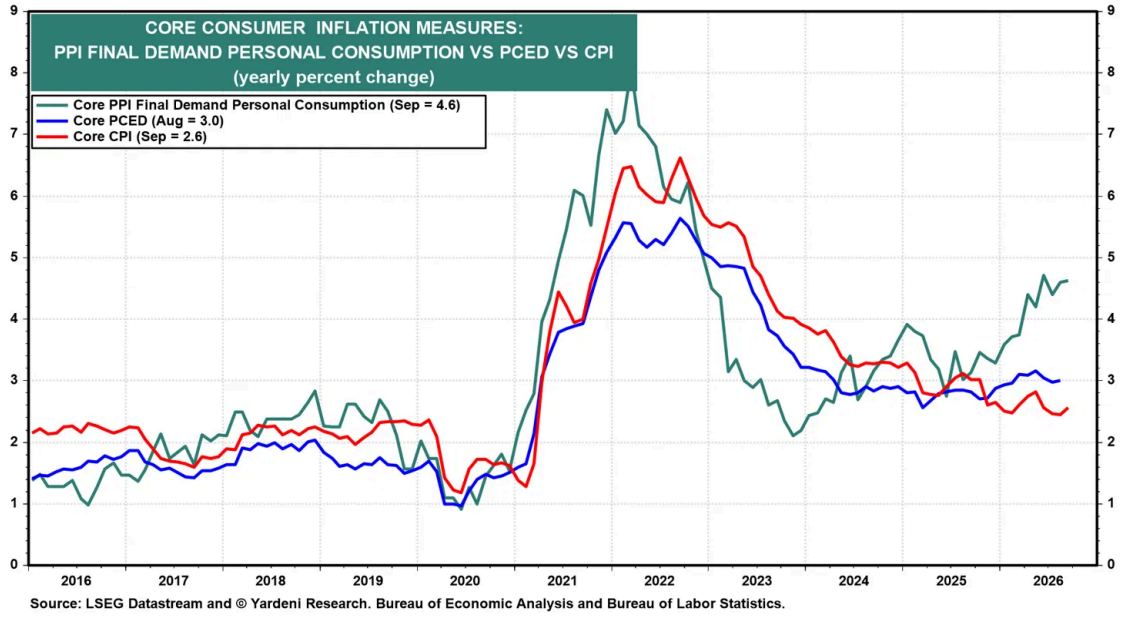


Source: LSEG Datastream and © Yardeni Research. Federal Reserve and Chicago Board of Trade.
* 6-month and12-month futures FFR minus FFR all divided by 25.

(2) GDP & PCED. The first estimate of Q3 GDP (Thu) follows Q2's third estimate of 2.2% saar, with the GDP price index up 6.1%. The Atlanta Fed's GDPNow model estimates Q3 growth at 3.5% as of October 20, led by a 17.8% jump in business equipment spending (chart).



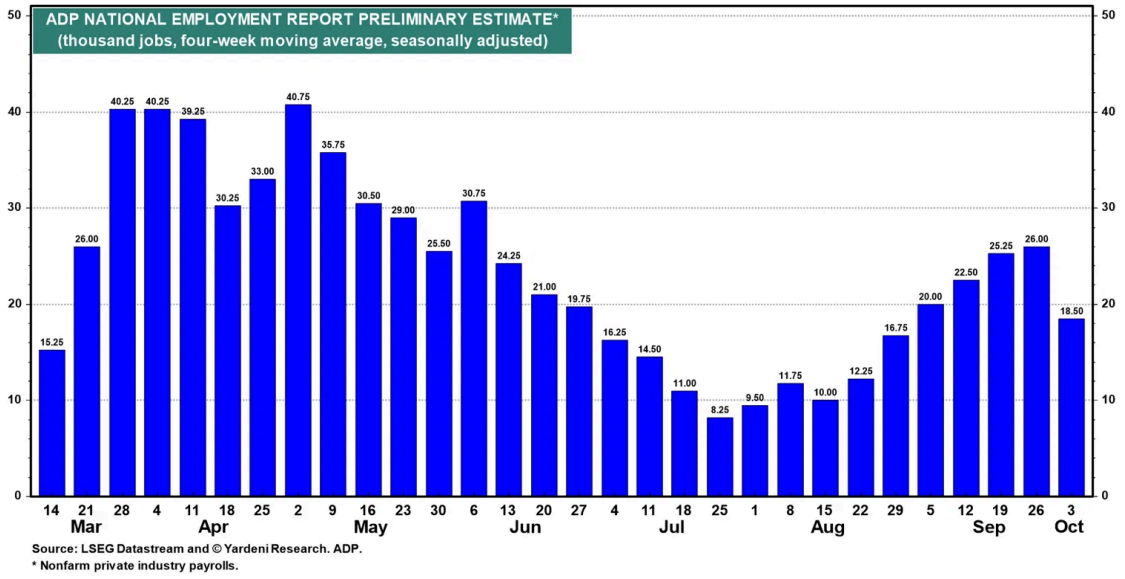
September's core PCED (Thu) follows August's 3.0% y/y. That was well below September's 4.6% pace of core PPI final demand for personal consumption and above the core CPI's 2.6% (chart). The Cleveland Fed's Inflation Nowcasting model projects September's core and headline PCED at 3.1% and 3.6% y/y, up from August's 3.0% and 3.4%. (The model's m/m rates are 0.28% and 0.47%.)



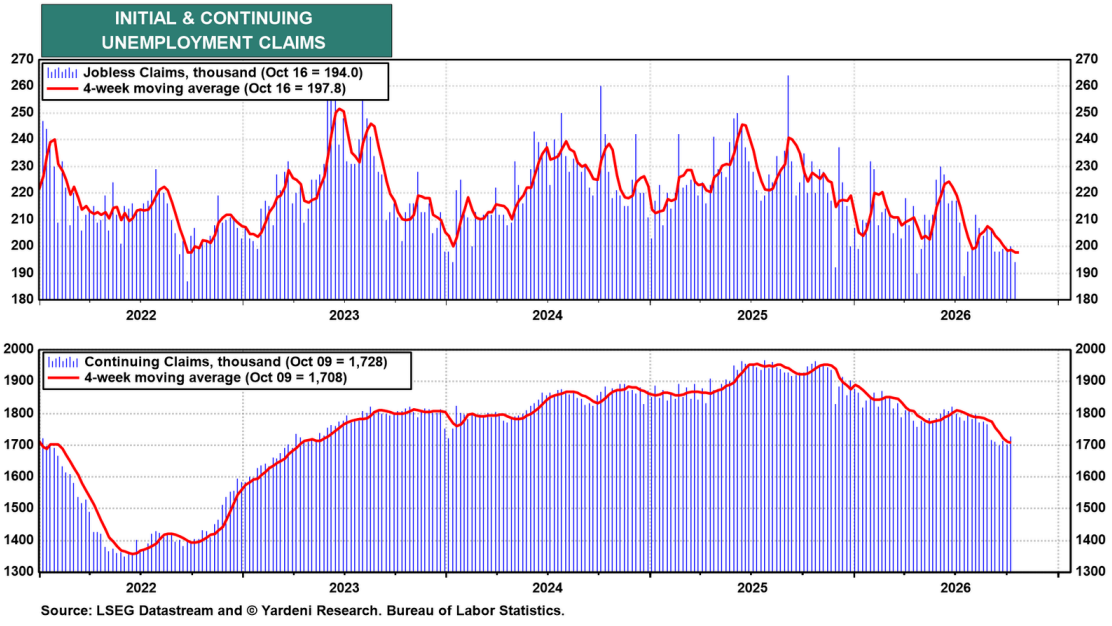
CPI computer software and accessories rose 28.4% y/y in September and PPI electronic components 26.8%, while PCED computers and peripheral

equipment rose just 8.4% in August. September's PCED will show whether that gap starts to close.

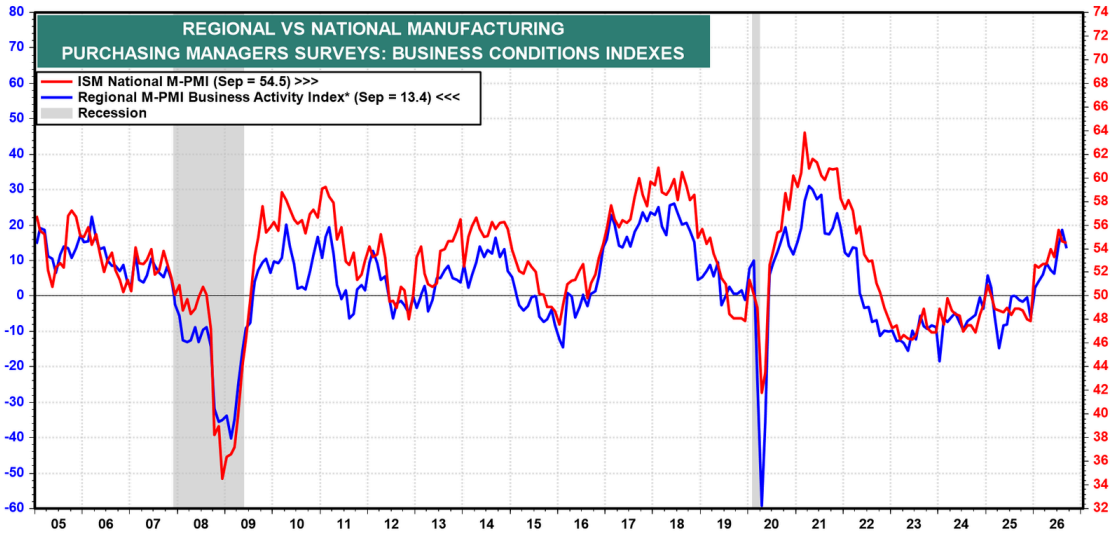
(3) ADP & unemployment claims. ADP's weekly employment reading (Tue) follows a drop in the four-week average to 18,500 for the week ended October 3, down from 26,000 the prior week (chart). That's still more than double July's low of 8,250, pointing to a solid October payrolls report.



Initial jobless claims (Thu) follow last week's 194,000, below expectations and near the lowest level since the late 1960s. The four-week average stands at 197,800 (chart). Continuing claims rose to 1,728,000 for the week ended October 9, up from 1,710,000, while their four-week average edged down to 1,708,000.



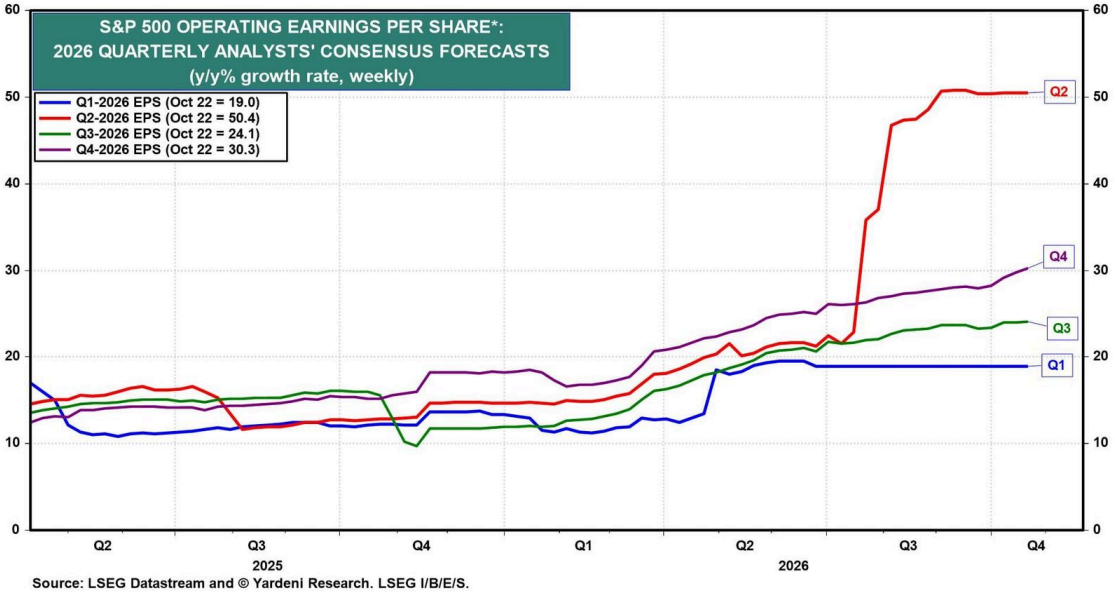
(4) Regional business surveys. The Richmond Fed's manufacturing index (Tue) follows September's -2 reading. The regional M-PMI business activity index slipped to 13.4 in September from August's 18.7, while the national M-PMI eased to 54.5 from 54.6 (chart).



Source: LSEG Datastream and © Yardeni Research. Institute for Supply Management (ISM) and Federal Reserve banks of New York, Philadelphia, Kansas City, Dallas and Richmond.
* Average of Dallas, Philadelphia, Kansas City, New York, and Richmond Fed business surveys.

(5) Earnings. The earnings reporting season heats up this week, with 36% of the S&P 500 companies set to report. Boeing, Seagate, and Corning report on Tuesday. Alphabet, Microsoft, SK Hynix, and GE Vernova follow on Wednesday. Samsung, Intel, Eli Lilly, SanDisk, and Amazon report on Thursday. Exxon Mobil reports on Friday.

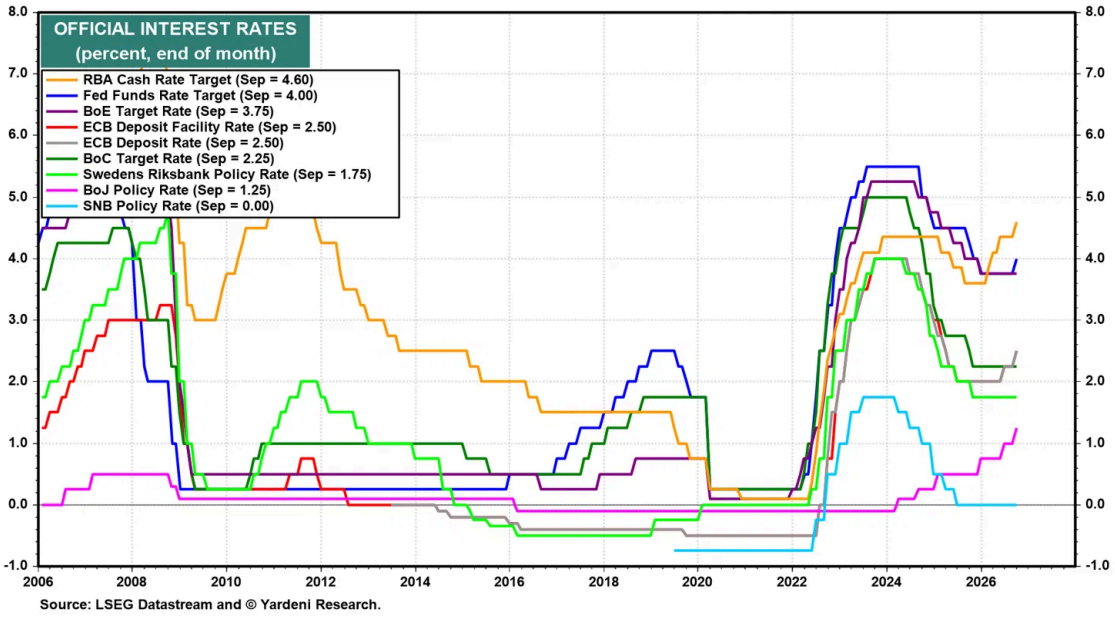
Analysts' consensus estimates imply Q3-2026 operating EPS growth for S&P 500 companies of 24.1% y/y, slightly up from last week (chart). Q4 estimates have also risen.



Source: LSEG Datastream and © Yardeni Research. LSEG I/B/E/S.
* Growth rates compare current members of the S&P 500 with members in the index a year earlier (apples-to-oranges comparisons).

(6) Global central banks. Both the Reserve Bank of New Zealand and the Bank of Canada (Wed) are expected to hike by 25bps. The markets are pricing in 88% odds that the RBNZ will lift its official cash rate to 3.00**%** and an 85% chance that the BOC will raise its policy rate to 2.50%. The European Central Bank (Thu) and the Bank of Japan (Fri) are set to hold their policy rates at 2.50% and 1.25%, respectively (chart).

December is the focus for the latter pair. The markets are pricing in 75% odds of an ECB hike in December and a 74% probability of a BOJ hike. Guidance from ECB President Christine Lagarde and BOJ Governor Kazuo Ueda will show whether those odds hold.



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產 5. Capital return on sales/profits 我們的專用指標是否惡化？目前持續改善中 6. 當AI數據算力中心資本開支增長趨緩後，這些公司的營收及獲利前景是否才開始爆發？目前資本開支動能還是遠遠高於營收/獲利增長動能。 最後就是我們認為要判斷半導體超級週期是否結束，要看他們的下游大客戶怎麼說/怎麼做，而不是看半導體產業鏈怎麼說/怎麼做。

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US MARKETS CALL: Still Proceeding Cautiously

YARDENI QUICKTAKES

US MARKETS CALL: Still Proceeding Cautiously

By Ed Yardeni & Toby Hearst • 24 Oct 2026

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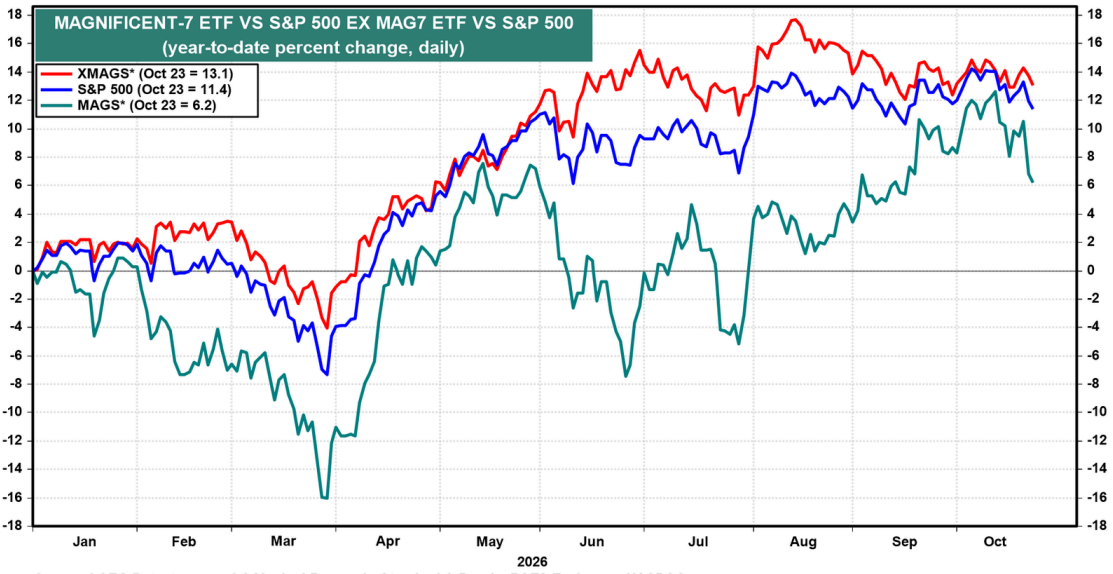
Photo by Jordan Christian / Unsplash

On September 15, we advised investors to proceed with caution. We pushed out our 8,400 S&P 500 target from year-end 2026 to mid-2027 and set 7,900 as our new year-end target. On October 14, we reiterated our caution. Sure enough, the stock market has been turbulent since mid-September, with AI-related stocks falling sharply.

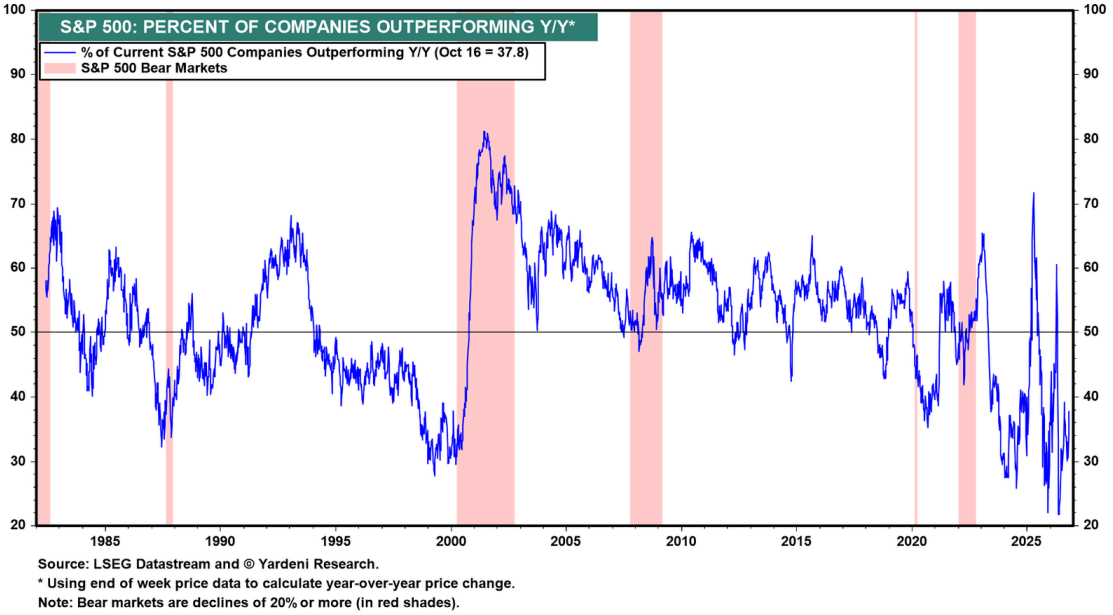
We are seeing some buying opportunities, but better ones are likely after the November 3 midterm elections. Our main concern is a likely escalation of the Middle East war. That could push oil prices above their $120 peak earlier this year.

I. Stock Market Performance

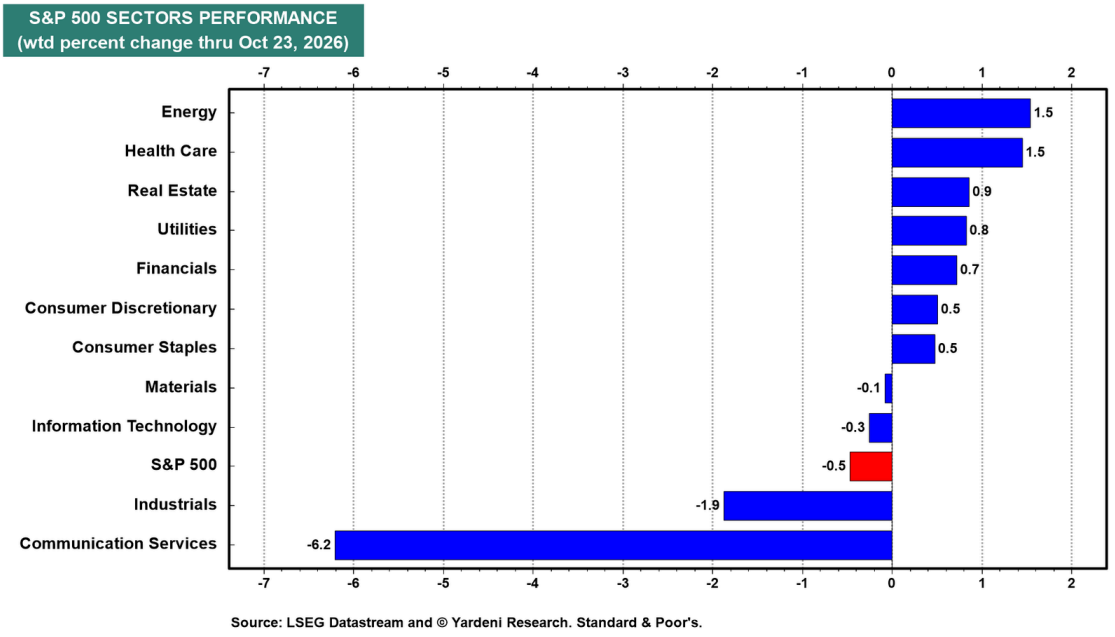
The S&P 500 is still up double digits ytd at 11.4% (chart). XMAGS is up 13.1%, while MAGS is up only 6.2%. The gap has widened again in recent weeks as MAGS rolled over. Meta led the latest leg down, falling 9.4% last week after reporting earnings.



Breadth remained on the weak side. Only 37.8% of S&P 500 companies are outperforming the index on a y/y basis (chart).

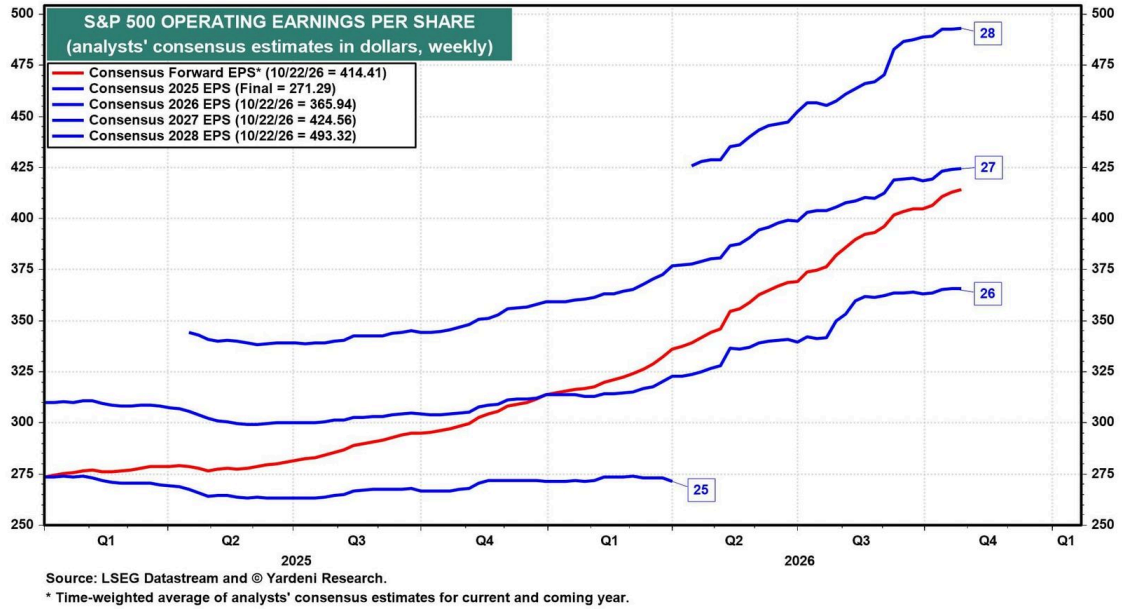


Rotation was notable last week. The S&P 500 Energy and Health Care sectors led with gains of 1.5% each (chart). Communication Services fell 6.2%, and Industrials dropped 1.9%. As bad as the week felt, the S&P 500 was down only 0.5%.



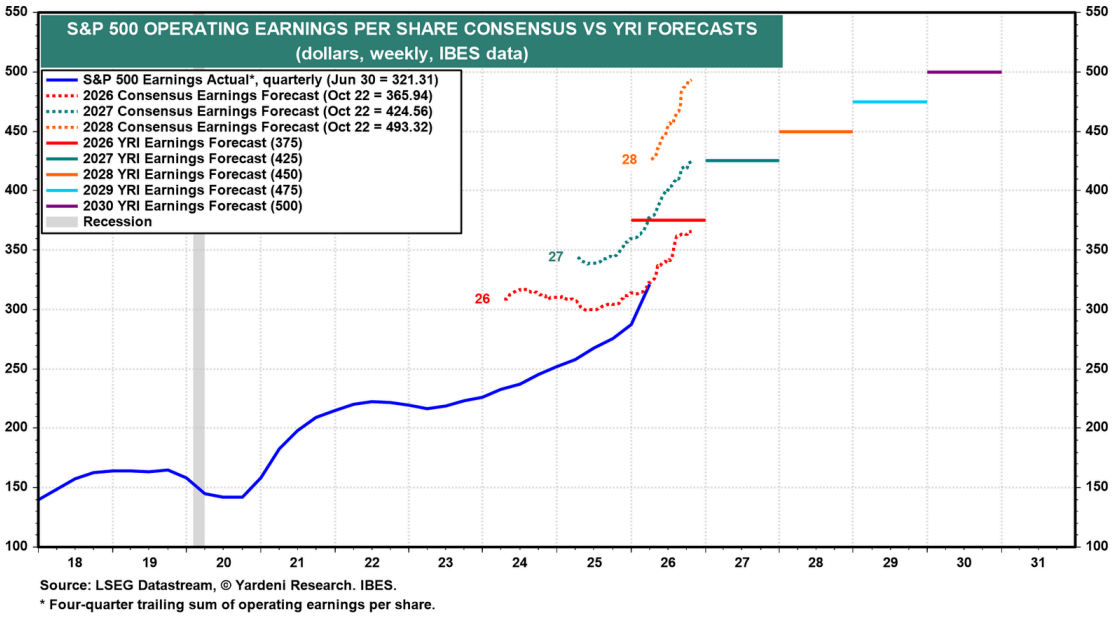
II. S&P 500 Earnings

S&P 500 forward earnings per share rose to a record $414.41 during the week of October 22 (chart). It is converging on the analysts' 2027 consensus estimate of $424.56, up from this year's estimate of $365.94 (chart).

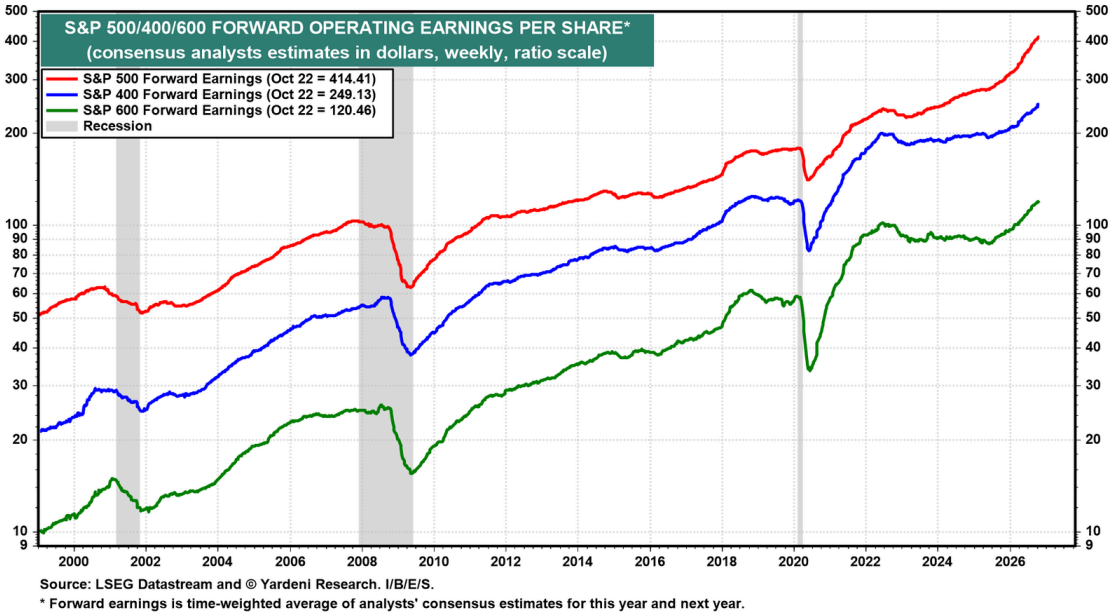


The 2026 consensus is closing in on our $375 per-share forecast (chart). The consensus for 2027 matches our $425 forecast. The 2028 consensus is already $493.32, well above our $450 forecast for that year and almost

at our $500 target for 2030! If the analysts are right, the S&P 500 could rise to 10,000 by the end of next year. We are sticking with that target for the end of 2029. We think the analysts are too bullish on earnings.

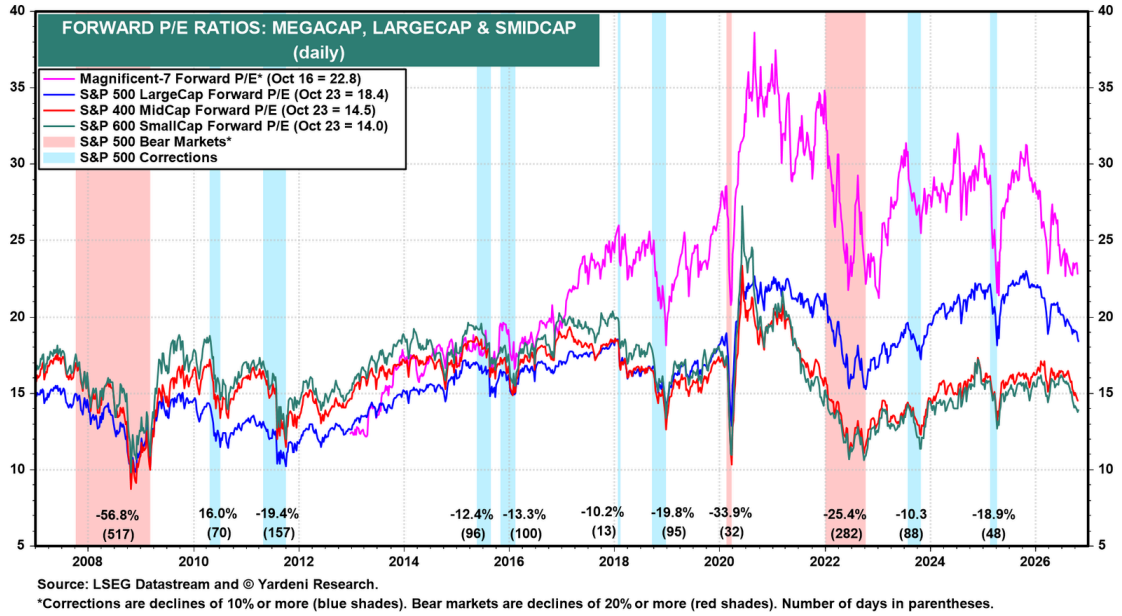


Forward earnings for the S&P 400 and S&P 600 are also at record highs (chart).

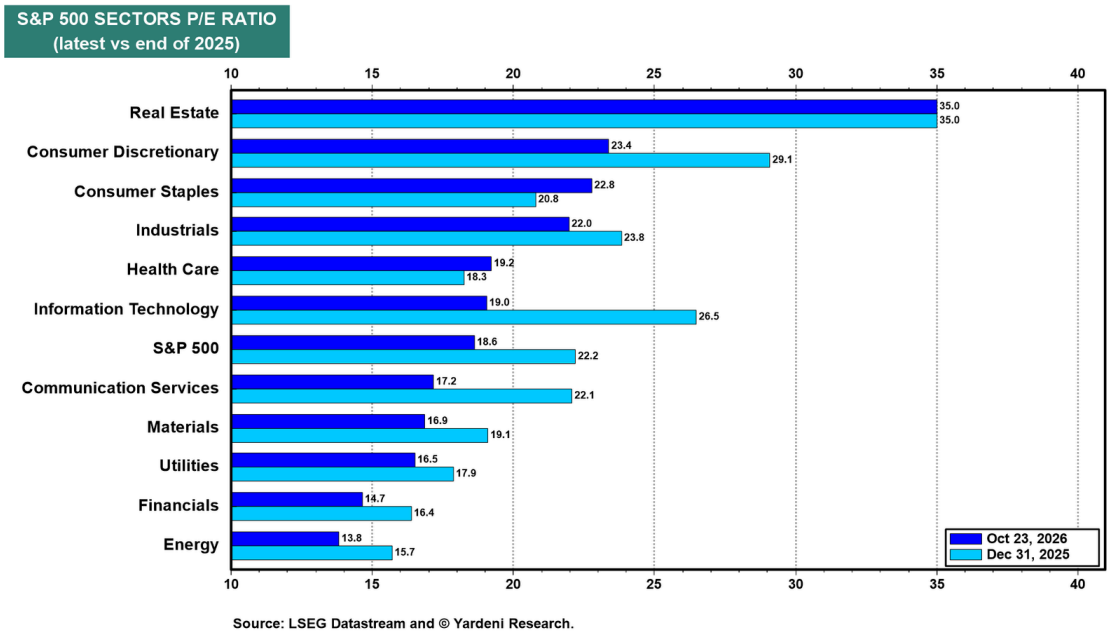


III. Valuation

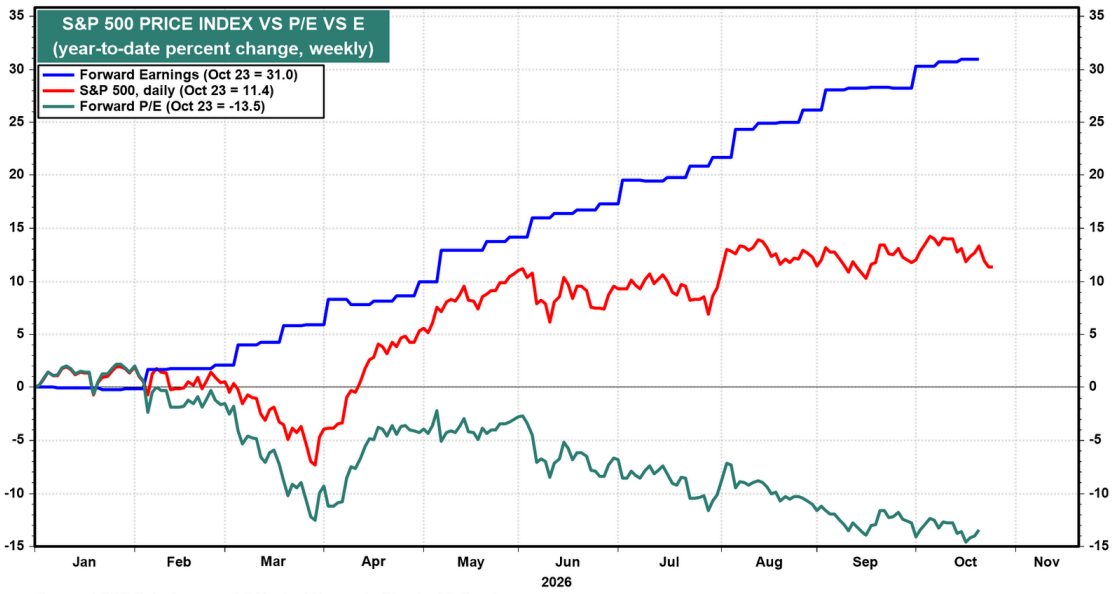
Valuation multiples continue to compress despite strong earnings (chart). The Magnificent-7's forward P/E is 22.8, down from a 2026 peak of 28.5. The S&P 500, S&P 400, and S&P 600 trade at 18.4, 14.5 and 14.0, respectively.



The big valuation story is that for the S&P 500 Information Technology sector. Its forward P/E dropped from 26.5 at the end of 2025 to 19.0 now (chart). The S&P 500 has fallen from 22.2 to 18.6.



The S&P 500's forward earnings is up 31.0% ytd (chart). The index is up 11.4%. The forward P/E is down 13.5%. Stocks have gotten significantly cheaper this year.



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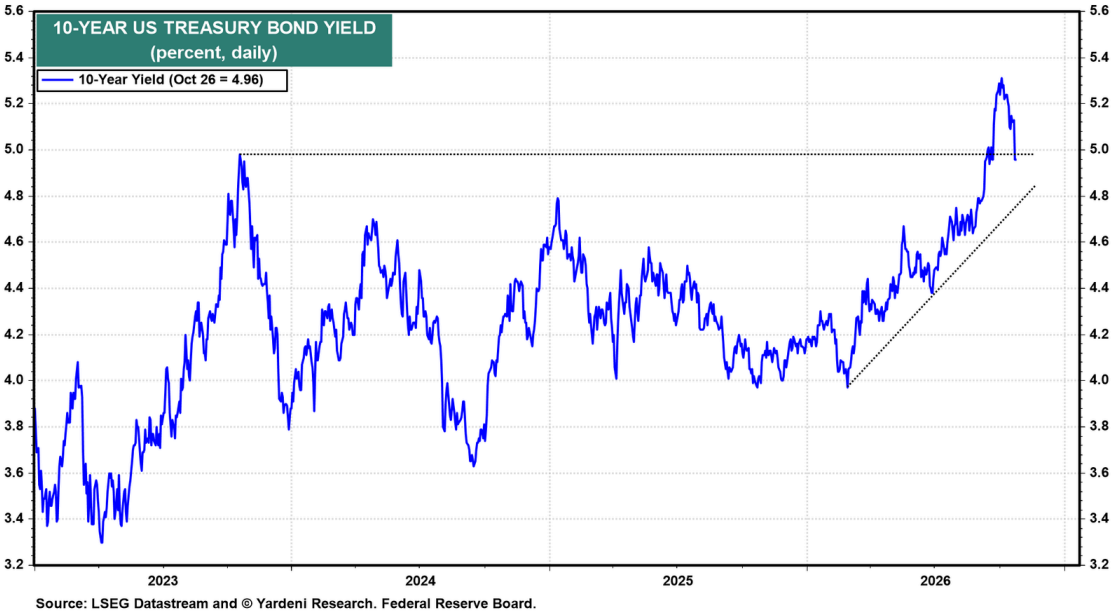
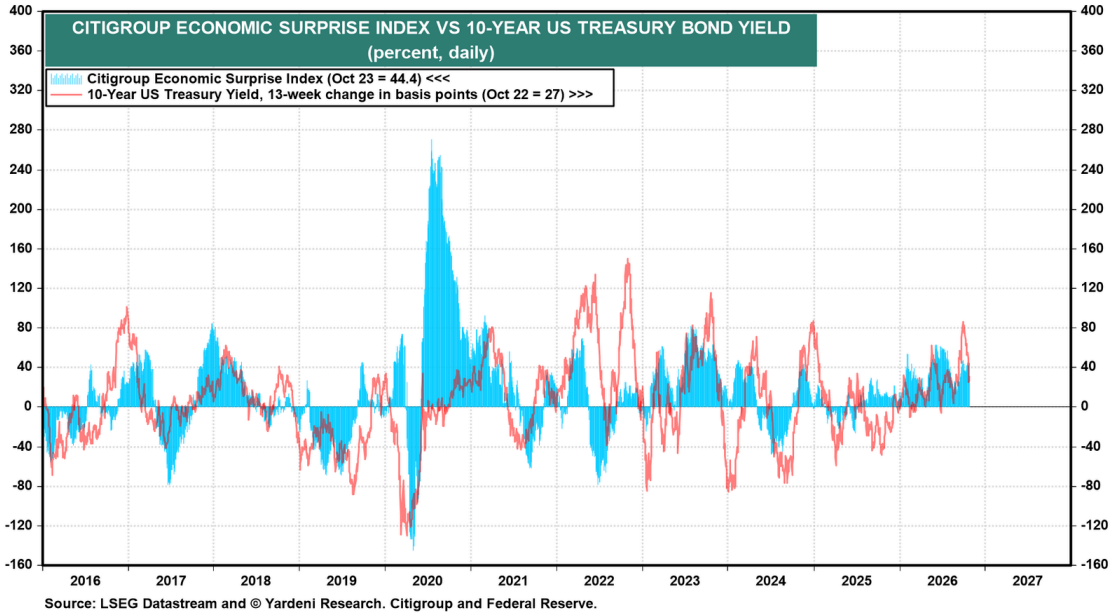
IV. Bonds

The 10-year Treasury yield is back in the “old normal” range of 4.00%-5.00% (chart). It peaked at 5.35%, attracting many buyers. It is now at 4.96%. Some of that decline reflects safe-haven buying during the recent risk-off selloff in the stock market. But market-based measures of long-term inflation expectations remain subdued. Bond investors seem to expect inflation to subside. We agree.

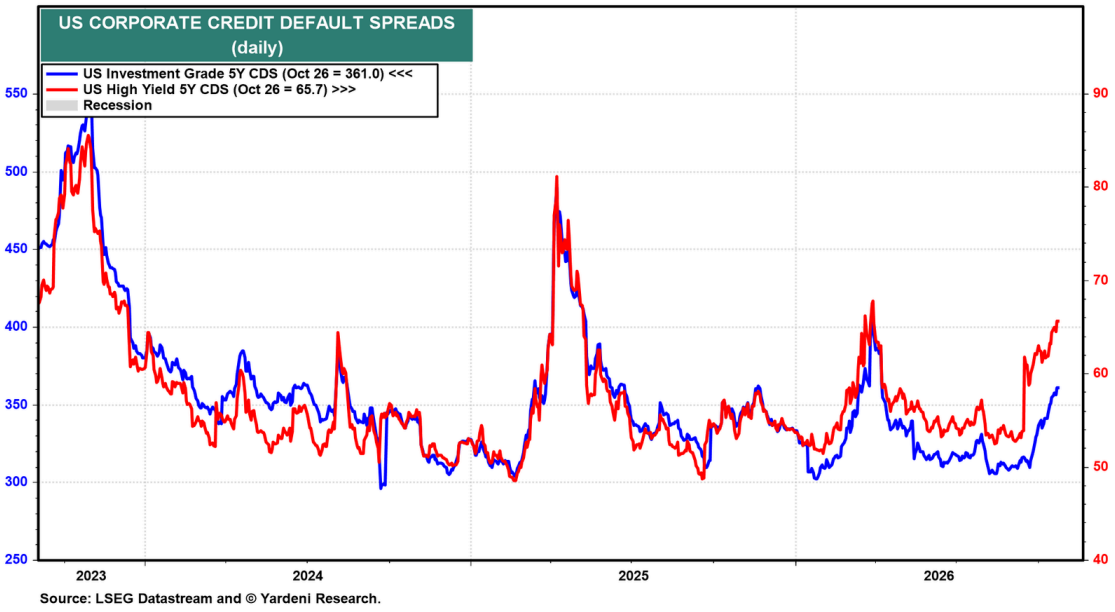


Source: LSEG Datastream and © Yardeni Research. Federal Reserve Board.

The 13-week change in the 10-year yield tends to track the Citigroup Economic Surprise Index (CESI) (chart). Recently, the yield's change overshot the index, as it has done before. Now, the 10-year yield is up 27bps over the past 13 weeks, down from over 80bps a few weeks ago.



Corporate credit default swap spreads are breaking out again (chart). The widening reflects credit-quality concerns about companies like Oracle and CoreWeave. The Bond Vigilantes are regulating credit in the AI ecosystem. That's healthy. We aren't particularly concerned.



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What's new?

2026 年 10 月 22 日至 23 日，路透社（Reuters）、南韓《每日經濟新聞》（Maeil Business Newspaper）與多家科技產業媒體同步披露：全球 AI 晶片霸主輝達（NVIDIA）與電動車及具身智能巨頭特斯拉（Tesla），聯手向南韓三星電機（Samsung Electro-Mechanics）注資約 28 億美元（折合約 3.7 兆韓元），用於其在南韓世宗市（Sejong）工廠大規模新建專用高階覆晶球柵陣列（FC-BGA / ABF Substract）半導體封裝載板產線。此前幾天（10 月 19日），三星電機已於官方聲明中正式確認與全球大型企業達成戰略夥伴協議，將自 2027年1月1日起正式向大客戶供應高階半導體封裝載板（三星电机与全球大型企业签订“存储器半导体用封装基板”长期供应合同（LTA））。報導指出，在 28 億美元注資總承諾中，輝達預計出資約 2.6 兆韓元，特斯拉出資約 1.1 兆韓元。這筆巨額資金旨在為輝達下一代 Blackwell Ultra GB300 NVL72 超級計算叢集、Rubin 架構 GPU，以及特斯拉即將量產的 HW5 自動駕駛車載晶片與 Optimus 機器人神經網絡晶片，鎖定最為緊缺的高層數、大面積先進封裝載板產能。

付費訂閱戶可分享受惠，受害公司/產業，非共識想法，及建議

Subscribed

Positively affect what supply chain vendors and explains why?

三星電機 (Samsung Electro-Mechanics, 009150.KS)：獲得輝達與特斯拉兩大全球最大 AI 算力買家的巨額資本與長約鎖定，使其一舉打破傳統日系（Ibiden, Shinko) 與台系廠商(欣興，南電）的長期壟斷，躍升為全球 AI 載板一線核心主力。

ABF 味之素積層膜材料商（日本味之素 Ajinomoto）與載板設備商：大面積 FC-BGA 載板層數已高達 20 層以上，良率爬坡極耗材料，直接帶動上游特種介電樹脂與雷射鑽孔設備採購放量。

Negatively affect what supply chain vendors and explains why?

傳統載板雙寡頭（日本揖斐電 Ibiden、新光電氣 Shinko）及台系傳統載板廠（欣興、南電）：輝達與特斯拉主動扶持三星電機建立新載板產能，短期可能看不出來，但長期將削弱現有日台供應商過去兩年在高階載板定價上的絕對話語權與超額利潤率，並改變市場份額。以28億美元投資來看，雖然僅佔4%的三星電機市值，但確明顯超過 Ibiden 及欣興近10-15億美元的年度資本開支。

晶圓代工龍頭台積電及封測產業鏈：從Nvidia 及Tesla 在HBM DRAM，DDR DRAM，NAND與三星電子的採購關係，擴大到三星電機 ABF 載板產能擴充的注資，我們不排除 Nvidia及Tesla 將進一步採用三星電子2nm （近期良率有明顯改善）晶圓代工製程及封測技術，讓三星集團進行 AI 訓練及推理晶片製造整合服務來搶台廠份額。

未獲得載板保證的二線 ASIC 晶片設計公司：頂級載板產能被巨頭包攬，使資金鏈較弱的中小 AI 晶片公司面臨載板交期延長至 50 週以上的斷鏈危機。

Our outside the box non-consensus thinking

特斯拉參投載板是「實體 AI 製造去台化/去日化」的戰略預演：市場多將注意力集中於輝達，但特斯拉首次拿出 1.1 兆韓元直投載板廠更具震撼性。這證明馬斯克已深刻意識到——HW5 晶片與百萬台 Optimus 的真正死穴不僅僅是晶圓代工產能短缺，而也包括ABF 封裝載板面積及厚度激增引發的良率瓶頸。特斯拉直接以車企身分下場穿透供應鏈投資底層零組件，正在重構半導體採購範式。

「晶片面積膨脹」倒逼載板成為半導體新護城河：隨著晶片尺寸光罩極限朝 10x 以上突破（Reticle Limit)，單顆 GB300 或 HW5 載板尺寸已超過 100mm x 100mm，相當於一塊小型主機板。載板製造已從傳統 PCB 加工轉變為「類晶圓級微影工程」，載板產能的鎖定甚至比搶奪台積電 CoWoS 配額更具決定性。

Our advises to investors

我們建議投資人關注三星電機（Samsung Electro-Mechanics）及其核心材料設備供應商在產業份額的變化，尤其是在輝達與特斯拉雙重認證下，其高階載板營收佔比將在未來兩年由不足 15% 是否能飆升至 30% 以上，迎來估值重估。適度獲利了結估值處於歷史高點的傳統純載板標的，防範 2027 年三星電機新產能開出後，行業整體毛利率面臨均值回歸的競爭壓力。三星電機產線在大面積 FC-BGA 的翹曲控制（Warpage Control）與熱膨脹良率爬坡仍值得觀察。

Sources of the major news

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- [Korea JoongAng Daily 官方合作披露] https://www.koreajoongangdaily.com/business/nvidia-taps-samsung-electromechanics-for-ai-chips-substrate-supply-chain/12932915

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AI Credit Crunch?

YARDENI QUICKTAKES

AI Credit Crunch?

By Ed Yardeni & Elias Griepentrog • 22 Oct 2026
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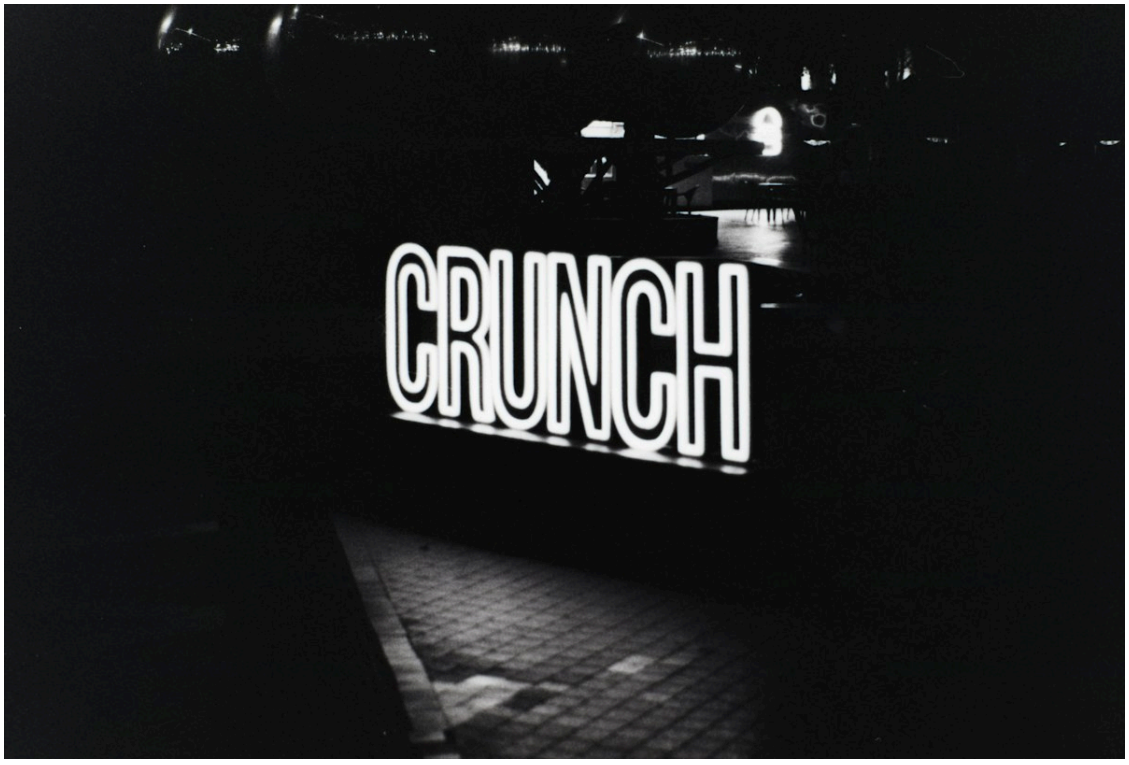


Photo by Ragnar Beaverson / Unsplash

I. AI Jitters

Investors have worried that AI companies are spending too much on data centers. These companies' once ample free cash flows have turned negative, forcing them to borrow. Concerns have mounted that they are driving up financing costs and won't generate sufficient returns to justify their huge investments. Now, another concern is moving to the forefront: Does enough capital even exist to finance everyone's ambitious AI spending plans?

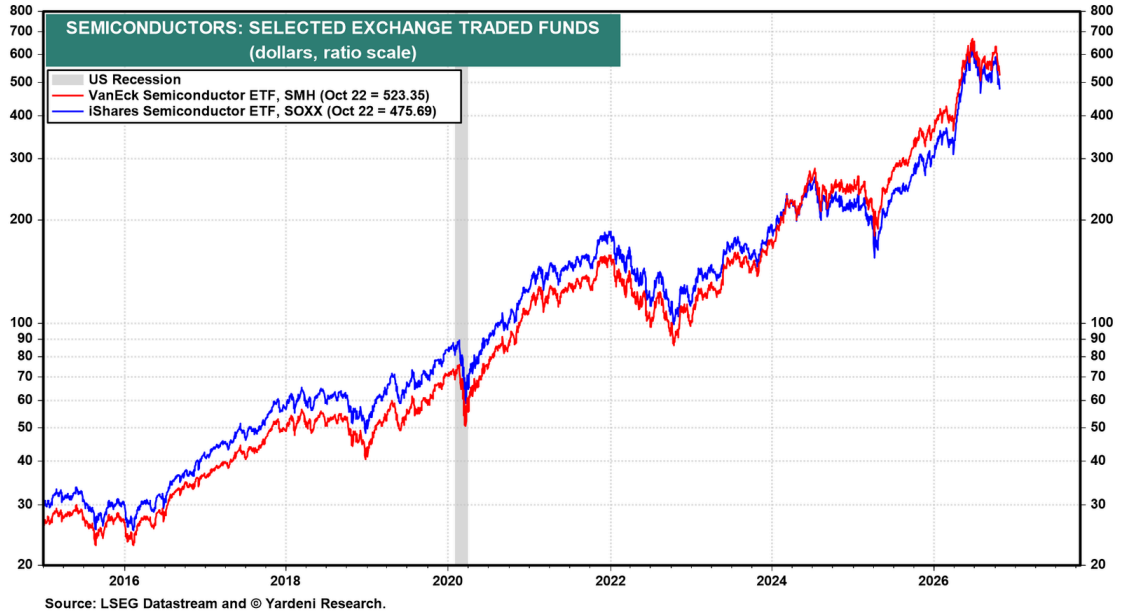
Meta's earnings announcement on Wednesday brought these concerns to the fore. Despite revenues rising 26% y/y to $64.6 billion, the company reported negative free cash flow of $2.1 billion. It raised the lower end of its 2026 capital expenditure guidance to $135–$145 billion and announced a new class of non-voting shares to facilitate future capital raising. Investors interpreted the move as a sign that even hyperscalers may be rushing to secure financing before competitors absorb the available capital.

Indeed, the Meta report stated: "Recent significant capital raises from peers like Alphabet and SpaceX, alongside anticipated fundraising from Anthropic and OpenAI, have created an increasingly challenging fundraising environment."

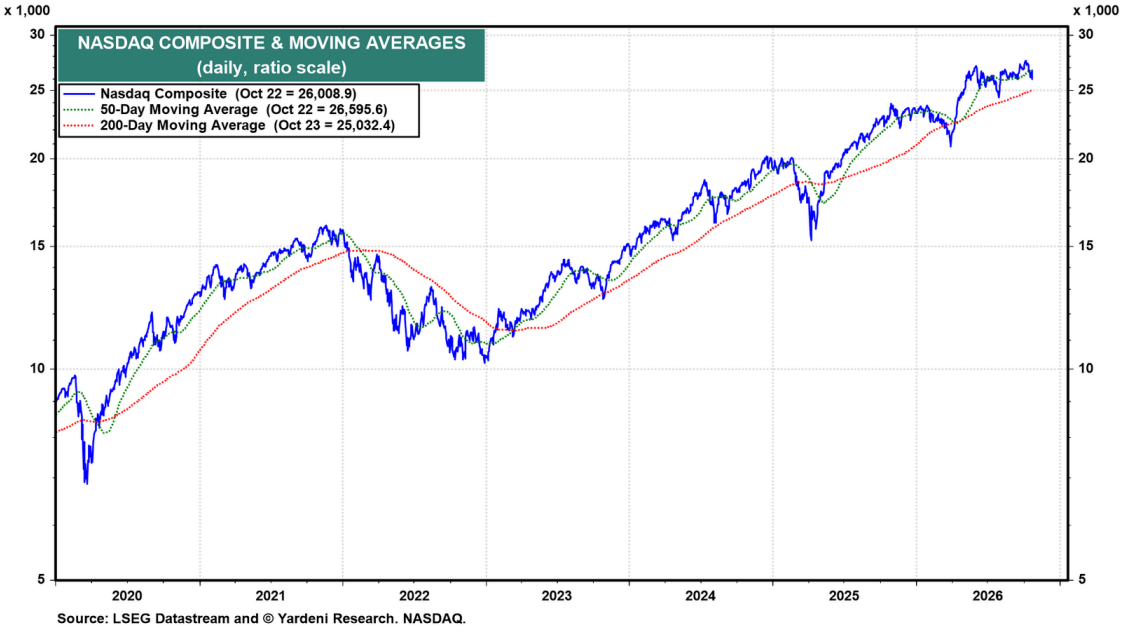
Several industry leaders have confirmed this concern. Broadcom CEO Hock Tan recently warned that capital could become the biggest constraint on AI development. BlackRock CEO Larry Fink said that competition for capital was the fiercest he had witnessed in his career. On Thursday, Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang warned that neocloud demand is "off the charts" but capital is scarce.

As AI companies compete for capital, rising financing costs increase the returns required to justify investments, amplifying the original worry about whether all that spending will pay off. Today's market action showed how these concerns are playing out across stock and bond markets:

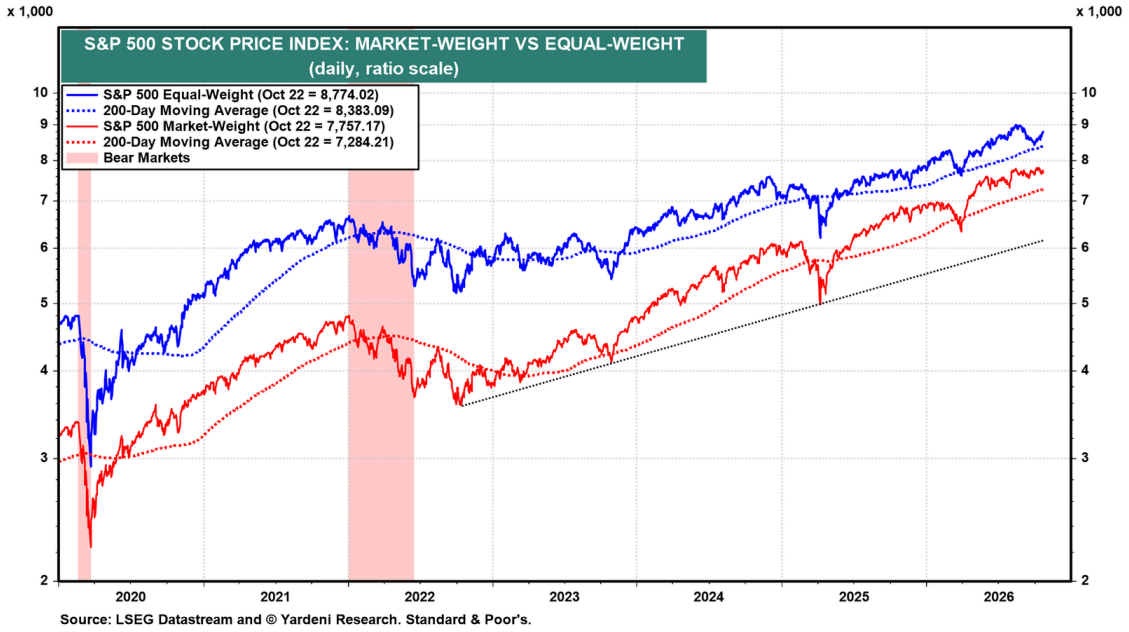
(1) AI stocks got a shellacking. Meta's shares plunged 7.0% today after yesterday's announcement, leading a broad selloff in AI-related stocks. Nvidia fell 4.4%, CoreWeave fell 10.1%, and Lam Research fell 11.8%. SOXX dropped 6.8% (chart).



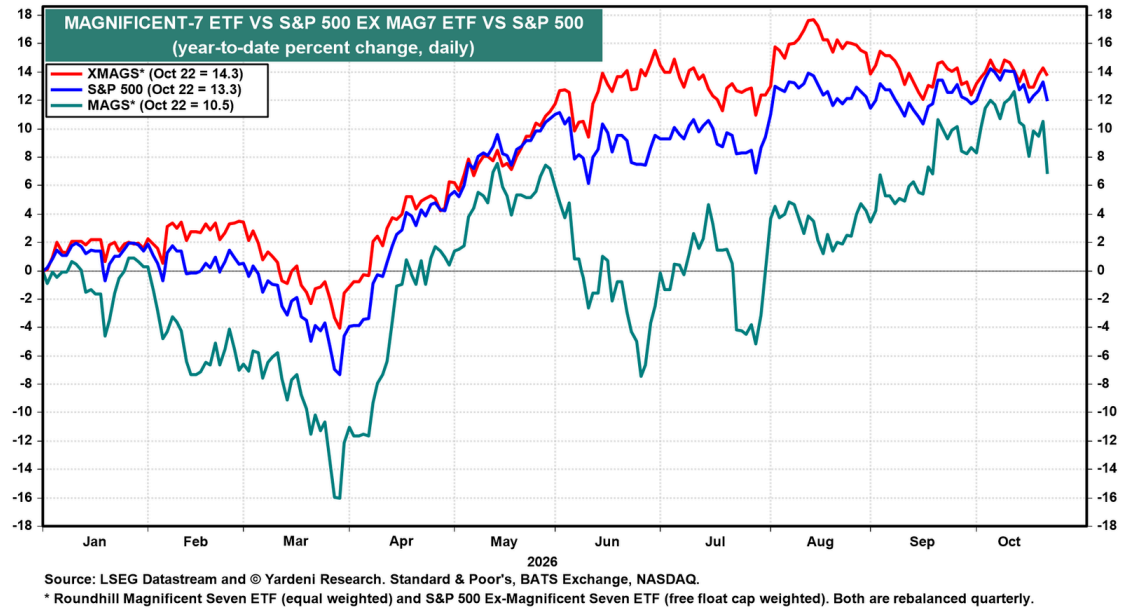
The Nasdaq dropped 2.6%, its worst day in four months (chart).



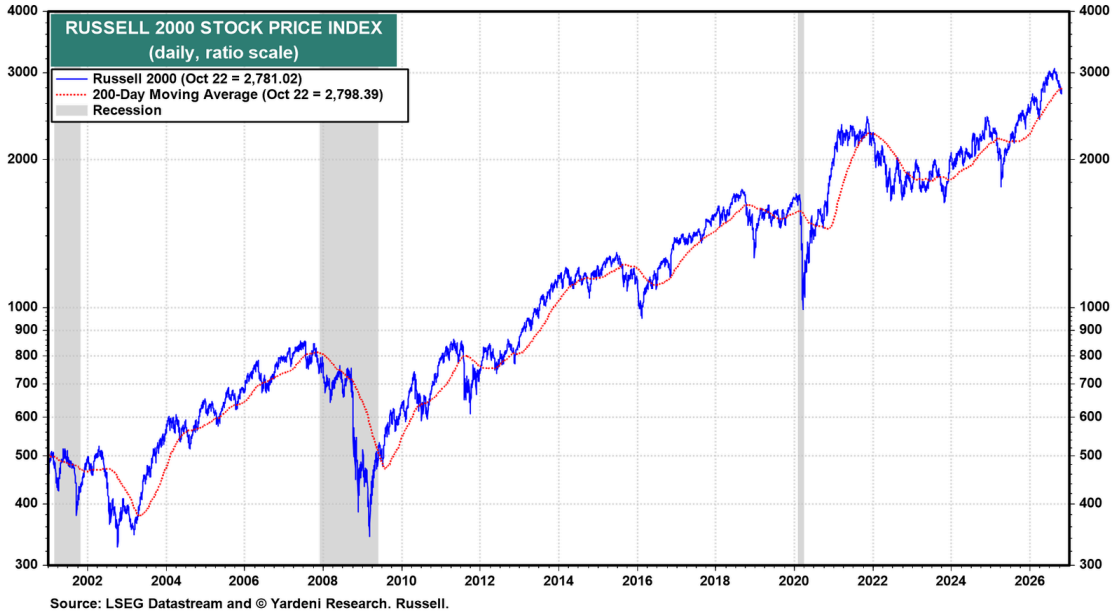
(2) Investors rotated. The market broadened away from technology stocks today. The equal-weighted S&P 500 edged up 0.7%, outperforming its market-cap-weighted counterpart, which fell 1.2% (chart).



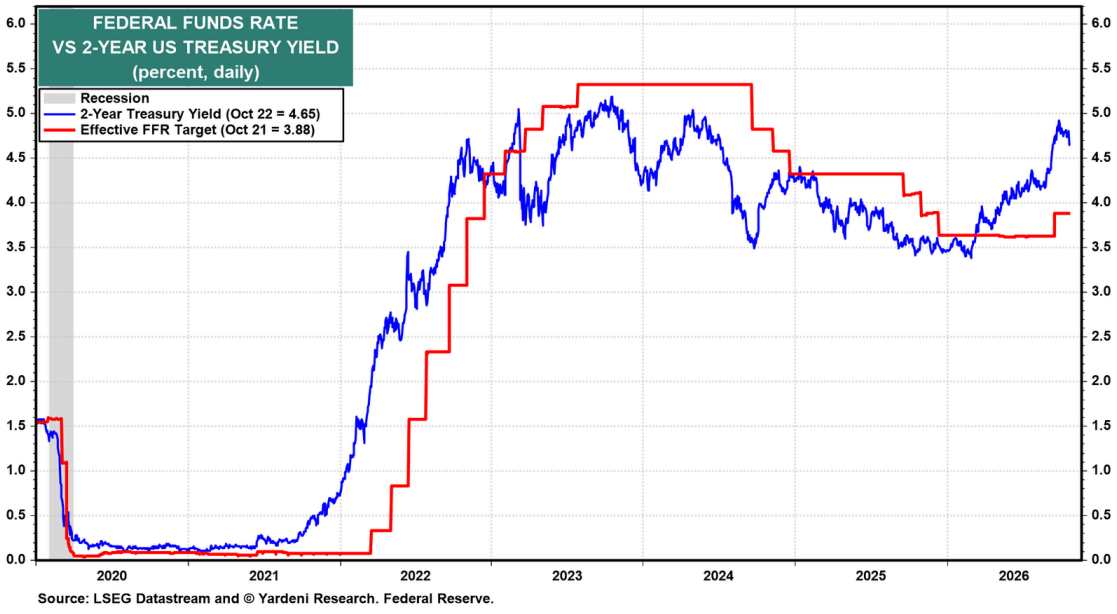
MAGS fell 3.4% today, while XMAG edged down 0.5% (chart). The latter is still outperforming the former so far this year: 14.3% versus 10.5%.



The Dow edged up 0.02%, while the Russell 2000 gained 0.11% (chart). Rather than abandoning equities, investors rotated away from the AI trade into other sectors.



(3) The bond market's reaction was a happy one. Treasury yields declined across the yield curve, with the 2-year falling sharply to 4.64% but remaining well above the effective federal funds rate (chart).



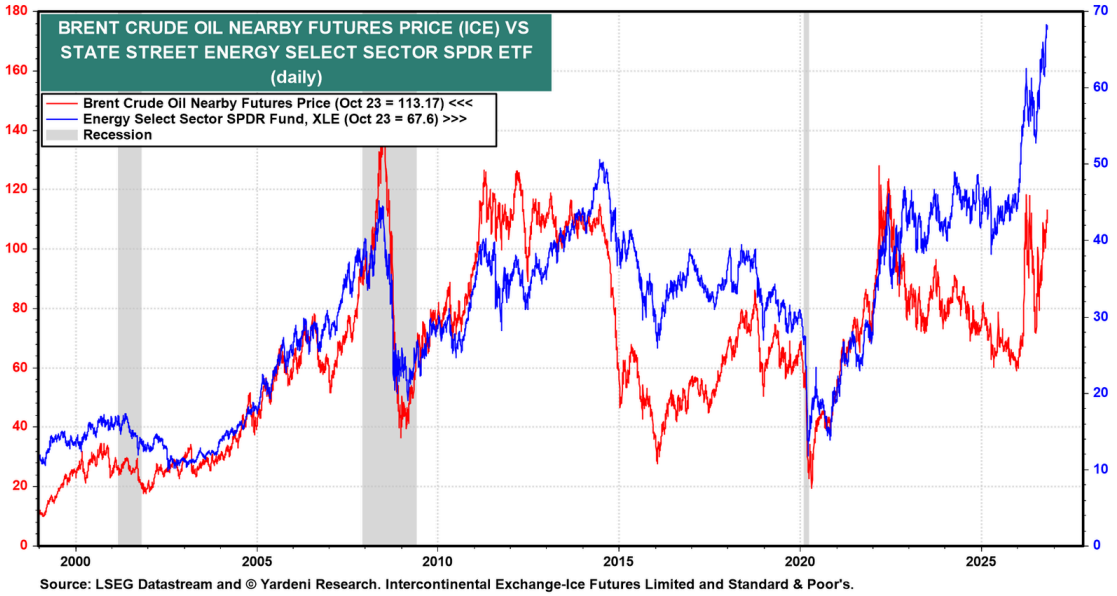
The 10-year Treasury yield fell below 5.00% for the first time in nearly a month, returning to what we consider its old-normal range of 4.00%–5.00% (chart). The Treasury market rally suggests that investors are increasingly concerned that tightening access to capital could slow the AI buildout, one of the economy's most important growth engines.

(4) Our take. We view market-driven tightening access to capital as healthy for the AI boom, resulting in more efficient capital allocation and reducing over-investment risks. Importantly, we expect the key players to retain financing access. The five major hyperscalers (Amazon, Alphabet, Meta, Microsoft, and Oracle) alone are projected to spend almost $780 billion in 2026. Over each of the following four years, from 2027 through 2030, that figure is expected to exceed $1 trillion annually. Their strong cash flows, balance sheets, and market access should allow them to continue investing in AI.

II. The Middle East Wild Card

Another development amplifying risk-off sentiment today was escalating geopolitical tensions in the Middle East. *The New York Times* reported that the US and Israel have developed plans for possible renewed strikes against Iran following the November 3 midterm elections. Meanwhile, intensifying Houthi attacks on Saudi infrastructure prompted the US to order nonessential diplomatic personnel and their families to leave Saudi Arabia, while Saudi Aramco evacuated staff from its Dhahran headquarters.

The price of Brent crude oil jumped to $113.17 per barrel Thursday, while West Texas Intermediate crude rose to $103.95 (chart). That sent XLE, which we've recommended overweighting, to a new record high today.



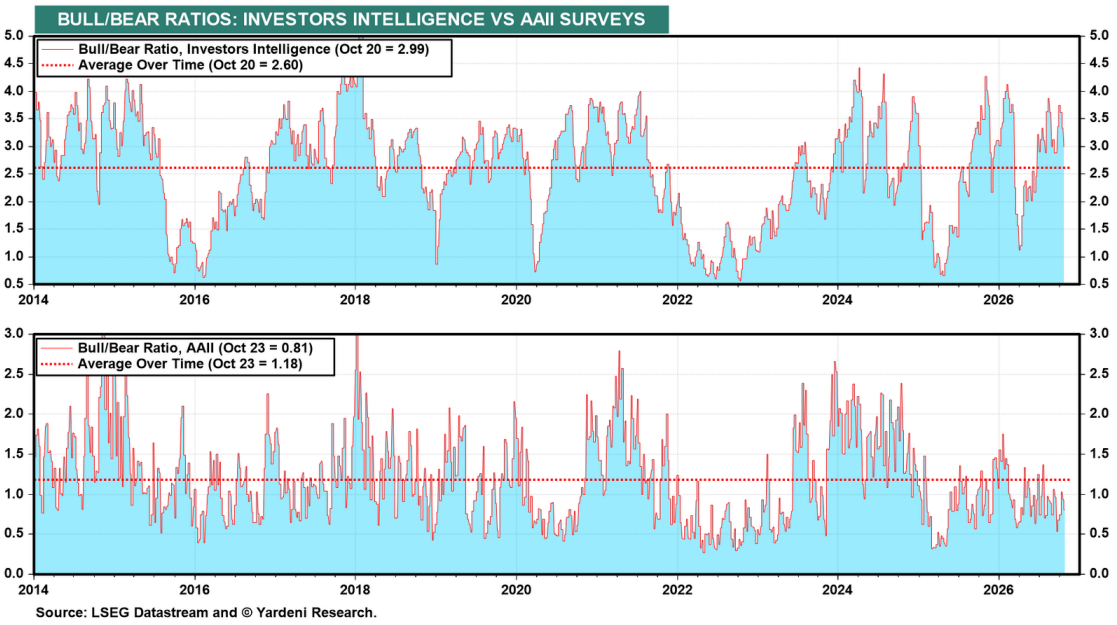
Yet, Kpler data cited by *The Wall Street Journal* showed Middle Eastern oil exports averaging more than 24 million barrels per day during the week through October 18, exceeding prewar levels of 23 million. Prices remain elevated partly because of higher shipping costs, but more importantly because of a geopolitical risk premium, reflecting concerns that such flows may not be sustained.

The bottom line is that the Middle East conflict remains a wild card. However, we expect US consumer spending and business investment to remain robust, while federal deficits of roughly 6% of GDP (during a solid economic expansion) provide additional economic stimulus.

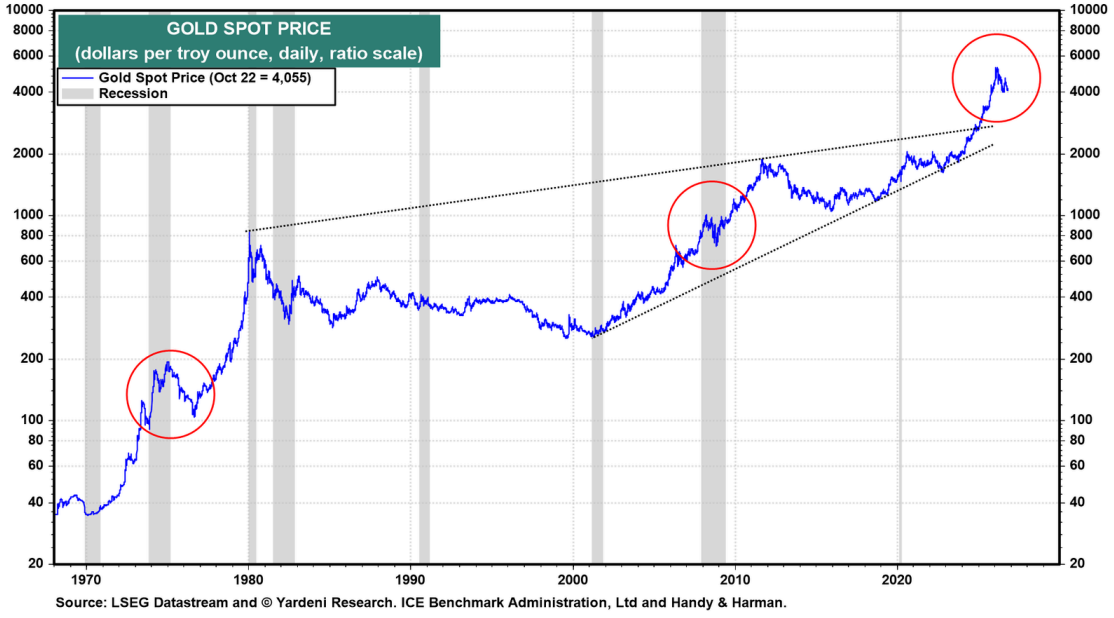
We expect the US economy will continue to pass the latest stress tests originating in the AI ecosystem and in the Middle East.

III. Miscellaneous

We expect to see lower bull-bear ratios next week after today's drubbing (chart). If they fall low enough, that might set the stage for a year-end rally. Then again, there might be a better opportunity to buy the dip when and if bombs start falling again in the Middle East.



Gold sold off on today's commotion even though interest rates fell (chart). We are expecting that the retest of $4,000 per ounce might hold and be a good entry point following this year's correction (chart).



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Andrew Lu on global Semi/Techs 10/17 曾分享費半指數差6.2%破7月份的最低點10445.4，今天收盤後剩下不到3%，更多半導體公司早已經破7月份低點，如果跌破沒支撐，短期真的就很難看，值得觀察的是從7月份超級財報週開始，公司只要公布符合預期或小幅高於預期的財報及營收獲利指引，都是以利多出盡下跌📉處理，即使超市場預期，也頂多來個一日行情，看起來10月超級財報週開始，歷史又重演一次，拉回幅度不遑多讓，7月份同樣的問題又浮出檯面，這到底是1. 基本面無虞，短期估值修正拉回；2. 還是AI擴張舞會即將結束，聰明錢跑路提前反應；你們覺得呢？ 我目前選 1，費半若跌破10000會持續定時定額，但會持續根據數據來關注AI舞會是否結束： 1. 每GW AI數據中心算力租用價格是否反轉下跌？目前是逐步上升； 2. AI數據中心算力租用 Backlog 積壓訂單增幅是否明顯減速； 3. Nvidia 如何處理親兒子 CoreWeave 的財務槓桿問題，是在旁看戲，還是積極參與無折價增資？目前還在看戲中，但肯定在運作增資 4. 財務結構差的Neocloud 是否能繼續擴產，還是被大雲併購而下市？目前還在繼續擴

產 5. Capital return on sales/profits 我們的專用指標是否惡化？目前持續改善中 6. 當AI數據算力中心資本開支增長趨緩後，這些公司的營收及獲利前景是否才開始爆發？目前資本開支動能還是遠遠高於營收/獲利增長動能。 最後就是我們認為要判斷半導體超級週期是否結束，要看他們的下游大客戶怎麼說/怎麼做，而不是看半導體產業鏈怎麼說/怎麼做。

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Date: 2 hours ago

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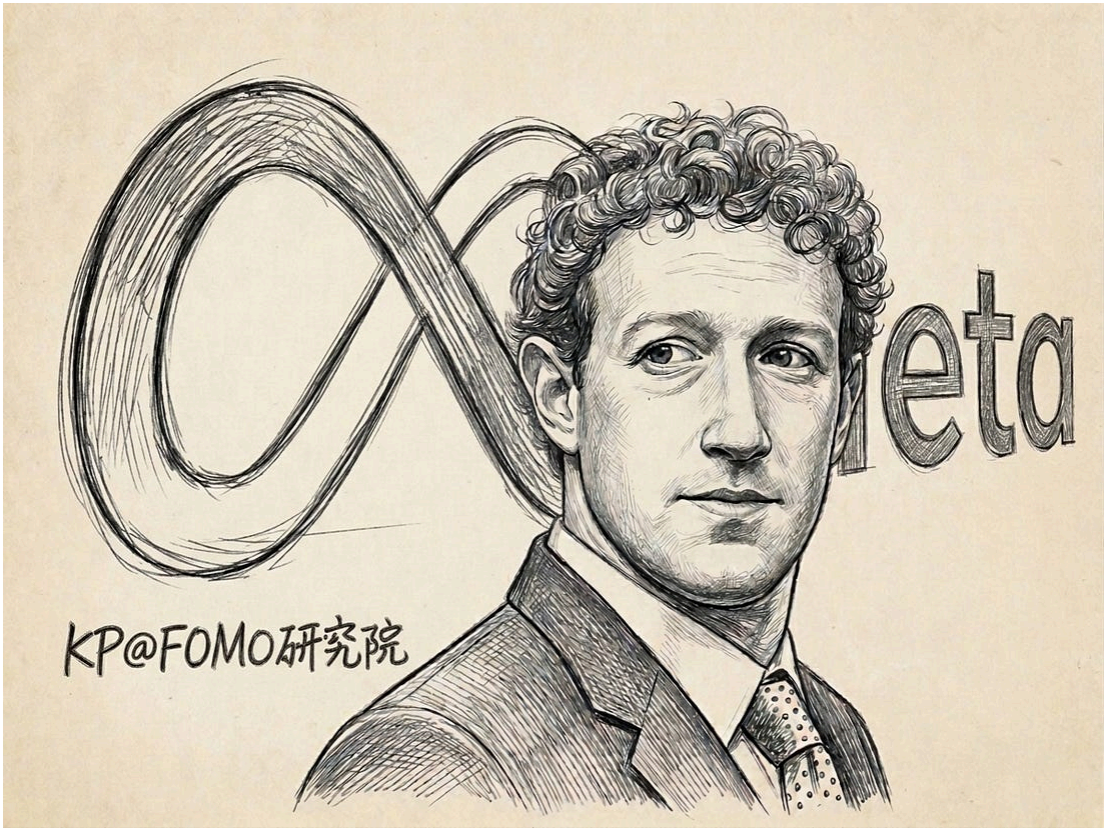
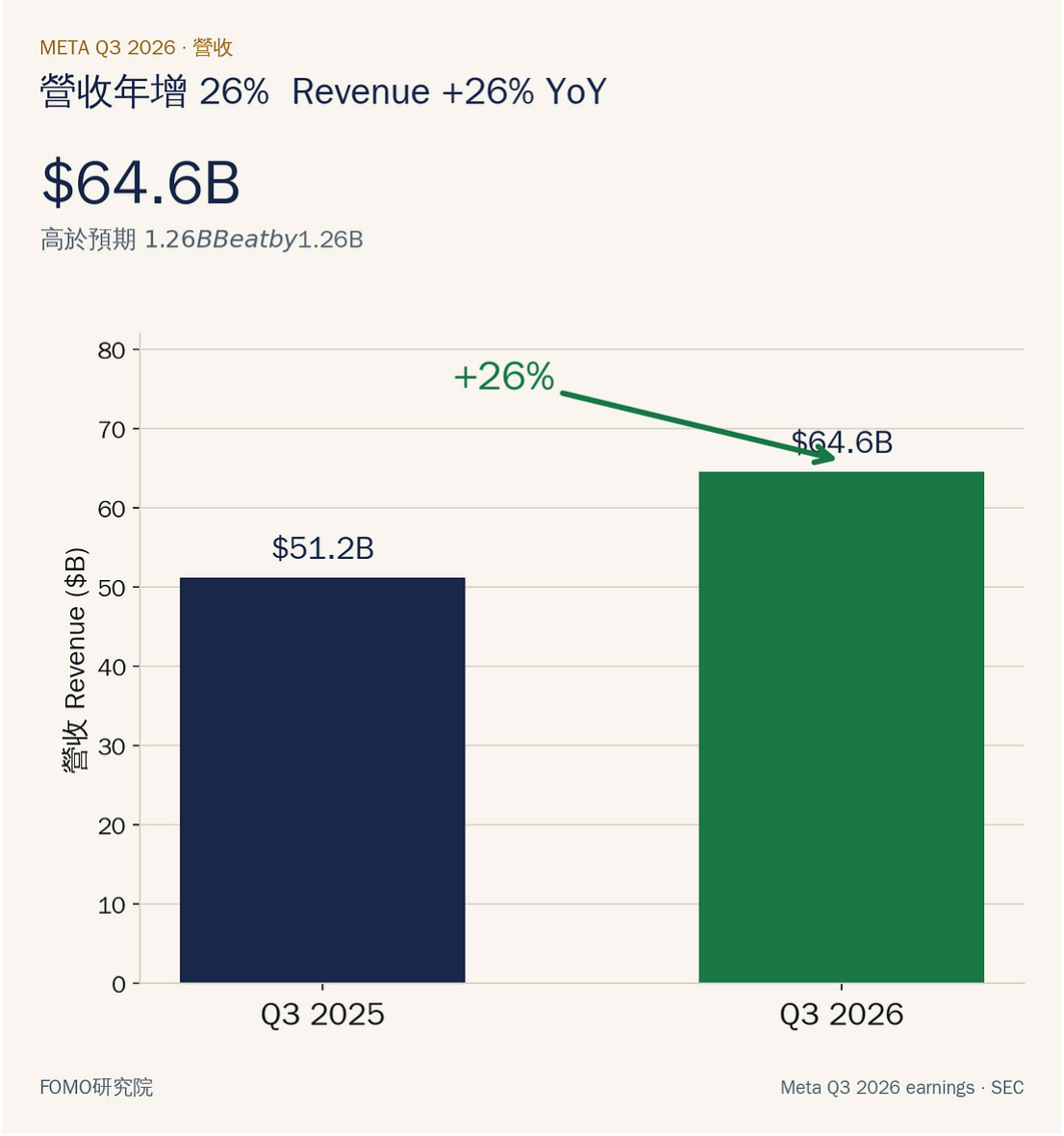


一家公司，營收年增 26%，廣告均價大漲 14%，最新推出的 AI 產品上線短短六週，就突破了千萬用戶。

但是，它的自由現金流卻是負的。



這家公司在第三季砸下去蓋資料中心、買伺服器的錢，竟然比本業賺進來的現金還要多。

更讓人意外的是，它同時宣布要發行一種「沒有投票權」的全新股票，悄悄替未來的融資預留空間。

這家公司的名字，叫 **Meta**。

我們先快速看一下這份讓人又愛又恨的成績單。

2026 年第三季，Meta 營收來到 646 億美元，年增 26%，硬生生比華爾街預期高出了 12.6 億美元。

Mark Zuckerberg 也終於交出了大家敲碗已久的 AI 產品數據：個人 AI 助理「Muse」在美國與加拿大上線僅僅六週，就有超過 1,000 萬人完成設定。

其中約四分之一的人每天都會使用，而最熱門的用途竟然是「買東西」，平均交易金額超過 200 美元。

與此同時，廣告本業完全沒有因為搞 AI 而分心。曝光次數年增 10%，平均廣告價格年增 14%。兩項相乘，帶動廣告收入年增將近 26%。

故事看到這裡，看起來非常美好，對吧？

但如果你把財報往下翻兩頁，會看到一組完全不同的數字。扣除一次性法律和解費後，Meta 的營業利益只年增了 11%。

算下來，每多賺 100 塊營收，只有 17.5 塊變成新增利潤。 第三季的自由現金流更是慘烈的「負 21 億美元」。

別忘了，去年同一季，這個數字可是「正 106 億美元」。

> **「產品在爆發，廣告在印鈔，現金卻在失血。」**

這幾件看似矛盾的事同時發生，究竟代表 Meta 現在處於什麼樣的位置？

接下來，我們用五個重點把這件事徹底拆解乾淨。

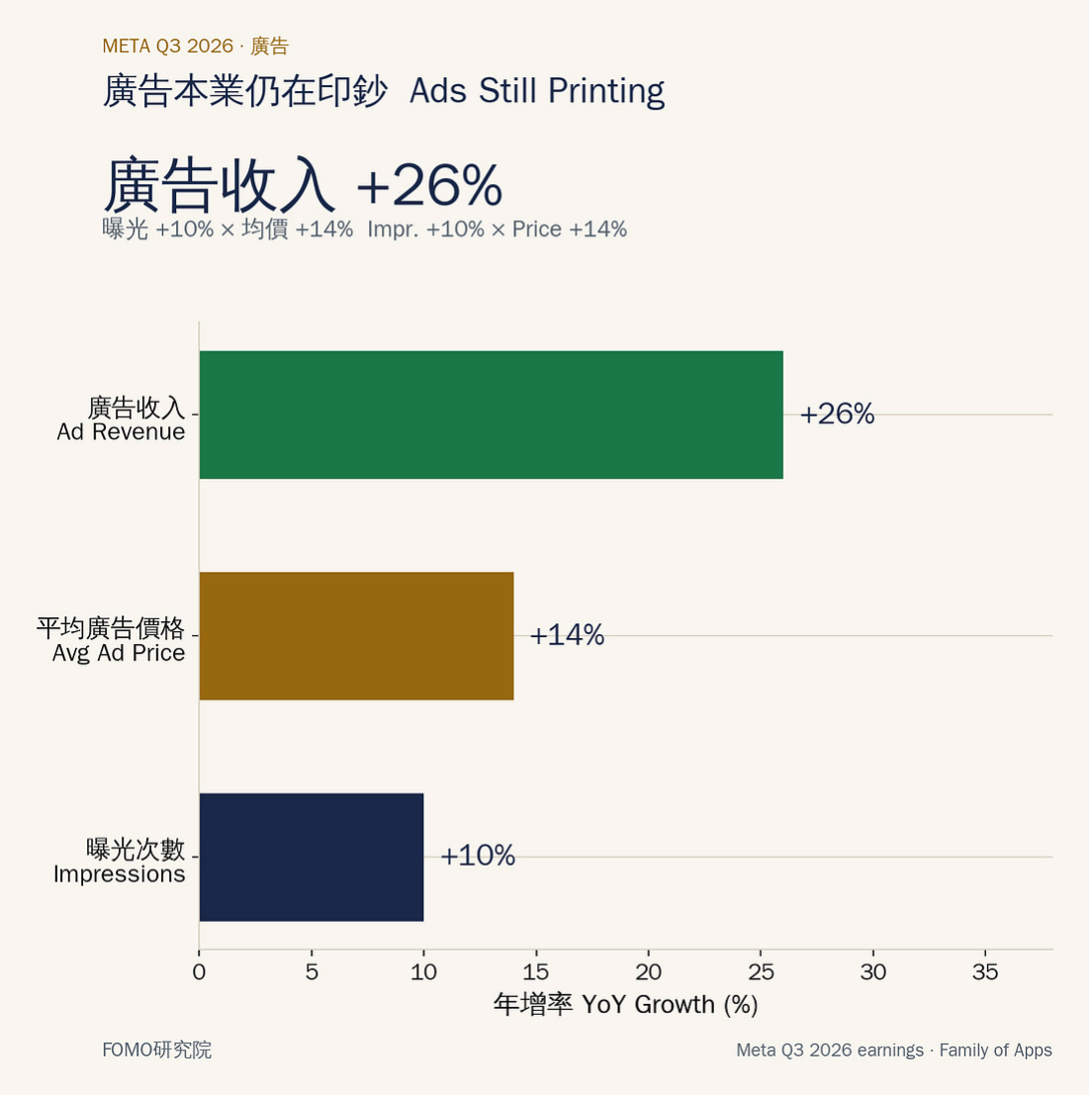
你會發現，每一個重點的結尾，都會自然帶出下一個問題的開頭。

重點一｜廣告越賣越貴，利潤卻只增 11%

1.1 拆解廣告印鈔機：量在放緩，價在狂飆

要看懂 Meta 的廣告收入，其實只要看一個簡單的乘法公式：

> **廣告收入 ＝ 廣告曝光次數 × 平均廣告價格**



在第三季，這兩個數字的年增率分別是多少？**曝光次數年增 10%，平均價格年增 14%。**

如果我們把時間拉長一點看，趨勢會更清楚。

今年前三季，曝光次數的成長率從 19% 逐步放緩到 14%，這季再掉到 10%。但在同一時間，平均廣告價格的年增率卻從 6% 一路加速衝上 14%。

方向完全相反：量在放緩，價在加速。

這背後的邏輯其實非常簡單。每個人一天就只有 24 小時，不管 Instagram 的短影音（Reels）再怎麼讓人上癮，你也不可能一天滑 30 個小時。

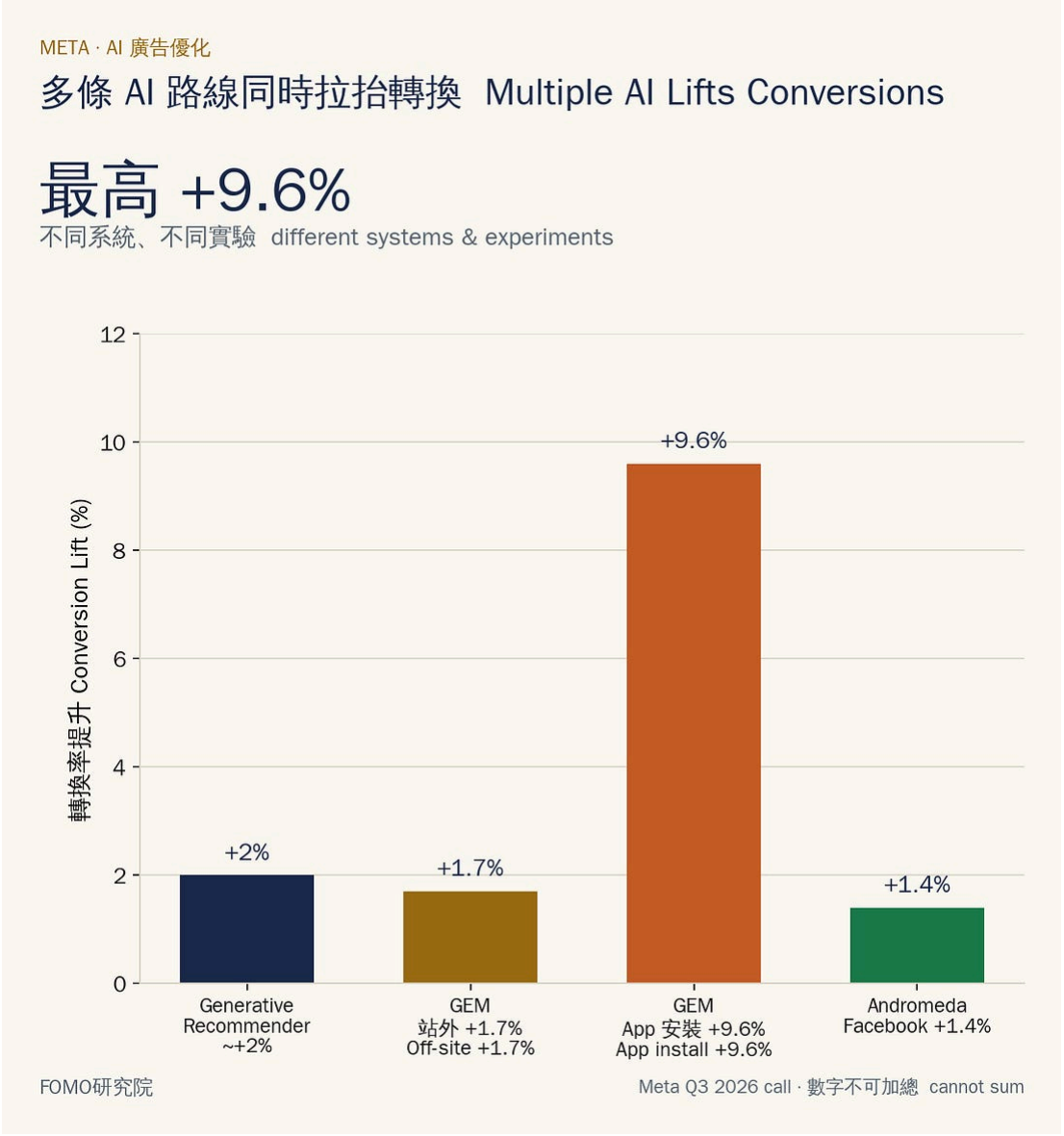
Meta 更不可能每兩支影片就塞十支廣告給你，否則大家早就把 App 刪光了。

既然不能無限增加廣告出現的「次數」，Meta 就必須讓每一次出現的廣告都「極度精準」。只有讓廣告主覺得這次曝光特別值錢，他們才願意在競價時出更高的價碼。

而讓廣告變精準的那台幕後機器，就是 AI。

1.2 AI 到底替廣告主多賺了多少錢？

在這次法說會上，財務長 Susan Li 罕見地公布了好幾組非常具體的數據：



- **Generative Recommender** 導入 Facebook Feed 的部分目標受眾後，廣告轉換率提升了接近 **2%**。
- **GEM 廣告排序模型**擴大應用後，站外轉換型廣告的轉換率提升 **1.7%**，App 安裝廣告更大幅增加了 **9.6%**。
- **Andromeda 廣告系統**升級，讓 Facebook 廣告轉換率提高了約 **1.4%**。

當然，這些數字分別來自不同系統和不同實驗受眾，我們不能直接把它們加總。但它們共同指向同一件事：**Meta 內部多條 AI 優化路線正在同時發威，對廣告主的投資回報率（ROI）產生了非常顯著的拉抬效果。**

此外，Meta 內部數據還顯示，採用「Meta AI Business Assistant」建議的廣告主，在維持相同單次轉換成本（CPA）的前提下，多拿到了約 5% 的轉換，同時也願意多投入約 9% 的廣告預算。

我們打個比方。假設你是一個賣衣服的網拍老闆，以前花 1,000 塊打廣告能賣出 100 件衣服；

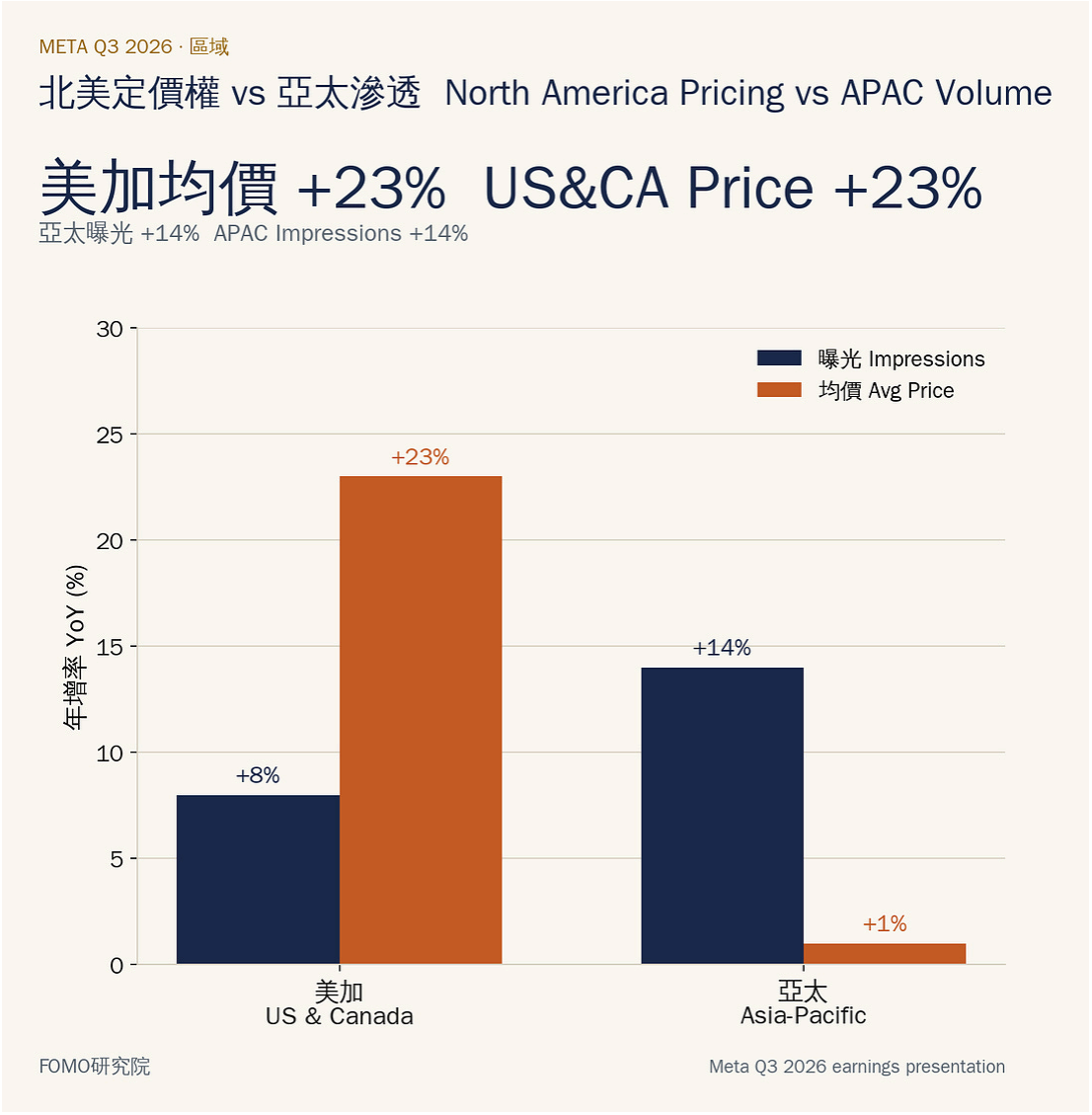
現在靠著 Meta 的 AI 變聰明，同樣花 1,000 塊可以賣出 105 件。只要每件衣服有利潤，你當然會願意把廣告預算加碼到 1,100 塊，甚至 1,200 塊。

這就是 Meta 賺錢的秘密：讓廣告主覺得「就算多花一點廣告費，依然很划算」。 當廣告主自願加碼，Meta 的平均廣告價格自然就水漲船高。

不過，Susan Li 也特別打了一劑預防針：本季廣告價格上升，除了歸功於廣告成效改善，也受到宏觀經濟環境回暖的幫忙。

換句話說，14% 的價格成長並非百分之百來自 AI。如果未來美國經濟放緩、企業開始縮減廣告預算，這個數字還是會面臨壓力。

1.3 攤開全球地圖：北美的「定價權」vs. 亞太的「滲透率」



如果我們把全球地圖攤開來看，區域之間的差異也十分有趣：

- **美國與加拿大：** 曝光量年增 8%，平均價格年增 **23%**。

- **亞太地區：** 曝光量年增 14%，平均價格年增 **1%**。

你看，北美是標準的「量穩價飆」，亞太則是「量漲價平」。這代表兩個市場正處在完全不同的變現階段。

北美廣告主的口袋深、支付能力強、轉換效果好，而且市場競爭成熟，所以每一次曝光都能拍賣出更高的價錢；

相反地，亞太地區雖然還有龐大的價格提升空間，但目前主要還是靠「用戶數與曝光量成長」在撐營收。

對投資人來說，這意味著 Meta 廣告業務的成長品質因地區而異。**北美展現的是強大的「定價權」，亞太展現的則是「滲透率」。** 兩者的成長天花板和潛在風險完全不同。

1.4 廣告以外的小金雞們，也在默默長大

除了核心廣告，Meta 旗下的其他產品線也在悄悄發力：

- **Threads：** 月活躍使用人數（MAU）已經正式超越 X（前身為 Twitter），每位使用者的使用時間年增超過 20%。
- **Instagram：** 全球每人平均使用時間再次創下歷史新高。
- **WhatsApp：** 帶動的應用程式家族其他收入（FoA Other Revenue）達到約 11 億美元，年增高達 59%。注意，這已經是實打實進入財報的真金白銀。
- **Creator Partnership Ads（創作者合作廣告）：** 這是另一個非常值得留意的數字，年化收入已經突破 150 億美元，年增超過 97%。品牌與創作者合作投放廣告的業務正在快速膨脹（不過這筆收入已經包含在廣告總營收中，我們在估值時不需要額外重複加計）。

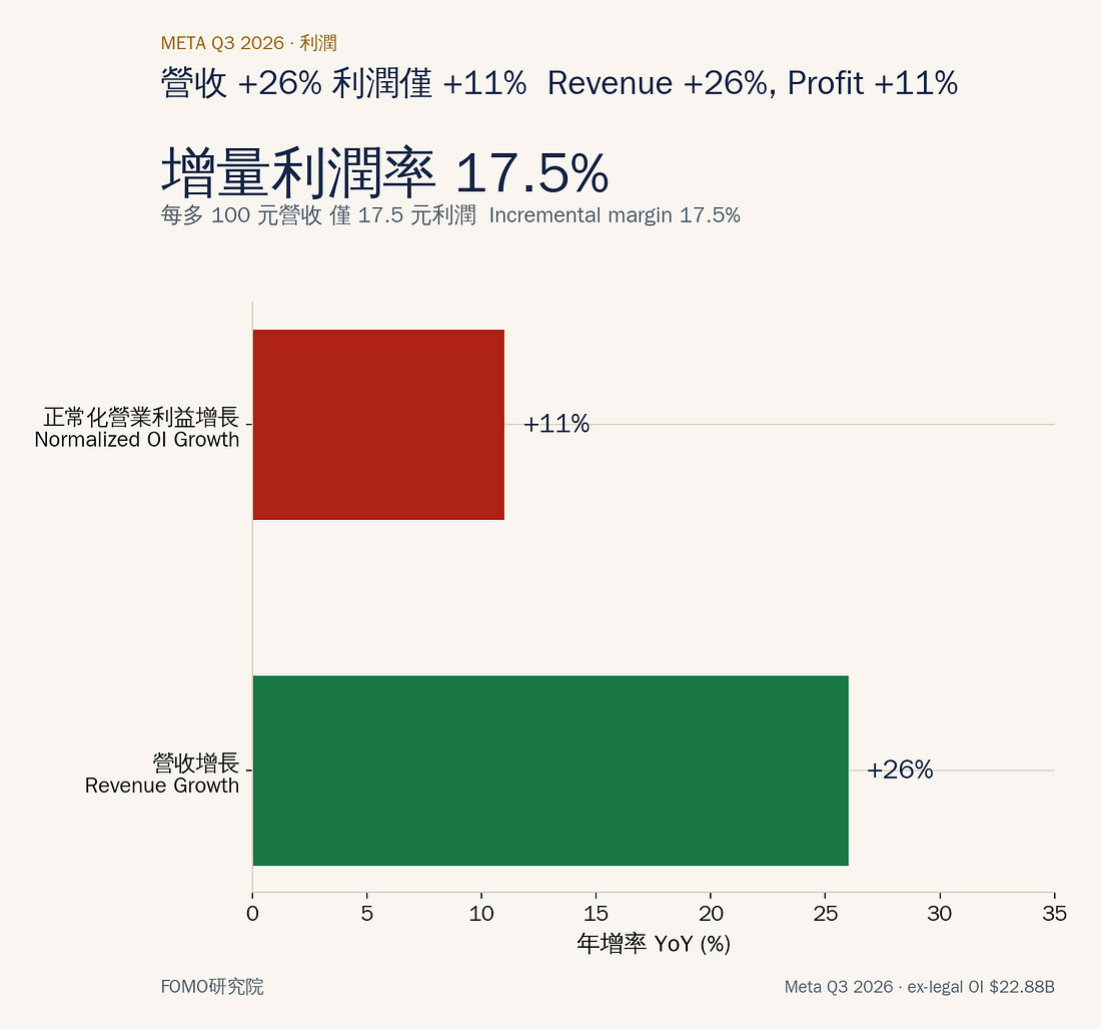
1.5 財報的驚人轉折：錢到底去哪了？

講到這裡，一切聽起來都順風順水。但請繫好安全帶，注意接下來的轉折。

營收年增 26%，那營業利益呢？

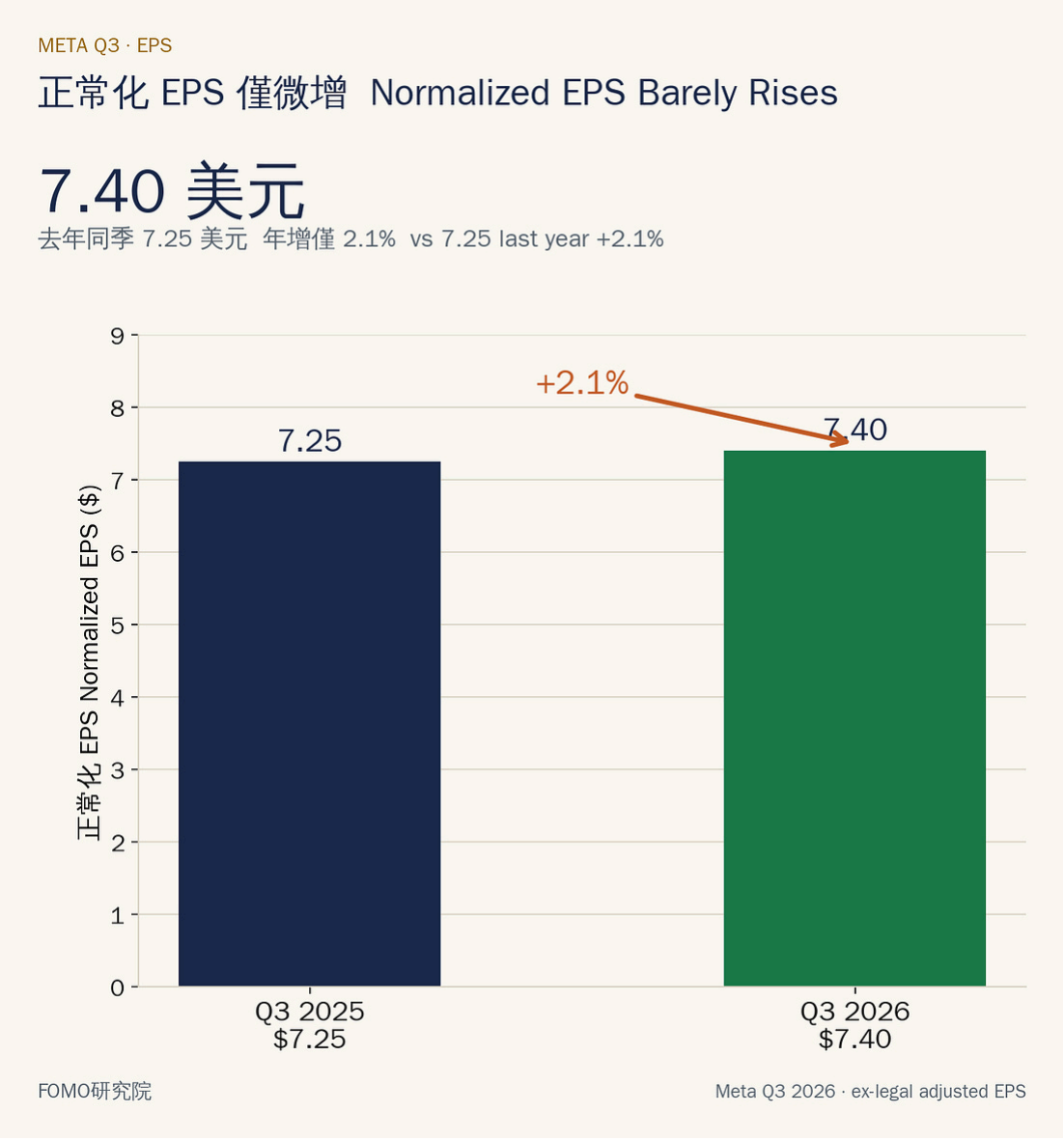
本季 Meta 認列了一筆高達 98.9 億美元的法律和解費用（與美國多州針對青少年心理健康的訴訟有關）。

就算我們把這筆一次性費用排除，算出來的「正常化營業利益」約為 228.78 億美元，**年增率也只有大約 11%。**



營收成長 26%，利潤卻只成長 11%。如果看每股盈餘（EPS）對比更強烈：去年第三季正常化 EPS 約 $7.25，今年是 $7.40，年增率只有微幅的 2.1%。

一家營收年增 26% 的科技巨頭，每股盈餘竟然幾乎在原地踏步。



我們再算得更精確一點。第三季營收比去年同期多賺了 133.59 億美元，但正常化營業利益卻只增加了約 23.43 億美元。

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23.43 ÷ 133.59 = 17.5%
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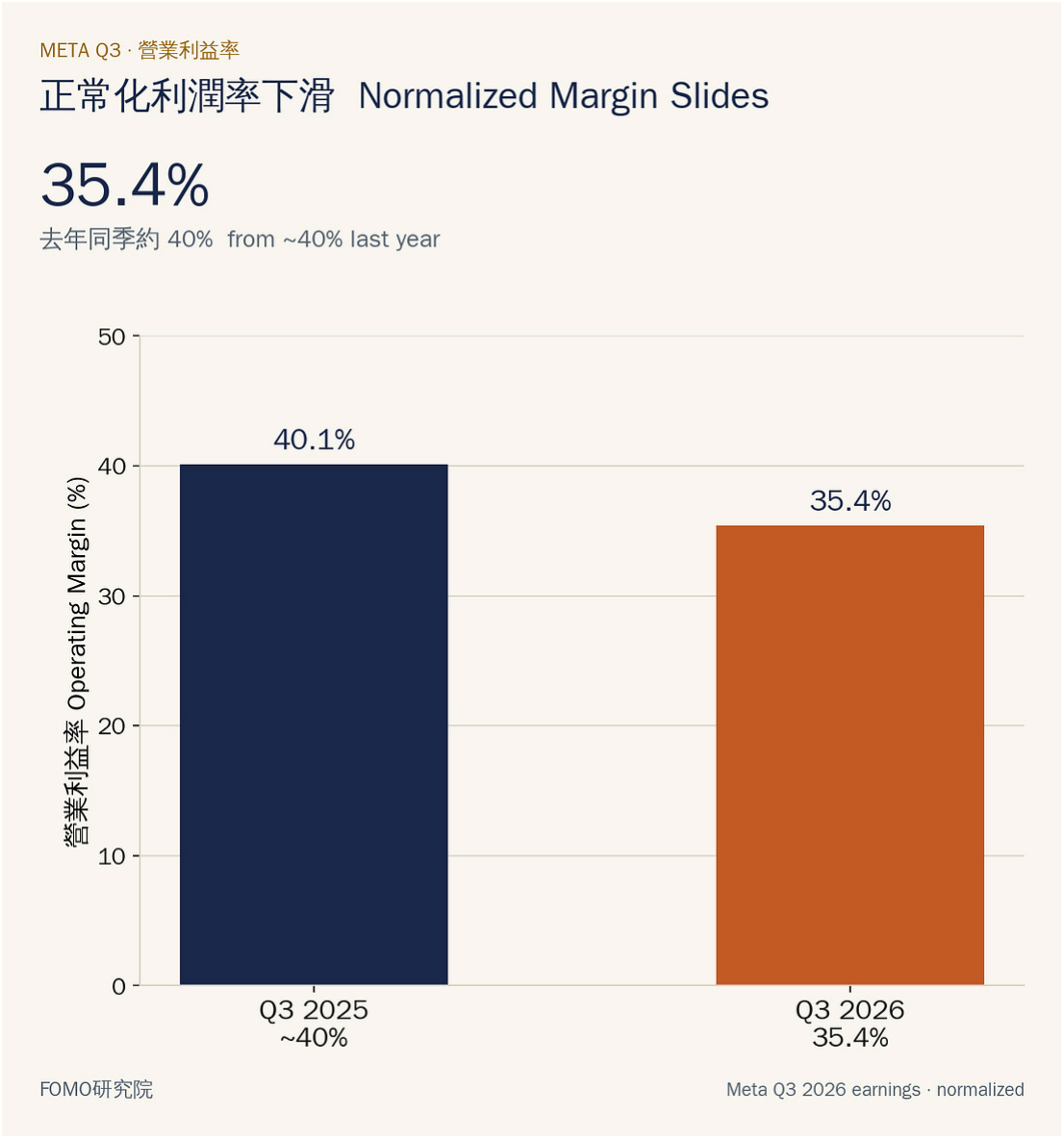
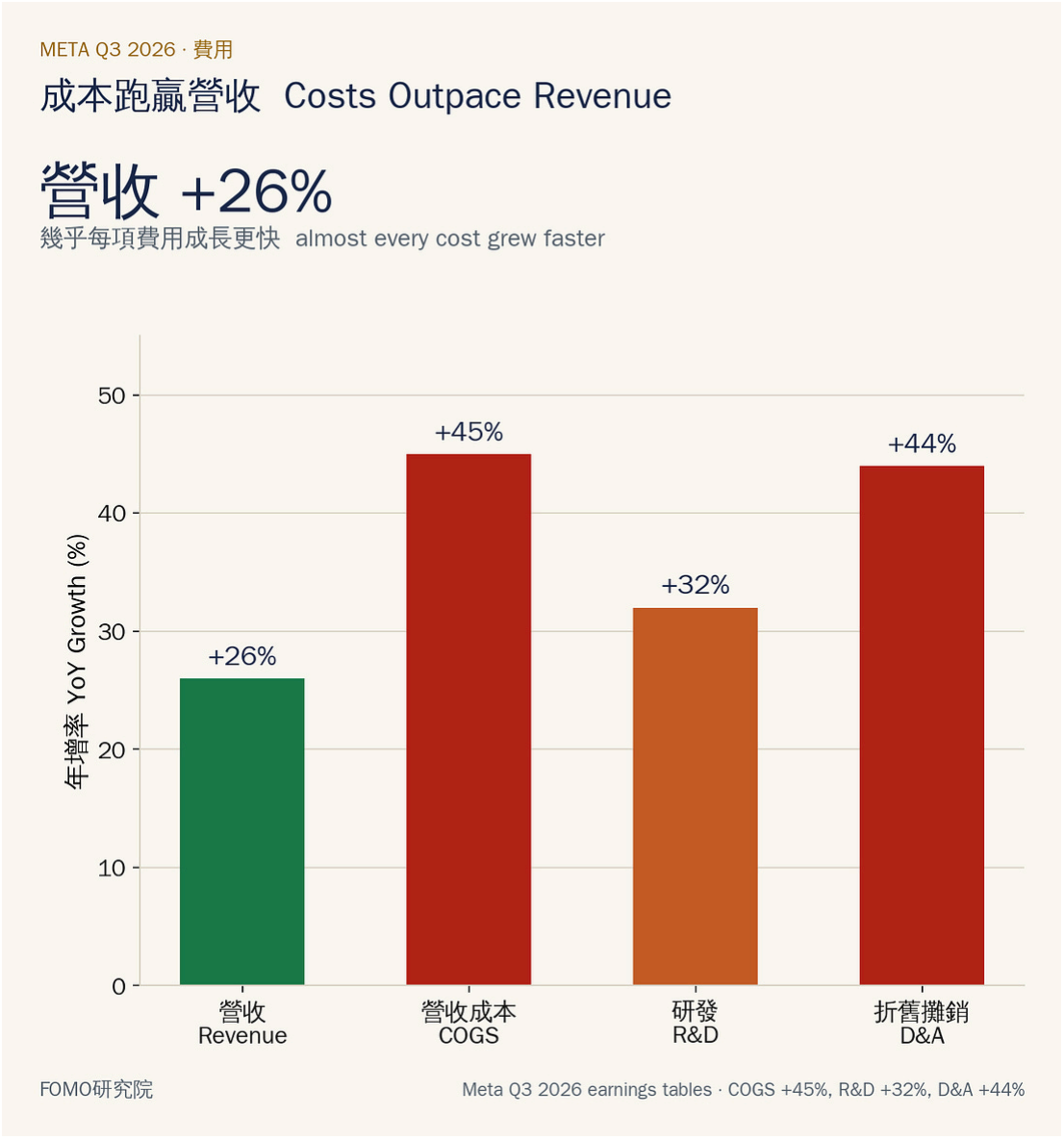
> **「每多賺 100 塊營收，只有 17.5 塊變成新增利潤。」**



換算下來，Meta 的正常化營業利益率從去年同期的約 40%，一路滑落到本季的 35.4%。這個數字，跟前面提到廣告業務強勁的印鈔表現，形成了非常刺眼的對比。

錢到底去哪了？

翻開費用結構，答案一目了然：**營收成本年增 45%，研發費用年增 32%，折舊攤銷更是年增 44%。** 幾乎每一項成本擴張的速度，都狠狠跑贏了營收的 26%。



Susan Li 在法說會上坦承，基礎設施成本、第三方雲端費用、推論算力支出，以及快速累積的硬體折舊，是本季費用飆升的元兇。

Meta 目前採取的策略是「雙管齊下」：一邊拼命擴建自有的資料中心，一邊向外部雲端供應商租用短期算力，好讓新產品不必苦等自家機房完工就能搶先上線。

這樣做的代價是短期費用率會偏高，但好處是產品部署的速度可以拉到最快。

於是，我們看到了一個畫面：**Meta 的廣告引擎正在全速運轉，但賺來的豐厚利潤，正被源源不絕地丟進下一個時代的基礎建設火爐裡。**

> **本節一句話總結：**
>
> **Meta 正在把過去的流量優勢，成功升級成「廣告定價權」，而 AI 就是背後那台漲價機器；但諷刺的是，這台機器本身，正在吞噬掉公司大量的現金。**

那麼，到底是有多少現金被吞掉了？這些砸下去的真金白銀，蓋出來的東西到底能不能賺回本？

答案，跟那個上線六週就破千萬用戶的新產品有關。

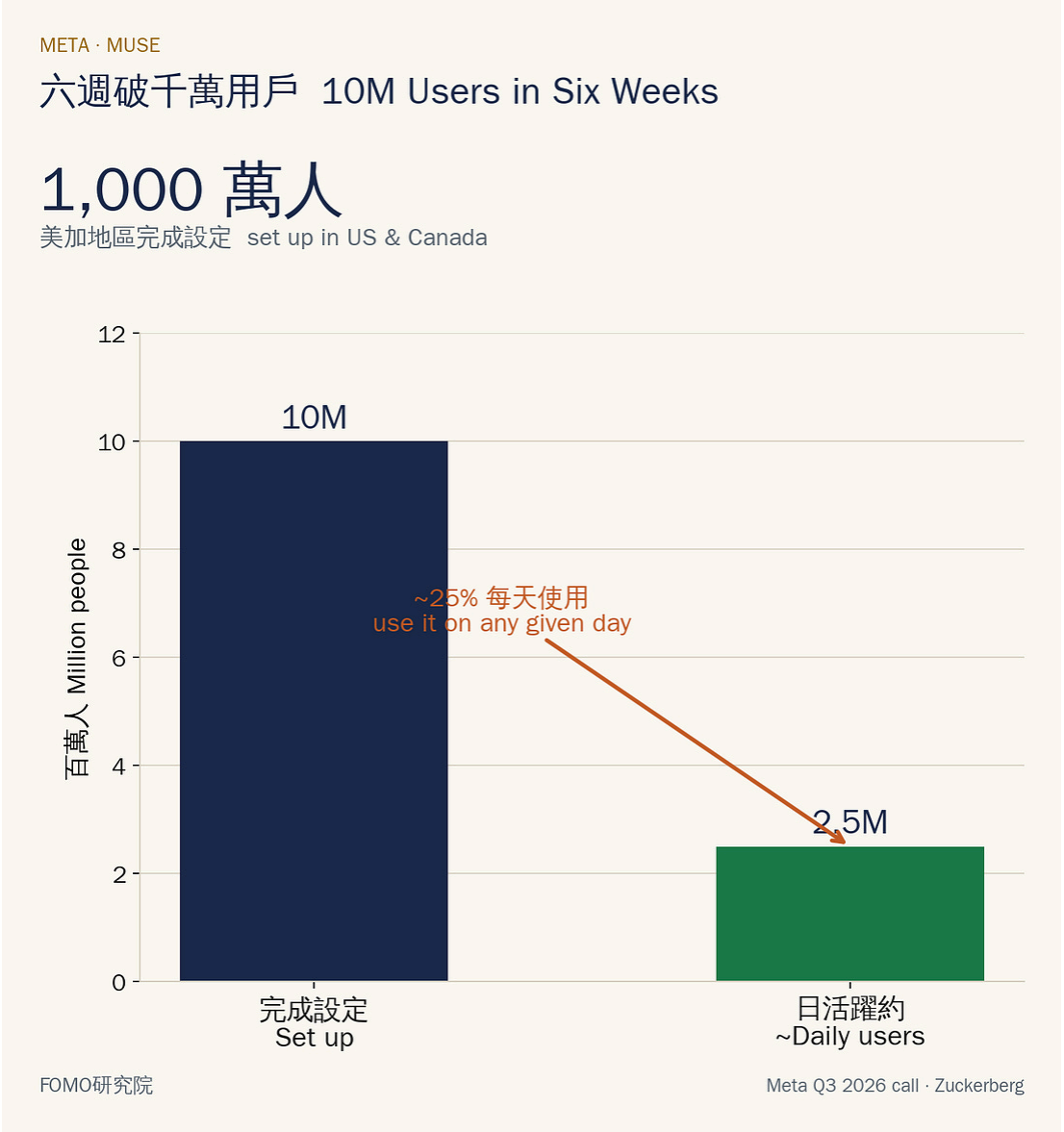
重點二｜Muse 六週破千萬用戶，但真正的問題是：每完成一筆交易能賺多少？

2.1 比 ChatGPT 還猛的開局，與「越用越離不開」的護城河

Muse 的用戶成長速度，比當初震撼全球的 ChatGPT 還要快。

在美國與加拿大上線僅僅六週，就有超過 1,000 萬人完成了個人 AI Agent（智慧代理）的設定。

更重要的是，其中大約有 25% 的人會在任何一天打開它來使用，換算下來，這已經是接近 **250 萬名日活躍用戶（DAU）** 的量級。



對一款甚至還沒在全球上線的新產品而言，這個起步力道非常強悍。

Zuckerberg 還透露了一個關鍵細節：**早期使用者的留存率，似乎會隨著使用時間拉長而改善。**

這點非常關鍵，因為 AI Agent 跟傳統的社群媒體有一個根本上的差異。

你可能會因為一時好奇下載某個 AI 聊天 App，玩個三天新鮮感過了，就再也沒打開過；

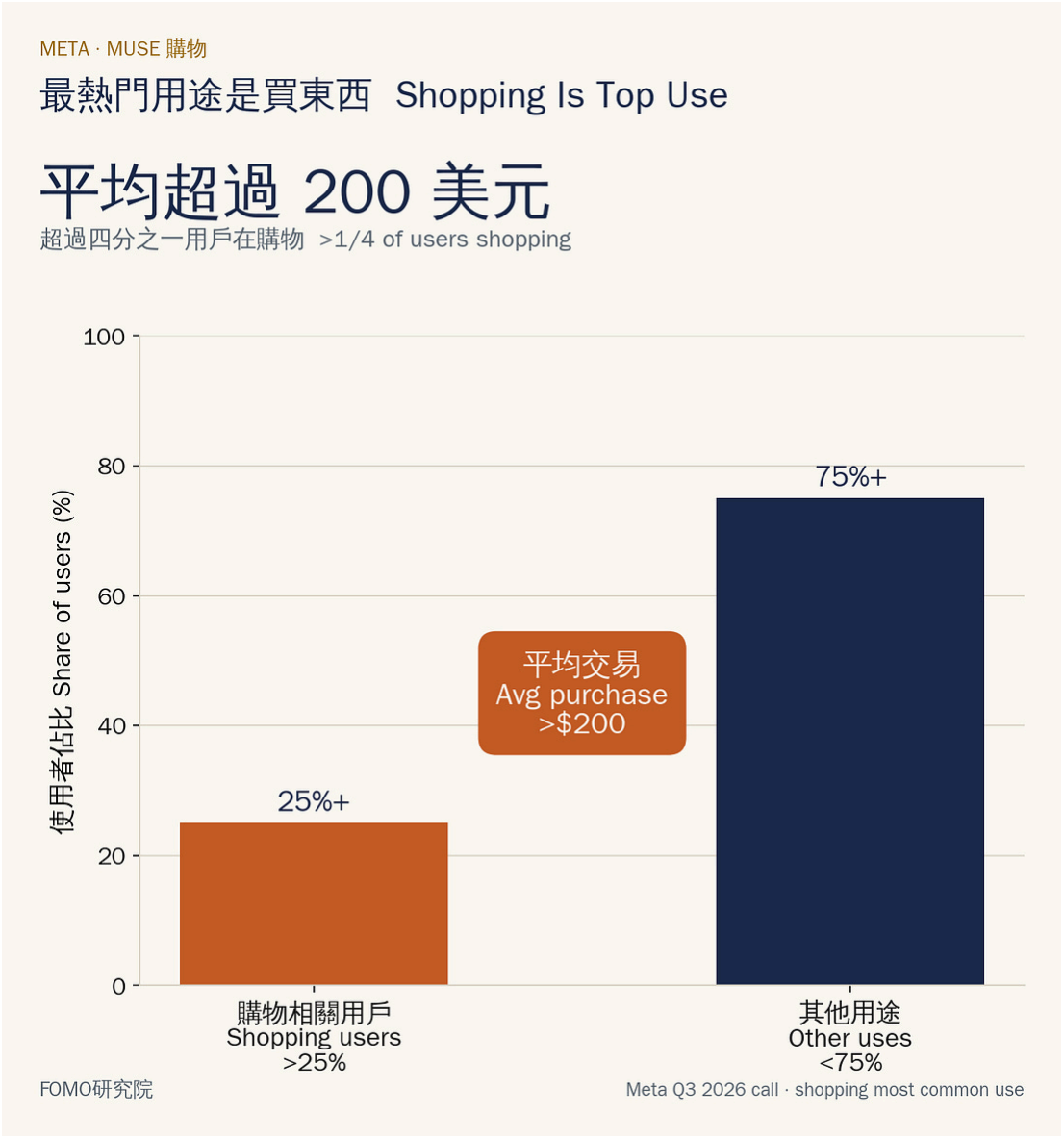
但如果一個 Agent 已經摸透了你的行事曆、購物習慣、工作流程，甚至每天都在替你打理生活大小事，你想要「換掉它」的轉換成本就會越來越高。

這正是 Meta 想要建立的長期黏著度。雖然六週的觀察時間確實還很短，但 Muse 顯然已經拿到了初步的「產品市場契合度（Product-Market Fit）」訊號。

2.2 真正的亮點：大家都在用它「買東西」

不過，真正重要的，是使用者都在拿 Muse 做什麼。

答案是：**超過四分之一的用戶，會用它來處理「購物相關」的任務，而且相關交易的平均購買金額超過 200 美元。**



Zuckerberg 也確認了這個數字包含「旅遊規劃」，而規劃旅行本身就是 Muse 最熱門的用途之一。

為什麼「購物」這個用途特別值得我們放大來看？

因為一般的 AI 聊天工具，通常都是從「回答問題」起步。

你問它歷史、請它寫寫文章、幫你整理會議資料。這些用途當然有價值，但商業化模式主要只能靠「收訂閱費」，營收的天花板相對明確。

但「購物」完全不同，購物本身就伴隨著真實的資金流動。

如果 Muse 能替消費者完成商品比較、查詢價格、預訂旅行，甚至直接獲得授權幫你刷卡付款，Meta 就有機會從每一筆交易中抽取佣金。

想像一下，過去你要買一張飛往東京的機票，得自己開搜尋引擎、打開好幾家航空公司網站、逛比價平台，慢慢交叉比對日期和價格。

現在使用 Muse，你只需要說一句：「幫我找十一月去東京最划算的機票，預算不要超過 1,500 美元。」Muse 就會在背後自己去搜尋、比價、確認條件，最後跳出視窗請你授權付款。

> **「如果這件事能大規模運作，Meta 就有機會從『幫商家賣廣告』，一躍跨足到『幫商家完成交易』。這是完全不同量級的商業機會。」**

2.3 每幫你買一次東西，Meta 要倒貼多少錢？

故事聽起來很性感，但請記住：**交易金額（GMV），不等於 Meta 放進口袋的錢。**

這裡有一條非常現實的單位經濟公式：

> **單筆交易貢獻利益 ＝ 成交金額 × 實收佣金率 − Agent 執行成本 − 支付與服務成本**

經營 AI Agent 的成本關鍵，不在於一開始那筆一次性的模型訓練費，而在於**每完成一項任務，都要持續消耗的「推論算力（Inference Compute）」**。

當你請 Muse 規劃一趟東京旅行，它在背景可能需要呼叫模型數十次——搜尋航班、比較飯店、讀取網友評論、聯繫商家、反覆驗證結果。

這每一次的呼叫，都在實打實地燃燒昂貴的 GPU 資源。

所以，擺在 Meta 眼前真正的考題是：當用戶規模從千萬擴展到數億、甚至十億人時，就算每項任務只花掉幾美分，一年累積下來也可能是數十億美元的恐怖費用。

推論效率的改善速度，將直接決定這門生意到底是印鈔機，還是碎鈔機。

德意志銀行（Deutsche Bank）就曾算過一筆帳：部分重度使用者每個月消耗的推論成本，可能高達 **40 美元以上**。

我們假設商家願意支付 2% 的交易佣金好了，這代表這位重度用戶每個月必須透過 Muse 完成 **2,000 美元** 的交易（大約是 10 筆 200 美元的訂單），Meta 才能勉強「打平」他消耗的推論成本，而且這還沒算進刷卡的支付手續費和客服成本。

面對這個質疑，Zuckerberg 這次給出了一個非常大膽的目標：**未來一年，Muse 的運算效率要提升超過 10 倍。**

如果真的做到，代表今天完成一項任務要花 1 美元，明年就只需要 10 美分。這將給 Meta 更大的空間去提供免費服務，或是賺取更健康的毛利率。

目前其實已經有一個初步的成功驗證：Meta 將部分「內容理解」的工作負載導入自研模型後，**單位處理成本大幅下降了超過 80%**。

這證明他們的 AI 研究能力，確實正在轉化成真實的成本優勢。

財務長 Susan Li 也補充了具體的省錢方法，包括：利用離峰時段的閒置算力、把簡單任務交給更小的模型處理、改善底層推論技術，以及提高 GPU 的整體使用率。

2.4 一魚五吃：Meta 的全方位變現藍圖

那麼，當成本壓下來之後，Meta 打算怎麼從 Muse 身上賺錢？

Zuckerberg 在這次法說會上，把商業模式描繪得比過去清楚得多，大致可以歸納為**五條變現路線**：

1. **免費個人 Agent：** 靠商家交易佣金與導購變現。
2. **付費訂閱制：** 讓重度用戶花錢解鎖更強大的模型與算力。
3. **Muse Business：** 面向中小企業的商業版服務。
4. **開發者 API 與企業服務：** 把底層能力租給其他公司。
5. **賦能既有廣告系統：** 收集更精準的意圖，直接拉升廣告轉換率。

這五條路線，全部共用同一套底層模型。

龐大的研發成本可以被多條收入線共同分攤，這是 Meta 相較於其他純 AI 新創公司最大的「結構性優勢」。

別人還得從零開始找用戶、建通路，但 Meta 手上早就握有數十億用戶、約 5 億個自我標示為商家的帳戶，以及地表最成熟的廣告投放系統。

Zuckerberg 也坦言，這次 Muse 的商業化會比過去的新產品「更早啟動」。

一方面是因為 Agent 的算力成本實在太高，不能無止盡免費補貼；另一方面則是因為購物場景本身就自帶交易收入，變現水到渠成。

不過，看到這裡我們還是要保持冷靜。所謂的「5 億商家」只是潛在觸及規模，不代表已經有 5 億個付費客戶等著掏錢。

而且 Muse 目前也只在美加地區上線，Zuckerberg 坦承 Agent 的運算成本依然偏高，必須先把效率提上來、並完成各國市場的在地化與服務整合，才有本錢往全球更多國家擴展。

2.5 華爾街最尖銳的拷問：商家憑什麼讓你分一杯羹？

整場法說會上最尖銳、也最直擊靈魂的一個問題，來自高盛（Goldman Sachs）。

分析師 Eric Sheridan 直接把話挑明：

當各大電商平台或品牌供應商都想死守自己的「顧客關係」與第一手數據時，Meta 要怎麼讓 Agent 進得去？商家到底為什麼要讓 Meta 介入自己的生意？

Zuckerberg 的回答是，目前反而有不少商家「主動」尋求與 Muse 整合，因為他們發現 Agent 可以替他們帶來原本接觸不到的「增量新客戶」。

Susan Li 則在旁補充了一個關鍵武器：Meta 正在和 **Shopify、Stripe、Walmart** 等重量級夥伴，共同推動一套名為 **「Personal Agent Protocol（個人代理協定）」** 的標準。

這套協定能讓消費者的 Agent 透過授權 API，直接與商家的 Agent 進行對話與交易，**同時讓商家完全保留對自己客戶資料的控制權。**

這個商業邏輯的核心，是把 Muse 的定位從「搶走商家顧客入口的掠奪者」，轉型成「替商家帶來新增訂單的合作夥伴」。

只要 Agent 真的能幫老闆們多賣東西，Meta 未來要收取導購費或交易佣金，就有了堅實的談判籌碼。

> **本節一句話總結：**

> **Muse 最有價值的突破，是成功把「AI 使用量」與「真實購物意圖」綁在一起，讓 Meta 有機會從廣告平台延伸到交易平台；但這場仗能不能贏，取決於推論成本下降的速度，能不能跑贏用戶規模擴張的速度。**

好，現在產品有了，千萬用戶有了，連賺錢的商業模式都畫出來了。

但別忘了，要把這一切美好願景全部跑起來，背後需要的是天文數字般的伺服器、資料中心和電力。

而這些東西的帳單，已經開始寄到 Meta 的辦公桌上了。

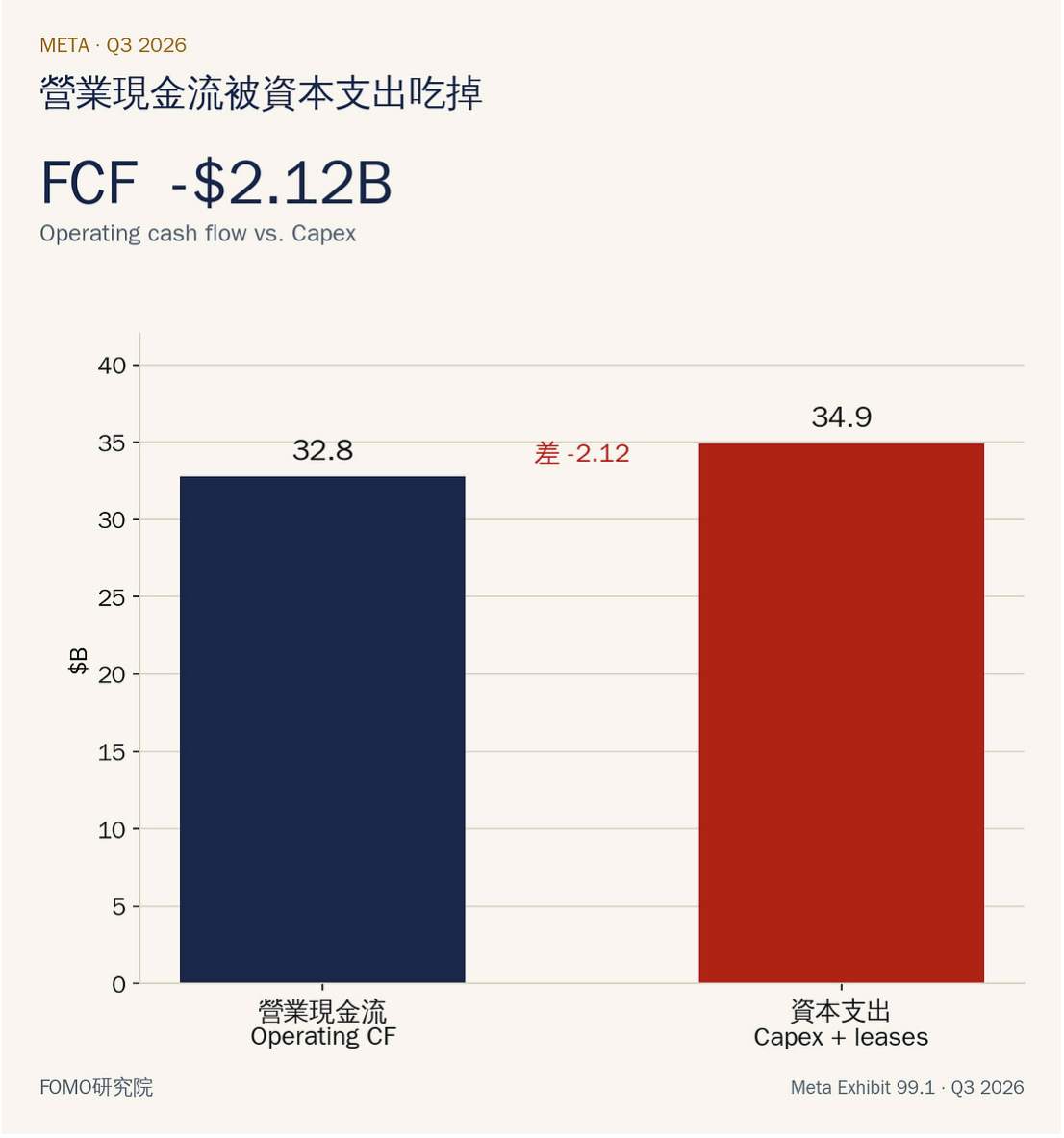
重點三｜自由現金流轉負，第四季還要再砸近 500 億：帳單來了

3.1 印鈔機突然熄火？自由現金流正式轉負

我們不講廢話，直接來看最殘酷的數字。

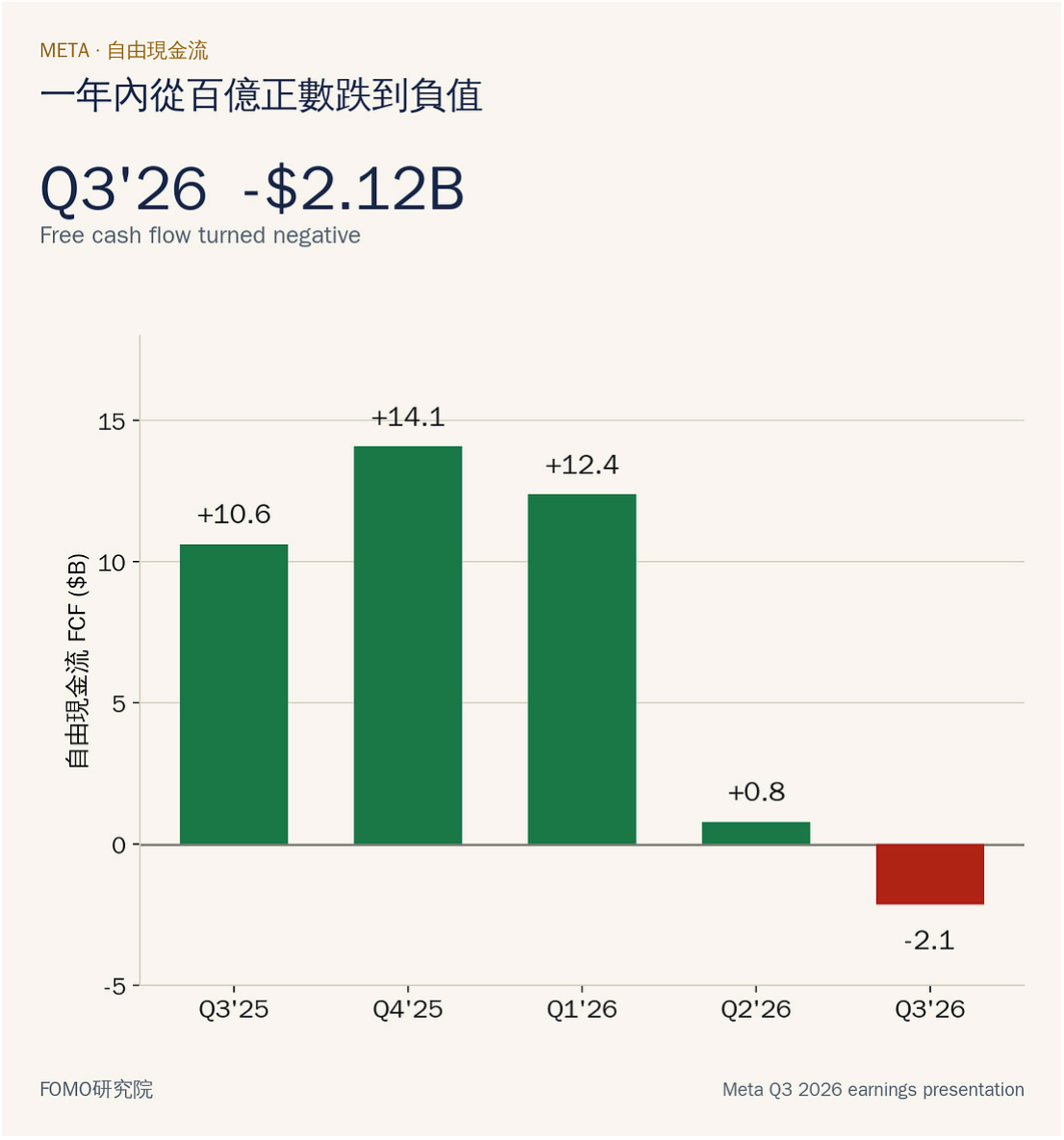
第三季，Meta 靠本業賺進來的營業現金流大約是 327.86 億美元。

單看這個數字其實非常強，但問題是，同一季他們花在買設備、蓋機房的資本支出（包含融資租賃本金），高達 **349.06 億美元**。



兩者一減，**Meta 第三季的自由現金流（Free Cash Flow），正式跌入負值，來到 -21.2 億美元。**

如果我們把時間軸拉長來看，這個變化的速度更是讓人觸目驚心：



- **2025 Q3：** +106.25 億美元
- **2025 Q4：** +140.77 億美元
- **2026 Q1：** +123.86 億美元
- **2026 Q2：** +7.84 億美元
- **2026 Q3：** **−21.20 億美元**

短短一年之內，Meta 從一間「每季可以輕鬆產生超過百億美元自由現金」的富裕巨頭，變成了單季要「倒貼超過 20 億美元」的公司。

過去華爾街投資人之所以這麼愛 Meta，很大一個原因就是它根本是一台強大的「現金製造機」。

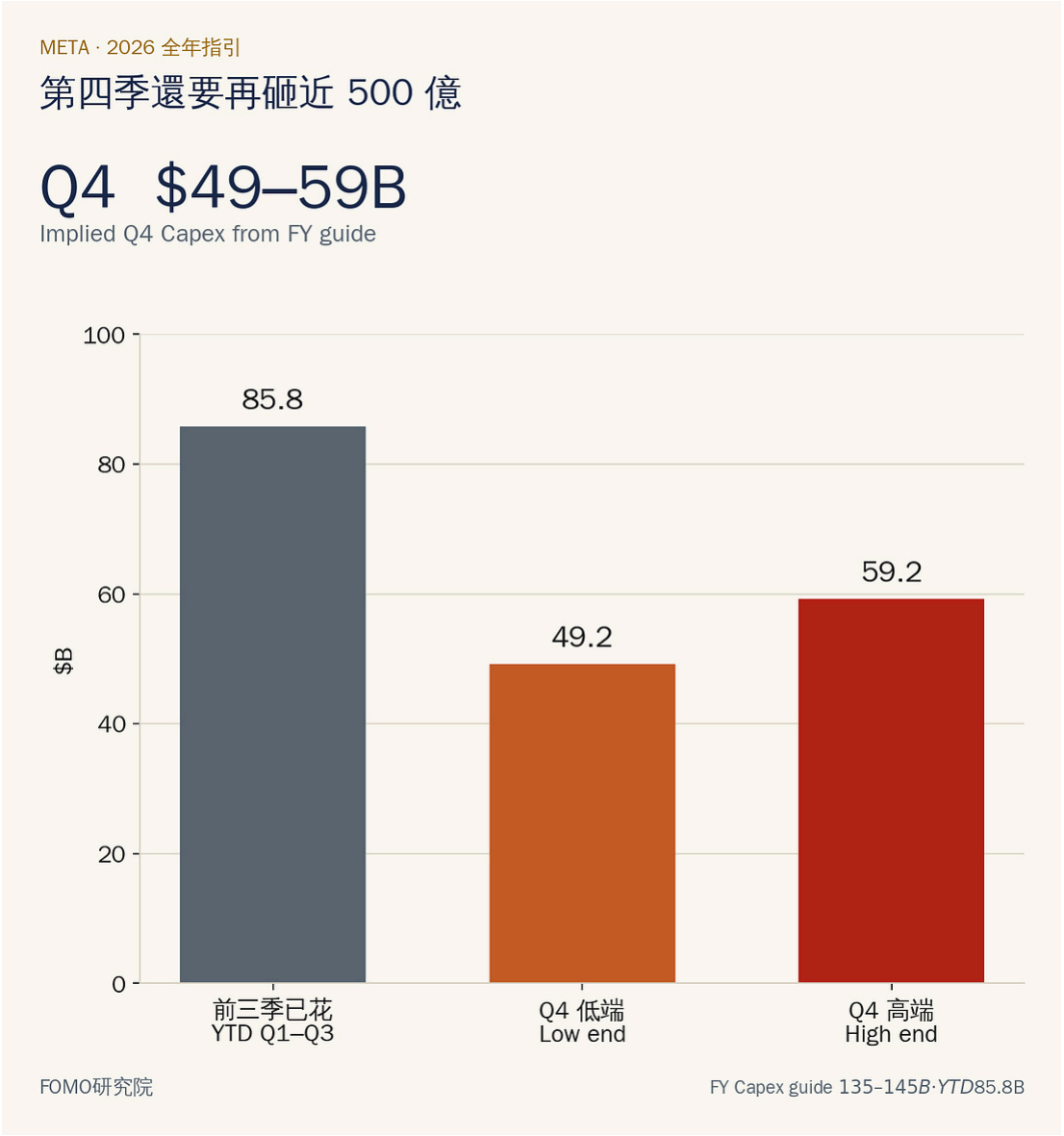
廣告本業源源不絕印出來的鈔票，不僅足以養活 Reality Labs（元宇宙部門）連年的巨額虧損，還有大把餘裕可以買回自家股票、甚至發放股利給股東。

但現在，這台印鈔機的輸出端，已經徹底被 AI 基礎建設恐怖的吸金速度給壓過去了。

3.2 史上最兇猛的燒錢季即將到來，而且「還看不到天花板」

你以為第三季已經夠誇張了嗎？**第四季還會更猛。**

Meta 在這次法說會上，把 2026 全年的資本支出指引微調到 **1,350 億至 1,450 億美元**。我們都知道，今年前三季他們已經花掉了大約 858 億美元。



這意味著什麼？我們拿計算機簡單算一下：光是在第四季這短短三個月內，Meta 就必須再砸下 **492 億至 592 億美元**。

這比剛剛創下紀錄的第三季（349 億），還要再暴增 **41% 到 70%**。

> **「毫無疑問，2026 年的最後三個月，將會是 Meta 創辦以來，單季花錢最兇狠的一段時間。」**

看到這種燒錢速度，摩根大通（J.P. Morgan）的分析師 Doug Anmuth 在法說會上忍不住追問：

那 2027 年到底還要投多少錢？過去管理層曾說過 2026、2027 年會積極擴建，到了 2028 年才會有比較大的財務彈性，現在能不能先給投資人一個大概的範圍？

財務長 Susan Li 的回答非常官方：2027 年的具體數字，要等到第四季法說會才會公布。目前公司內部正在評估多項不同投資期限的提案，希望能在年度預算內支持更多計畫。

把這段公關辭令翻譯成白話文就是：「我們現在還沒打算告訴你，這波燒錢的天花板到底在哪裡。」

3.3 藏在財報附註裡的震撼彈：數千億美元的「隱形帳單」

看到這裡你可能會問：Meta 帳上還有錢嗎？

如果只看資產負債表，帳面上的現金確實還夠用。截至第三季末，Meta 手上還握有約 **824.5 億美元** 的現金與有價證券；長期債務帳面約 809 億美元，總債務約 837 億美元。整體的資金調度能力依然相當充裕。

但真正重要的細節，其實藏在 SEC 季報的「合約承諾附註」裡。

根據截至 2026 年 6 月底的 10-Q 財報文件揭露：

- **尚未開始生效的租賃義務：** 約 2,790 億美元。
- **不可取消的合約承諾：** 約 3,493 億美元（其中有約 817 億美元安排在 2027 年到期支付）。
- **7 月份最新簽下的資料中心租賃：** 又新增了約 680 億美元。
- **或有雲端容量採購義務：** 另有最高約 147 億美元。

雖然這些數字的會計性質不同、涵蓋的時間跨度也不同，我們不能直接拿來全部加總；但它們共同傳遞了一個極度強烈的訊號：

Meta 已經透過具有法律約束力的合約，提前把未來好幾年的算力與機房資源，死死地鎖在自己手裡了。

為什麼要提前鎖定這麼龐大的規模？

Meta 為了確保未來幾年有足夠的產能，它必須現在就出面簽下土地、包下電廠、蓋好廠房，並跟設備供應商簽訂長約。

因為如果你等到「確定有需求」的時候才去買，市場上可能早就沒貨了，或者價格已經被競爭對手炒到天價。

在這場 AI 基礎設施的軍備競賽裡，誰能準時拿到電力、機房和 GPU，誰就能決定新產品推進市場的速度。

Meta 選擇用「天價合約」來換取未來的「供應確定性」；但背後的代價就是，萬一未來 AI 需求不如預期，這些已經白紙黑字簽下的租金與採購款，依然得硬著頭皮付出去。

3.4 先付錢、後收錢的痛苦期：當網路巨頭變成「重資產公司」

這種商業模式，跟台積電、美光（Micron）或艾司摩爾（ASML）這些硬體軍火商有一個根本上的差異。

半導體公司是可以拿著客戶的「預付款」和「長期採購訂單」來驗證需求、才去擴產的。

但 Meta 的模式完全相反，它必須**「先掏錢」**建立起一個能服務數十億用戶的龐大 AI 平台，然後才慢慢從提升的廣告效率、用戶訂閱費與抽成交易中，把投入的錢一塊一塊賺回來。

所以，未來我們要衡量 Meta 這些天價建設到底值不值得，看的不是「訂單能見度」，而是這四個指標：**活躍用戶數、每項任務的推論成本、商業化收入，以及算力利用率。**

而這裡，就產生了一個讓投資人非常難受的**「時間差」**。

現在，真金白銀已經在以百億美元為單位大量流出了；但一座新的資料中心從破土動工到正式插電運轉，往往需要好幾個季度、甚至更久的時間。

等昂貴的伺服器買進來了，會計上的「折舊」才正要開始；而真正的營收，卻要等到產品上線、用戶養成付費習慣、廣告主願意加碼預算之後，才會慢慢反映在財報上。

所以在未來的幾個季度裡，我們很可能會不斷看到這種精神分裂的現象：**Meta 的營業現金流依然很強，但自由現金流卻被龐大的資本支出壓得喘不過氣；同時，損益表上的「折舊費用」會逐季攀升**，因為前幾季瘋狂買進的設備，開始要算進成本裡了。

> **「更危險的一個變數是：如果 AI 模型迭代的速度持續加快，部分舊款 GPU 的『實際經濟壽命』可能會比會計上估計的還要短。這會讓折舊攤提的壓力，比市場目前預期的更早、更猛烈地炸開來。」**

但請注意，這並不代表 Meta 的本業變差了。這只代表它正處在一個轉型為「先付錢、後收錢」的重資產建設週期。

另外還有一個小地雷要留意：本季財報上認列了一筆高達 **98.9 億美元的法律和解費用**。

目前這筆錢主要還停留在「會計帳面」上的認列，等未來某個季度真正要從銀行帳戶把現金匯出去時，自由現金流還會再面臨一次額外的擠壓。

> **本節一句話總結：**
>
> **Meta 正在把過去引以為傲的「現金製造能力」，大規模轉換成未來幾年的「AI 算力供應確定性」；短期內自由現金流將持續承壓，真正的投資回報，必須等產能上線、產品變現之後才看得到。**

好，現在問題來了：光靠本業賺來的現金，顯然已經不夠支付這張天文數字般的 AI 帳單了。但Mark Zuckerberg 顯然完全不打算踩煞車。

錢不夠，又不願意慢下來，那該怎麼辦？**Zuckerberg 的解法，是創造出一種全新的股票。**

重點四｜Class C 無投票權新股：一場為 AI 長期戰爭預鋪的資本工程

4.1 表面上是股票分割，骨子裡是「無上限的印鈔許可證」

面對龐大的 AI 資金缺口，Meta 在這次財報中拋出了一個重磅消息：

預計在 2027 年 1 月，建立全新的 **「Class C 無投票權普通股」**。屆時將向所有現有的 Class A 與 Class B 股東，每持有一股就配發一股 Class C。

如果單看帳面效果，這其實就等同於一次「一拆二（2-for-1）」的股票分割。你手上的持股總價值不會變，原有的投票權也完全不受影響。

既然什麼都沒變，那為什麼要大費周章搞出這個新股種？

答案很簡單：因為 Meta 需要一個全新的長期融資工具。

我們先來看看過去幾年的劇本。以前，Meta 靠著廣告本業產生的龐大自由現金流，可以一邊悠哉地投資新產品，一邊在市場上瘋狂買回自家的股票。

股票回購會減少在外的流通股數、推高每股盈餘（EPS），結果就是股東開心、華爾街開心，股價也跟著開心。

但現在，這套劇本被徹底撕碎了。

你知道 2026 年前三季，Meta 花了多少錢回購股票嗎？**答案是：零。**

對比去年同期，這個數字可是高達 **262.5 億美元**。

從兩百多億直接砍到變成「零」，這筆巨款去哪了？不用懷疑，全部都湧進了資料中心、昂貴的 GPU、模型研發，以及推動 Muse 走向全球的擴張大計裡。

> **「2026 年前三季，Meta 的股票回購金額是零。去年同期是 262.5 億美元。這筆錢沒有消失，只是全部變成了機房裡的算力。」**

4.2 既要華爾街的錢，又要死死握住方向盤

當一個新商業機會的成長速度，已經远远超過公司內部現金流累積的速度時，**「融資能力」本身，就會變成一種決定生死的競爭優勢。**

看看 Meta 現在攤開來的戰線：正在全球大興土木的資料中心、已經白紙黑字簽下的數千億長期租賃與採購合約，還有正在推向全球的 Muse。

這每一項，都是需要持續且龐大資金灌注的無底洞。

這時候，Class C 新股的妙用就出現了。

它的存在，讓 Meta 未來在需要額外銀彈時，可以隨時透過股權市場增資募款、拿股票去收購其他 AI 公司，或是用來支付頂尖 AI 人才的天價股票薪酬。

最關鍵的是，因為 Class C「沒有投票權」，不管發了多少新股，都完全不會稀釋掉Mark Zuckerberg手上的投票權與絕對決策控制權。

有了這個新工具，未來搭配原本的營業現金流與發債借款，Meta 就能依據不同專案的時程與規模，靈活選擇最划算的融資方式。

不過，為了避免市場馬上陷入「股權要被稀釋了」的恐慌，財務長 Susan Li 在法說會上也明確打了預防針：

設立 Class C 是為了增加未來的募資、併購與員工薪酬工具，但**「目前並沒有要宣布任何具體的融資或增發計畫」**。

換句話說，槍已經先擦亮、子彈也上膛了，只是現在還不急著開火。

4.3 為什麼這次跟「元宇宙」完全不同？

這整套資本工程背後的戰略判斷，其實非常清晰。

如果我們回顧 Zuckerberg 過去幾十年的投資決策，從當年的行動廣告轉型、收購 Instagram，到後來硬剛 TikTok 推出 Reels，他已經多次向市場證明，自己有能力提前嗅到下一個技術趨勢，並把龐大的用戶基礎轉化成驚人的商業價值。

而另一邊的 Reality Labs（元宇宙），則展現了他性格中極度固執的另一面：

只要他認定某項技術具有長期戰略價值，他就願意不計代價地持續投入資本，完全不怕承受短期的巨額虧損。

這次對 AI 的梭哈，無疑延續了他一貫的「進攻型風格」，但跟當年賭元宇宙有一個最關鍵的差異：

這次，Meta 不需要從零開始發明一套商業模式。

Meta 手上已經擁有全球最成熟的廣告變現系統，而新推出的 Muse 也開始展現出真實且強勁的用戶需求。

這意味著，現在砸下去的每一分 AI 投資，不僅能立刻改善既有廣告的轉換率、降低內部營運成本，還能同步透過訂閱制、企業級服務與交易佣金，幫公司開拓出全新的營收水源。

它不是在荒地上蓋房子，而是在既有的數十億用戶與商家生態系上，直接疊加一層強大的 AI 變現能力。

這跟市面上那些純粹的 AI 新創公司，從第一天就必須苦哈哈地找用戶、建通路、單純靠燒投資人的錢度日，完全是不同維度的戰爭。

> **「對現有股東而言，真正的問題其實只有一個：這些新投入的資本，能不能創造出高於資本成本的回報？」**

這是一道很純粹的數學題。只要新增投資的報酬率夠高，創造出來的新企業價值足以彌補未來可能發生的股權稀釋，那 Class C 就是一個能加速長期每股價值成長的推進器。

反之，如果砸下去的天價資金換不回對應的利潤，那麼未來的股權稀釋，就會變成全體股東必須共同吞下的苦果。

> **本節一句話總結：**
>
> **發行 Class C 新股加上股票回購歸零，清楚攤開了 Zuckerberg 的優先順序。在 AI Agent 的平台格局完全定型之前，先把所有現金留給算力建設、模型研發與分發優勢，至於討好華爾街的股票回購，以後再說。**

好，現在連最底層的融資工具都準備好了，產品也已經在軌道上狂奔。

那我們終於要來到最後、也是所有投資人最關心的一個問題：**2027 年的 Meta，到底值多少錢？**

重點五｜不猜目標價，反推股價：市場現在押注的是哪一種 Meta？

5.1 最核心的數字

在看長遠的估值之前，我們先來看看眼前的成績單。

Meta 預計第四季營收會落在 730 億到 760 億美元之間，中位數大約是 745 億。拿這個數字去對比去年第四季的 598.9 億美元，年增率高達 24.4%。

這代表公司的核心成長動能依然非常強勁，只比第三季的 26.1% 稍微放緩一點點而已。

如果把眼光放遠到 2027 年，下一波接棒的成長引擎會從哪裡來？

美國銀行分析師 Justin Post 在法說會上就問了這個關鍵問題。財務長 Susan Li 的回答是這樣的。

第一，核心的廣告推薦與變現還有很大的改善空間；

第二，**Muse 的訂閱、交易抽成、企業服務和 API 等新業務，從 2027 年就會開始貢獻收入**，並在接下來幾年逐步放大。

另一個讓人鬆一口氣的好消息是，過去一直被視為錢坑的 Reality Labs，年度虧損預計會從 2026 年的 180 億至 190 億美元，縮小到 2027 年的 150 億美元左右。

這個長期拖累獲利的部門，終於開始逐步把資源讓位給 AI 投資了。

但問題是，2027 年最核心的變數，也就是資本支出（CapEx），現在還是一片空白。 管理層在法說會上只留下一句會繼續「積極投資」，至於具體的數字，要等明年一月的第四季法說會才會正式掀牌。

大家要知道，資本支出只要多出 300 億或少掉 300 億美元，後面攤提的折舊費用就會差上十萬八千里，EPS 也會跟著劇烈震盪。

在這種情況下，如果硬要把目標價算到個位數，算出來的誤差恐怕會比結論本身還要大。再加上現在的自由現金流已經轉為負數，傳統的現金流折現法（DCF）在短期內也很難派上用場。

所以，我們可以思考另一個問題：

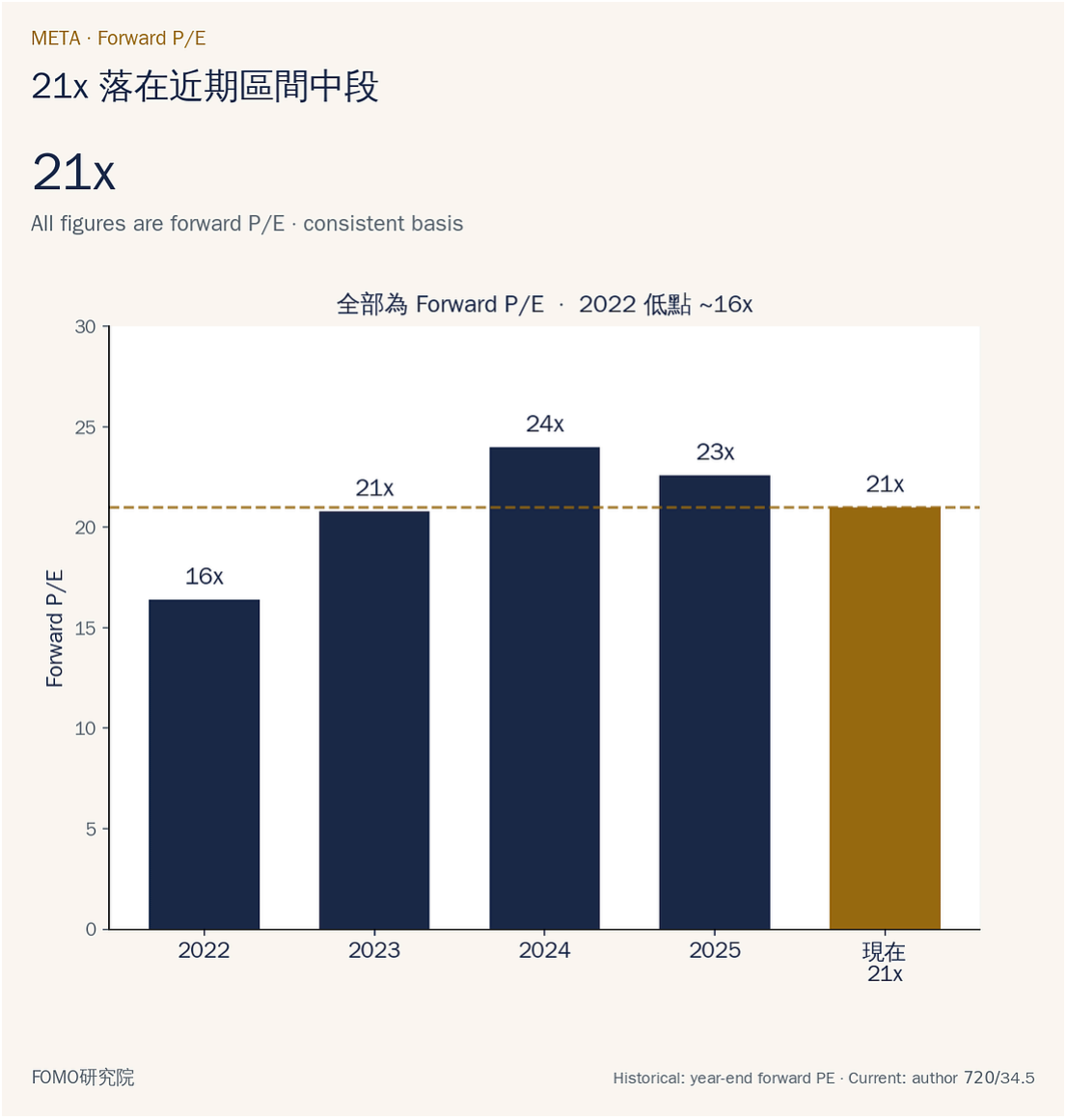
> **「以現在的股價來看，市場已經默默替 Meta 假設了什麼樣的未來？」**

5.2 反推本益比：表面上的 21 倍，與藏在水面下的貓膩

我們直接把股價反過來推算。

財報後股價大約是 720 美元，而華爾街預估 Meta 2027 年的 EPS 大約是 34.5 美元。把 720 除以 34.5，算出來是 21 倍本益比。

這代表市場現在正用 21 倍的本益比，買進一家「預期明年能賺 34.5 美元」的公司。



(註：以股價 720 美元、2026 年正常化 EPS 約 30 美元計算。未來 Class C 配股後股價與 EPS 會同時減半，本益比不受影響。)

但真正的問題來了：華爾街預估的「34.5 美元」這個分母，本身真的靠得住嗎？

如果明年的獲利預估之後被下修，那現在看起來合理的 21 倍本益比，就只是一個便宜的假象。

今年帳面數字是被一次性費用壓低的（包含 Q2 的 24 億法律費與 12 億遣散費，以及 Q3 約 100 億的和解金）。

把這些一次性費用加回來，**今年的「真實獲利（正常化 EPS）」其實已經有 30 美元了。所以明年要賺到 34.5 美元，實際需要的成長率是大約 15%。**

成長 15% 聽起來不難？

但看看 Meta 今年的狀況：全年營收大增 25%，真實獲利卻幾乎原地踏步（從 29.7 美元微幅走到 30 美元）；第三季營收大增 26%，真實獲利卻只成長 2.1%。

簡言之，今年多賺的錢，幾乎全被暴增的成本吃光了。

這代表華爾街做了一個很大膽的假設：明年營收成長會放緩到兩成左右，但獲利成長卻要從「接近零」突然跳升到「15%」。

這只有在「明年成本踩煞車」時才可能發生。那麼，成本真的會降下來嗎？我們把正反兩股力量攤開來看：

幫獲利催油門的四股推力（支持 EPS 上修）：

1. **營收持續超預期：** Q3 營收贏預期 2%，Q4 指引中點也高出 1.2%，明年營收預估大概率會上調。
2. **元宇宙止血：** Reality Labs 虧損縮小，直接省下約 35 億美元的成本空間。
3. **裁員效益發酵：** 今年 5 月裁員約 8,000 人，遣散費今年已認列完畢，明年能完整省下一整年的人事成本。
4. **AI 變便宜了：** 自研模型發威，讓部分工作負載的單位推論成本暴降超過 80%。

扯獲利後腿的四股重力（支持 EPS 下修）：

1. **恐怖的折舊海嘯：** 今年 CapEx 高達約 1,400 億美元，是去年的兩倍。今年買的伺服器與機房，明年要開始承擔完整一年的折舊；況且明年的 CapEx 還不知道要燒多少。
2. **利息的雙重打擊：** 長期負債攀升到約 837 億美元（利息支出增加），同時手頭現金縮小（利息收入減少）。這就是為什麼 Q3 營業利益明明在成長，落到最後的 EPS 卻只成長 2.1%。
3. **庫藏股順風消失：** 過去靠大量回購減少股數、墊高 EPS 的魔法，在自由現金流轉負後，明年恐怕沒了。
4. **華爾街正在認錯：** 財報前 90 天內，分析師已經把今年 EPS 共識從 33 美元砍到 30.8 美元。過去半年，市場是一路追著成本往下砍獲利。

以目前的股數和稅率粗估，**每多出 100 億美元的稅前成本，EPS 就會被吃掉 3.3 美元（直接蒸發共識的一成）。**

只要明年一月公布的 2027 CapEx 指引比預期高，隨之而來的折舊與電費，就會讓獲利明顯下修。

如果明年重演今年的劇本，營收成長兩成、但獲利被成本吃光，那 EPS 最終只會落在 31 美元附近。

> 我的判斷是：明年的營收預估會上修，但 EPS 共識下修的機率遠大於上修。因為營收的好消息，會被折舊、利息和股數三個方向的重力抵銷掉一大半。

這個結論會徹底改變我們看估值的方式。如果明年真實 EPS 只落在 31 到 33 美元，表面上的 21 倍本益比就會失真，**720 美元的股價，實際對應的是 22 到 23 倍的本益比。**

不算極貴，但也不算特別便宜。

5.3 三種未來劇本，市場正在押注哪一個？

決定 Meta 股價的有兩個變數：**Muse 的產品力**決定本益比，**CapEx** 決定獲利。

劇本一：Muse 不如預期，CapEx 照樣大增（悲觀情境）
市場開始懷疑 AI 投資的回報，EPS 約 30 到 31 美元，本益比降到 17 到 19 倍，股價約 510 至 590 美元。

劇本二：Muse 表現好，但 CapEx 繼續上修（基準情境）
產品撐住本益比，成本壓住獲利。EPS 約 31 到 33 美元，本益比 22 到 24 倍，股價約 680 至 790 美元。

劇本三：Muse 放量，CapEx 見頂（樂觀情境）
EPS 超越共識，本益比上看 25 倍以上（戴維斯雙擊），股價 860 美元以上。

現在 720 美元的股價，正好落在劇本二的中間。（順帶一提，用共識的 34.5 美元乘以 21 倍，也剛好是 720 美元。）

> 換句話說，市場已經假設 Muse 會成功，也已經消化了 CapEx 會繼續上修。這代表 Muse 不是免費的選擇權：它不需要大獲成功，但不能失敗。

從這季財報來看，我認為劇本二最有可能：

- **產品讓人放心：** 自研模型推論成本大幅下降，2027 年的變現路徑也很清楚，Muse 不是只會燒錢的空殼。
- **成本依然揪心：** 以 Zuckerberg 對 AI 基礎建設的態度，2027 年 CapEx 繼續上修的機率很高。而且 Muse 越成功，越有理由加碼。

這次和 2022 年最大的不同是，廣告本業仍維持兩成以上的成長。所以我認為市場願意用略高的本益比，包容短期的折舊壓力。

結論： 只要 Muse 不出錯，股價不至於因為 CapEx 大增而崩盤；但真實 EPS 被壓在 31 到 33 美元，股價也很難大漲。

掉到劇本一大約有 20% 到 30% 的下檔，衝上劇本三則需要 CapEx 見頂，這在短期內不太可能發生。

投資 Meta 在 2027 年的核心命題，其實只有一句話：

那些已經砸下去、以及即將砸下去的天文數字資本支出，最終能不能透過廣告效率、Muse 交易與企業服務，換成持續且可預期的每股利潤成長？

如果答案是肯定的，目前的估值仍有空間。如果答案遲遲無法兌現，再好的產品故事也撐不住一個持續燒錢的資產負債表。

這是我們追蹤 Meta 接下來兩到三季，最核心的任務。

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